



arnica butler

corrupting
april

CORRUPTING APRIL

By Arnica Butler

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CHAPTER 1

*Party is almost over
Some of us want to go to a club
That okay with you*

I was sitting in the living room, whiskey in hand, zombified expression plastered to my face, when I read this message from April.

I hadn't meant to get drunk, nor had I meant to spend the entire evening obsessing about what April was doing at her sex siren, nebulously porn-employed or porn-employing childhood friend Lilith's house. I had given her permission to attend the party, telling her I really didn't feel like going. Secretly, I suppose I had hoped that April would not want to go without me, or that she would try harder to drag me along. Looking back on it, I think I had contrived the moment like a trap, hoping in one way that April would sidestep it, and in another way, hoping she would step into it.

"You don't want to come with me?" April had asked, genuinely befuddled.

"Nah," I said. "You've seen one party at Lilith's, you've seen them all."

April had looked at me after I said this, with an expression that made me think she was finally getting wise to me and my twisted mind.

But then, she scratched her head and tossed her hair - a gesture that was faintly reminiscent of something Lilith did all the time (and quietly unsettling, as a result) - before shrugging. "Oh... kay," she had said. She was already typing by the time she asked, her voice dripping with disinterest, "Is it okay if I go without you, then?"

What was it that had made me say "yes?" Or rather, "yeah, sure?" A self-destructive impulse? It certainly wasn't for lack of imagination, or lack of thinking ahead.

I think ahead. I *was* thinking ahead.

So I must have known that April would go to the party and stay late, and that "something" was bound to happen when she did. Had I foreseen the club? Not really, but that was only because Lilith's house parties were *like* a club, only with fewer rules and less driving.

I stared at the wall without responding for a good long while, considering my predicament, which was, no matter what angle I attempted to look at it from, entirely of my own doing.

I was the one with the hotwife fantasy.

I was the one who had gently suggested it to my wife when opportunity knocked, in the form of her childhood friend, the sex siren Lilith.

I was the one who had placed my fingers at April's back all along, pushing her gently toward doing the things I secretly fantasized about her doing.

I had encouraged her to step outside of our marriage vows, with first one man, and then two.

I had agreed to let her make a porno, and if truth be told, I had done it greedily and hungrily.

I had sent her to the party alone, partly so that I could sit here in the living room, aching, playing with the fire of April's possible infidelity.

But what would infidelity be, at this point? April had already become a porn-star, a natural slut, a filthy, juicy sex object hidden beneath her sweet exterior. And I loved her that way, I wanted more of her that way.

But I had become an addict, and I had seen that coming as well: like pornography, and booze, and anything else delicious you sink your teeth into, there was a steady tick of desensitization.

A constant need to dose myself a little more, each time, to get the same high.

So - perhaps because of all of that, perhaps because I was drunk, perhaps both - I finally let my gaze tear from the plain gray wall, and I responded to her text.

sure

just tell me everything

I mulled this over for a moment and then added:

no sex

I typed this right before I - perhaps because of the reasons described above, perhaps because of the booze - summoned an Uber, rose

from my chair, and strolled to the master bedroom to find something worthy of wearing to a club.

I did all of this in a self-inflicted daze. It's the sort of state I put myself into consciously whenever I'm doing something I know I shouldn't really be doing. It relies on momentum, this state: move from one thing to the next, to the next step immediately in front of you, and do not think about anything else beyond that.

"You got an address yet?" the Uber driver asked.

It was only then that I realized I had no idea where they were going. I also noted, with a degree of irritation that I knew logically wasn't warranted, that April hadn't gotten back to me about my last text. Not so much as an "okay." There was no rule between us that she had to, necessarily, and she *had* taken the time to send me a message asking for my go-ahead in the first place.

But it irked me that she hadn't responded.

Irked me, and set me to thinking about all the infinite betrayals that could unfold from there.

I gave the cabbie the name of a club downtown, and sat back, not really believing myself or my actions. But that was only for the briefest moment in time.

Then, I started plotting again.

*

My relationship with Lilith had a somewhat conspiratorial bent to it by then, so it surprised me very little that it was Lilith who I texted to give me the name of the club they had gone to. This was after I had been dropped off at the end of a very long line to a club I only knew existed because of Lilith, and I realized that I could be waiting in line forever only to discover they had never gone there.

where are u?

I wrote "u" because I was standing there next to a lot of very young women and something about writing the whole word out seemed infinitely inappropriate.

It might seem like a dick move, seeking the name of the club from Lilith rather than my wife, especially when you knew, as I did, that Lilith would read my text, smile devilishly, send me the name of the club, and then either forget about me entirely, or keep an eye out for me so that she could watch, and maybe participate, in my self-torture.

Lilith could be counted on for very little: she is like everyone's absolutely worst kind of ex-girlfriend - if she happens to see you and notice you and remember you (all very big *ifs*), she doesn't want to fuck with you, or key your car, or even blow you off. She simply doesn't give a fuck, and has usually forgotten you exist almost as soon as she's been reminded that you do.

I had been trying to figure Lilith out since I met her, what seemed like ages ago in Mexico. April had been friends with her for most of her life, though what, exactly, the definition of "friends" was had never been entirely clear. Lilith had, for whatever reason - again, no one will ever probably know but we all suspect it was a vaguely greasy, sexual reason - been "given" a trip to an all-expenses paid resort in Mexico, and she had wanted April to join her.

"Lilith from high school?" I had asked.

Sweet summer child.

Lilith's full name is Lilith Stephanapolous, and April had rarely mentioned her. They were college friends, had traveled together, I had never seen any pictures of any of this, and so I had constructed a vision of Lilith in my mind based upon her name.

The Lilith of my imagination had been a dour, mealy-faced woman with too much dark, wiry hair, and perhaps the constant nagging of a shadowy mustache above her lip. I mean: Lilith. And she didn't shorten that name. What could you expect?

Not the Lilith of this real world, that's for sure. No matter what you envisioned in your mind when you heard Lilith's name, I feel certain it failed to capture the *real* Lilith: a naturally-platinum-haired, always perfectly tanned, Swedish-looking sex siren, with a pretty face that no one ever got around to looking at because she had an aversion to clothing except when it was utterly illegal to be without it - a requirement she adhered to only in the strictest sense, by donning scraps of semi-transparent fabric that clung to her body and served more as an interesting light show for her curves than anything else.

Once you met Lilith, who poured herself from chair to chair like an expensive champagne and stalked from place to place like a fishing trawler - stunning and then dragging countless hapless men behind her by the eyeballs - you would engage, as I did, in musing about what it was that Lilith *did*. For a living, during the day.

You might, at first, think that Lilith didn't do anything. You might think this after watching her for a few nights, walking around, breezily accepting all the things that men (and often women) purchased for her, never standing in line, or waiting for bartenders, or paying for anything herself, like the rest of us mere mortals. But then you might, as I did, discover that Lilith lives alone and not with a sugar daddy as you might have expected, but in a huge house filled with expensive things in a very expensive part of town. Lilith is the sort of person who puts saunas that cost as much as your house in her back yard, overnight, and without a trace of dust sprinkled upon her landscaping - which I can tell you from experience, is the sort of contracting only really, disgustingly huge amounts of money can buy.

You might attempt, as I did, to extract this information from Lilith through the time-tested art of asking questions.

"What is it you do, exactly, Lilith?"

Lilith smiles wryly, speechlessly, or magically diverts the conversation in a way that makes you unaware that she has done it until several minutes later, when it is too late to go back. Perhaps *that* is her line of work: smiling, changing the subject, making people feel stupid for having asked her a question, being some kind of magician or hypnotist, or expert in Jedi mind-tricks.

Whatever it is that Lilith does, it has to do with sex, and she does it well. I was convinced for a period of time that Lilith herself was the *product* - perhaps a porn star, or an escort. High-end, undoubtedly, for Lilith reeks of exclusivity and luxury.

But certain events made me doubt this assumption. Lilith was some kind of puppet-master madame, though to what, exactly, I did not know. I knew only that whatever Lilith did, she did it as legally as possible, further confounding me.

Beyond this vague outline, Lilith was a mystery. April wasn't any help, either. April dismissed questions about Lilith's occupation with a wave

of her hand or a shrug of her shoulders, effusing a naiveté I had started to doubt truly existed.

It was Lilith who had gently nudged both me and April into our current arrangement. Perhaps it would be better to describe that as sweeping us up in it. But to say that Lilith was like a storm was incorrect: she was calm, and calculating, and infuriatingly blasé. The storms she kicked up took place outside of this inner circle of Lilith-ness, leaving one to wonder if Lilith had ever really been there at all, if she had ever really had anything to do with anything.

I waited in line at Arcade, a club Lilith had taken us to months before. I doubted that the club could have remained hot enough for Lilith for so long, but if they were in there, I didn't want to lose my place in line. The girls in front of me were smoking, and the scent set off a pang in my chest that had nothing to do with nicotine (I had quit ages ago), and everything to do with nostalgia.

They smiled at me and asked me if the smoke was bothering me, in that breezy tone that twenty-somethings use when they say something: asking a question, the answer of which they don't give a shit about.

I shook my head, and I must have done it with enough disinterest to pique theirs, because they suddenly found me interesting and exchanged a "look."

My phone buzzed in my pocket and I took it out, unable to enjoy my victory moment of having captured what my buddy Sebo calls "The Man of Mystery Appeal."

"I go in, I try to look like I'm there to assassinate someone and all these chicks are getting in the way of my line of sight. Works every time. You do that, Thomas, the ladies will eat it up."

It's Sebo's contention that because I'm so extraordinarily average looking, I will give off some kind of Bruce Willis appeal. Perhaps he was right. I didn't have time to give it much thought, because the only thing on my mind at the moment was that my wife was at a club with Lilith's stable of men, and I needed the name of that club so I could "show up" there.

Zaouk Klub

A quick Google search revealed nothing, which meant nothing, because lately the coolest places were only cool because no one could

stumble upon them on the internet.

Surprisingly, my phone buzzed again shortly, with another message from Lilith.

what are you wearing?

I imagined Lilith, wherever she was, sitting on the lap of her latest boy toy, or interrupting the poor sod who had just purchased her a \$50 drink, typing away with her particular blend of disinterest and impishness. What might be going through her mind was unfathomable: the only thing I could know for sure was that Lilith was not going to mention any of this to April. Not because she cared, one way or the other, what I was up to, but because Lilith enjoyed moving pieces around on a board and then watching, or perhaps not watching, what happened because of it.

"Hey," I said, to the ladies in front of me, who were attentive with a suddenness I would only think about later.

"Can I get a cigarette?" I asked, scarcely thinking before I did. I had meant to ask them to take a picture of me, because I was at the fringes of the selfie-taking generation and it had not been my first thought.

"Sure," one of them bubbled. She lit it for me. I grunted a thanks and then held my phone up to take a picture of my clothing, cigarette dangling from my lips.

"Hot date?" the other asked.

Sometimes I find myself being a cool guy, and it's the sort of thing I feel like I'm sitting back and watching from the outside. Cool Thomas is more like a rhythm than a man, and you have to just let him do his own thing. I took the cigarette out of my mouth and blew a stream of smoke to the side the way Sebo does - a habit I'd acquired from him when we first started smoking. "More like a job," I said, seriously but jokingly.

What did I mean by that? I didn't know and neither did they, but they loved it.

"You look good," one of them assured me.

I held the phone in my hand, waiting for Lilith. "We'll see."

*44th and Stuart
I'll put you on the list*

44th and Stuart was an industrial part of town bordering on gangland. It was the kind of place no one ever went to unless they worked there, and only in daylight. Regular Thomas, when sober, might have double-checked this address or bailed on this plan, but drunk, Cool Thomas was all puffed up by the fact that his outfit passed muster with Lilith so that he could go - what? spy on? stalk? - his wife at a secret club.

I dropped my phone back into my pocket. "Gotta run," I said. "Thanks for the smoke."

They giggled and asked if they could go with me, but I ignored them and stepped out of line at the illustrious *Arcade*, walking straight into traffic like I didn't give a damn and stepping into someone's cab just as they got out.

Later, I would remark to myself that I needed to tell Sebo thanks for the advice. It was too late for me to do anything with it, but the ladies really did seem to love that act.

*

Apparently someone had made a club in an old transfer station, and apparently it wasn't as secret as its absence from the internet made it seem like.

"Zaouk Klub," the driver said, unfazed, after I gave him the address.

He didn't say anything else for the next ten minutes, as we left the gentrified city behind and skirted the implicitly no-go neighborhoods to cut back into the industrial area known as The Mills.

"Hard to get in," he said, as if he were only adding on to his previous comment.

"Got it covered," Cool Thomas said, and he met my eyes in the rear-view mirror.

I suppose I passed muster with the guy, which seemed like another notch under my belt when I thought about it later. I tipped him a twenty.

The line to the club seemed to be hundreds long, and I might have balked at that if I hadn't been riding so high on whiskey and my baller-Bruce-Willis act. I wasn't about to let the Russian cabbie, whose grudging approval I had just won, think I didn't have the *cojones*, so I strolled confidently up to the front door.

I almost lost heart, and was pretty sure I was headed to an embarrassing scene, about halfway up the enormous set of steps. The bouncers were overweight, bleary-eyed black guys who seemed half-asleep, but I'd witnessed enough bar fights and people getting tossed from clubs to know that this breed of bouncer was *not* sleepy, moved pretty fast when required, and was not taking any amount of shit from anyone – certainly not anyone like me.

I talk myself out of a lot of shit, but I'm not too great at talking myself *in*.

Still, I kept my hands in my pockets and strolled right up like I owned the place, because I was driven, at this point, by something divorced entirely from reality. I had a little bit of youthful bravado, that murky sexual drive that I had lost when I was twenty-something, propelling me forward.

I was thinking how much like a drug that was, getting ready to get the classic wave-off - a tisk, the way black guys do it, when they suck something through their teeth and shake their head minutely. "Man," they were going to say. "Get on outta here."

Oh well. I was riding high until then. The front of the line didn't even know I didn't belong there. They were looking at me with jealousy.

I was still trying to stay a few feet ahead of my trajectory, thinking what I was going to say, when the sleepier of the two shifted, his eyes moving toward me without his head turning, a scowl developing on his lips.

His eyes moved back to the man opposite him, and he lifted a finger and said something I couldn't hear. This activated the other man, who seemed annoyed.

"You Thomas?" he said.

He was lifting the velvet-covered chain blocking the entrance (un-ironically, like it was 1987).

My hands were still in my pockets and I just kept right on walking. I moved my head a little - that's a nod in a neighborhood like the one I grew up in, the kind of movement you can deny the meaning of later.

And in I went.

*

Even in a venue as big as Zaouk Klub, and as full of beautiful people as it was, spotting Lilith was no difficult task. Partly I suspect this is

because Lilith sort of warps time and space around her: men move *away* from her first, I suspect because they don't believe she is real. Then they recover, and get pulled toward her, leaving an imprint of the gravitational wave, made flesh, in her wake.

Lilith was doing her usual: being charming and also completely aloof, and however you imagine that is probably close to what it looks like in real life. She was at a bar, deep in the center of the club, which had been built in, on, and around whatever electrical equipment had been abandoned there. With all the club lights flashing and people dancing, the effect was one of apocalyptic gaiety.

The entrance let people in on the second floor, so I was looking down at the pit of dancers and the heart of the party. I moved my eyes from Lilith to the people who surrounded her, and didn't recognize anyone. Specifically, I didn't see Jonny, or Jonny's friend Rog, or the guy known only to me as Reggie, who had been in the porno April had been commissioned to make.

And I didn't see April.

I walked along the balcony of the second floor, which encircled the dance floor below. I was intending to surveil from up there, making passes around and around, until I found what I was looking for, but I ran into a wall at the end behind the DJ. So I wedged my way into a tiny space between the barrier and the people leaning against the balcony, and elbowed my way in until I had a little perch.

It was a good vantage point, because the lights were shining down at the crowd, and so no one would be able to make out that it was me crammed into the corner up here. For a while, it was just a blurry mess of attractive people.

I thought about texting Lilith and asking her where April was, but because I knew Lilith the way that I knew her - which is to say, mostly suspicions and hunches, with a dash of observational data thrown in - I suspected she would ignore my text, or do something to fuck with me. I didn't want to give her the satisfaction of knowing that I was any more desperate than I already seemed to her. I knew Lilith wouldn't text *me*: she had gotten me into the club, but I knew she had only done that out of mischief. She had probably forgotten all about me after that.

My inebriation was wearing off, and I was getting crabbiest with every second that I scanned the crowd and couldn't find April. I wished I

had a drink, but people were, amazingly, piling into the club at this late hour, and I would never get my vantage point back if I left my post then.

Just as I was beginning to lose hope entirely in my plan - which, now that I was sober, seemed less like a plan and more like a violation of trust with April - she appeared.

Actually, she had appeared moments before that, it just took me a while to recognize her.

When she had left the house, April had been wearing a very sexy black dress. A standard, opaque, tight-fitting black dress. It was sexy on her: since she had been venturing into these new situations, she had taken her wardrobe along for the ride, but only when she went out to do something with Lilith. Her necklines plunged a little further, and her skirts were tighter and shorter, showing off her lean figure and the gentle curves in all the right places.

This dress was... well, not *that* dress.

It was black, but seemed to have come from the factory where all of Lilith's clothing was made, where some strange fabric existed that was both transparent and not, depending on which way the light moved. In shadows, the material looked like it was nothing more than a single layer of thin threads woven into a fine mesh and, with light on it, the dress became silvery and impenetrable to the human eye. A strip of fabric just below April's bottom held it close to her legs, but the rest was sort of loose-fitting and draped off her shoulders from two tiny spaghetti straps. The whole thing shifted constantly, and looked like it would slip off her body at any moment.

Even from where I was, I could see that her skin was unusually shiny, and after staring for a while, I realized that it must be sweat. She looked a little like she had been rubbed down in baby oil.

Her face was flushed, and her hair was loose, silky smooth, and unruffled - because April has that sort of hair - but it had the volume, slightly inflated about her head, that it normally acquires only if she is exercising.

The makeup was another story, and probably the main reason I wasn't sure it was her immediately: dark powder framed her eyes, and bright red stained her lips.

She looked hot, but in a way that April almost never looks hot: she looked ever-so-slightly trashy. Kind of like Lilith. Expensively trashy. The

sort of trashy you have to work at, and pay for.

She was led to Lilith by a dark-skinned guy in sunglasses, who held her hand up above her head and pushed her through the crowd from behind. His body was against her back the whole way, and April's mouth was open in a wide smile. They were obviously yelling something at each other over the music.

I had watched this without really keying in that it was April until the man released her hand and leaned in over the bar, face turned the other way, to talk to someone down a few places from him. April put her hand on Lilith's shoulder and started talking very close to her ear. Whatever she said seemed to make Lilith smile, though I couldn't really tell.

The man who had escorted her turned around and stood behind April, bringing a glass over his head to rest it in her hands. He was a foot and a half taller than her, so the top of her head didn't even make it to his chin - and I suspected this was distorted by the heels April was almost certainly wearing.

I stared as April and the man merged together, and I had to wipe sweat from my eyes to squint and confirm what seemed to be obvious: April was leaning back against this dark stranger with sunglasses, like it was the most natural thing in the world, and they had been a couple forever.

The memory of watching this scene remains in my head like a montage. It's difficult to describe it unfolding linearly, though it must have. April leaned against him, and they were moving a little to the music. Her face seemed vacant, something I mistook for a trick of the light at the time: her eyes seemed too dark, and her features a little too happy and yet also lifeless. I was a long way off, but this was the kind of thing I could still see from where I was. The man was talking to Lilith, leaning toward her occasionally, and April was just standing there, sinking into his chest.

At some point, April lifted her right arm, and reached up for this guy, folding her arm at the elbow and dropping her hand to his shoulder. She was smiling, saying something that he leaned down close to her mouth to hear.

My cock had already been slowly burgeoning to life, but this gesture shot me to full-on erection with a painful thud. It seemed as though my vision had suddenly become more hawk-like, like I could see in better detail and I was closer up, as he spoke in April's ear.

At the same time, he lifted his hand and drew it down the underside of April's arm, which made her mouth fall open. She dropped her arm with his hand as he kept going: right down her arm to her ribcage. His other hand worked its way to April's hair and pulled it around to one side, baring her left shoulder. And then he put his left hand back up to her shoulder, and began to stretch his large, brown hand to follow the path of the skimpy strap, down to the low collar of the dress, along its border, over her breast, and then back again.

April smiled and shivered, staring vacantly at Lilith, who was amused by this entire scene if I was reading her correctly.

This went on for a long time: the man's dark hand making slow, leisurely passes over April's arms, along the hems of her dress, gently sweeping over her smooth, shiny skin while April let him do it.

It wasn't X-rated, but it wasn't PG, either.

What I couldn't understand about it was why it was taking so long. The three of them didn't seem to be talking anymore, but they were facing each other as if they were, and they weren't dancing, and April was just letting this guy run his fingers all over her - but he wasn't doing much else.

"You lookin to buy?" someone shouted next to me. I kept staring, not realizing he was talking to me. It was only when I overheard someone else's voice say something like, "Looks like he's already in," that I started to put it all together.

April was high, and probably, from the looks of this club, on Ecstasy. Or whatever the kids were calling it these days.

I glanced to my left, and caught a glimpse of the pills being exchanged, and the whole club, and everyone in it, transformed suddenly, as if a veil had been pulled back. Everyone was a little high on something.

Everyone but me.

My eyes flew back to April, and I had trouble finding her for a moment of sheer panic. But she hadn't moved: she was still in the same place, leaning against the tall dark stranger, who I was starting to suspect might have been "Reggie" from the porno, still staring vacantly, a pleasant smile on her lips, as Reggie ran his fingers down her arm, along her chest, over her throat, in ever-more intimate forays. His fingers slipped under the material of the dress a little further with each pass.

A tattooed arm broke up the light reflecting off of Lilith's pussy-pink dress - she had really outdone herself in a nearly transparent dress with

a fur trim at the bottom that looked straight out of the pages of Playboy (all she needed were the ears) - and I recognized the coiled, raw strength of Jonny's bicep.

The four of them seemed very cozy as they bunched closer together. Hands were everywhere, as naturally as though they had an orgy every morning and were all best friends. Nothing *obscene*, but perhaps that's what I found so obscene about it: my fantasy consisted of April sucking cock or taking it hard in some sordid double penetration scenario with these guys, not this kind of chummy familiarity.

And I wasn't even sure, now that I had watched for so long, that the guy behind April *was* Reggie, which meant he might be someone else.

Jealousy had me by the throat and the balls at this point: my stomach was twisting, cold and dark, inside my gut, and blinding pain gripped my balls. My chest felt like someone was sitting on it. It was a terrible, terrific high.

At one point, I wasn't sure if I was going to puke right over the edge or not.

Jonny leaned in toward April and blocked her face from my view. He started doing the same thing to her: moving his fingers along her arm, over her wet skin. April's body seemed to be melting into the chest of the big black guy propping her up.

Jonny stepped away and I saw April smiling, then unsteadily pushing herself away from the guy and leaning toward Lilith to say something.

Jonny moved in on her and put his mouth close to her shoulder, maybe even biting into her flesh, which made April stop talking for a moment. Jonny started talking to the guy, beckoning him toward his face with an upraised hand. The guy had to lean in to hear what Jonny was saying. Jonny lowered his hand via April's back, the back of his hand against her skin as he dragged it along her spine.

The world lurched all around me. The scene had the feel of the first time April had stepped out of our marriage, in a back room of a party at Lilith's house.

Except I had been there, then.

I stared at my wife as the two guys plotted behind her. I could see it all unfolding now: April was clearly on something, and they were going to just keep stroking her arms and her back, until she purred like a cat, and

then they were going to gently nudge her out of this club and have their way with her.

It was the sort of scene I had suspected had taken place while April was shooting her porno: after-hours, after-shoots, when they were no longer on the clock, surely something had taken place among them. How could it not?

And was it unfair of me to expect that April wouldn't have developed some sense of intimacy with her fellow porn actors?

It burned, whether it was or it wasn't.

They began to move, without Lilith, slowly edging away from the bar and into the crowded dance floor. April was still leaning against the big black man, and Jonny was walking forward, facing her, hands somewhere on her body that I couldn't see because of all the people.

I was curious about Lilith, but I didn't dare lose sight of April. They were sinking into the shadows on the dance floor, where the lights were a dark blue and red, and I could only see snippets of what they were doing, frozen in moments by a strobe light that began to flash frustratingly slowly.

April with her head tipped back, her mouth open, laughing. April serious, sandwiched between them. April dancing. April with Jonny's fingertips between her lips. The broad back of the black guy as they turned around. April with both hands over her head, loosely draped around his neck, her face tipped to the side, eyes closed.

Dozens of flashes of these scenes, and then, nestled in the middle of them, the one that burned right through my retina and erased everything but itself from my mind for tens of minutes:

A parting of the crowd, a temporary gap between the bodies, right as the blaring strobe soaked the scene. A black hand between April's legs, under her skirt, which was bunched just at the lowest part of her hips. April's mouth open, like she was panting, nearing a climax, her eyes staring vacantly as her attention was sucked entirely to her melting core.

It sank into my brain as feelings first, and I made sense of it slowly, until finally, finally, I realized what it was.

That guy was finger-fucking April right there on the dance floor, Jonny somehow assisting.

The crowd dissolved into a blur of colors and lights, and I lost sight of them as the realization of what was happening tore through me like

a tsunami, filling my head with a molten jealousy that I couldn't see or think my way through. Somewhere below, I could feel my heart thudding in my chest, each beat a cold-hot squeeze of pain.

*

The revelers on the balcony eventually pushed me out of my post. I had no sense of how long I was standing there, but the group to my left grew in size, and eventually I was no longer leaning on the balcony but instead walking backwards, not looking where I was going, and then collapsing on a tatty couch where two girls were involved in animated conversation.

The woman closest to me turned and scanned me from head to foot. "You okay?"

She asked this question with the unflappable calm and cardboard emotion of a first responder, a serrated edge of annoyance at the edges of her voice. I waved my hand at her, and she took a deep breath. "You having a heart attack? Can you say something so I know you're alright?"

"He's just drunk," her friend assured her.

She stared at me icily. I could see I wasn't getting rid of her until I satisfied her first aid checklist.

"I'm fine," I said.

"Lie down if you feel faint," she told me, and scooted over so if that happened, she could get out of the way.

I took out my phone with some intention in my mind, but once I had it in my hand it escaped me. Had I been thinking of texting April? Calling a cab? Texting Lilith? Jonny? And what would I have said, if I had?

I walked like a zombie to the bar on the second floor and ordered myself a drink, staring at my phone the way dogs stare at a closed door their master just disappeared behind. I could have gone to look for April, but something inside of me didn't want her to see me here.

I typed a message for April into my phone. I erased it and re-worded it, hesitated, put my phone away with the final version still on the screen, ready to be sent.

You having fun?

I sipped my whiskey and looked at myself in the mirror. I was a married man, a happily married man in my thirties, and I was composing and hesitating over text messages like a forlorn sixteen-year-old. Playing games, as if I was dating this woman, as if she didn't know me and I didn't know her.

A thought flickered somewhere in the back of my mind: this was what I liked about all of this. The not knowing - it was the elixir that burned whenever jealousy dumped itself into my veins.

It was against my better judgment, and I regretted sending it the moment I did, but such is modern life: icy regret after tapping an icon shaped like a paper airplane. I pulled my phone out and let my thumb hover over the screen. A bartender watched me while toweling a glass, sure that he knew the motives behind my pause, the desire to send and not to send. He looked, frankly, relieved that it wasn't his problem.

I bought another drink and tipped him huge, before walking, half in a daze, toward the balcony, where I managed to look manic enough that people got out of my way and gave me a spot.

I found Lilith again in the crowd. She had drifted, like a lily-pad, her white-blond hair and crazy reflective dress glowing with the colors of the dance floor and turning her into a beacon. She was standing, holding a drink, involved in a discussion with a man. It looked more like business than fun, but with Lilith it could have been anything.

I moved my eyes out in circles, searching for my wife. I had my hand on my phone and I knew I hadn't received anything back from April, but I checked it anyway.

And then, Lilith was lifting her hand and waving at someone, reaching out into the dark patch next to her (for the light seemed to follow Lilith everywhere, as if she were on a stage).

And there was April, phone in hand, face still wearing a strange expression, eyes larger than life.

Lilith put her hand on April's arm and ran her fingers over it, much as the black guy had done. April swayed, her eyes heavy and falling closed, a bit like a friendly cat purring when you pet it.

Then Lilith was taking the phone from her hand and looking at it briefly. April's head was moving in a side-to-side motion while she talked.

Whatever Lilith saw, she didn't think much of it. She dropped April's phone into a bag and then handed the bag to April. The lights shifted, and all I could see was her bright platinum hair. When they came back to the place where April had been standing, Lilith was back into the conversation with her male friend, and April was holding her phone in two hands, looking at it forlornly, being jostled by the people around her.

A long time passed like that, enough time for me to realize that April, like me, was typing and retyping a message. Playing games, telling me some kind of half-truth probably. I knew I couldn't be angry about that - it was, after all, the essence of what I'd just done. I liked it, maybe a little. The knife twisting in my stomach, thinking of what she would eventually write to me.

But the message didn't come. The big man came up behind her and stood right behind her, lowering a water bottle over her head. April abandoned her phone, tipped her head back to smile up at him, and took the water in both hands.

I watched the scene morph: April chugging water, then slowly turning toward him, until he could pull her in close to him and push a strand of her hair back from her face. His lips were moving, and I could almost hear in my mind, with a Barry White voice - I had no idea what he was saying, but it was easy enough to know the gist of it. We've all tried it at some point. A hot, intoxicated girl who let you finger-fuck her on the dance floor, still high, craving physical touch. *Come on, baby, let's get you out of here and I'll rock your world.*

His fingers made their way to her back, dancing over her shoulder blades, moving down to her ass. April was swaying, serious-faced, then suddenly smiling. He had to lean over to say things next to her ear. I was too far away to see it clearly, but when I remember that scene, it is as though I had a telescope, and could see the air between his big lips and her delicate earlobe, and see every pinprick where her skin had turned to goosebumps with the caress of his breath.

His arm went around her, and he leaned to talk to the guy Lilith was still chatting with. It was the final scene of a successful seduction: *don't wait for me, I'm taking this hot girl home.*

But just as they had begun to move, and April was being pulled along, an expression of worry plastered onto the vacant features that ecstasy

had conferred on her, Lilith - Lilith! - reached out and put her arm around April, dislodging the black guy's arm.

She pulled April close to her, and then continued talking to the first man, with the same business-like expression. Not missing a beat, she took April's phone out, turned it on, chatted continuously as her fingers swept over the screen, and then dropped it into her own bag. She waved her hand at the bar and sent the big guy away.

Once he was gone, Lilith faced April and took the phone out of the bag, putting it into her hand.

At that exact moment, I looked down at my own phone, which was buzzing.

*Lilith here. A's about to go home with a guy. I know
him. He's cool
You cool?
She's on MDMA
My bad
;)*

How about them apples.

April was taking the phone from Lilith, staring at it. Lilith returned her attention to the guy she was talking to. I held my phone in front of me, staring, fingers moving over the screen, wondering what I should say. My eyes were darting back and forth between April and my phone. April tucking some hair behind her ear, trying to make sense of what Lilith had done. Me, trying to make sense of what Lilith had done.

Maybe Lilith was such a mystery to me because whenever she did something like this, which required a whole lot of careful analysis, I was always in a state like the one I was in now: no blood in my brain to allow it to process anything.

Was I cool with April going home with this guy? On the basis of Lilith's recommendation that "he's cool?"

What did that even mean, in Lilith's world? Not a serial killer? Didn't care about her being married? Free of STDs? Not looking for a long-term relationship? Had a huge dick?

Who could know?

And what did I want? Did I want to watch April leave with him, and feel the hole it punched through my chest for hours while I sat alone in this club, before going home to hope my wife would tell me the details of the wild sex she had that night, later when she returned in the morning?

Did I want her to lie?

And what the fuck was *Lilith* doing? It was hard to believe someone as reckless and crazy as Lilith was actually worried about me or April's marital issues, and yet what other motivation could she have for sending that message?

And yet, she looked wholly unconcerned. Was she just trying to clear her own conscience, keep me from blowing up at her?

What?

It was maddening.

I waited for April, to see if she would write something after Lilith's message. She had a drink in her hand now, and her suitor was standing behind her possessively.

Jonny appeared behind her, out of nowhere, and put his lips on her shoulder in a kiss that was awfully, angeringly, romantic. April turned sharply and then smiled at him. She was still holding the phone like it was an injured bird she didn't know what to do with, but I could see that she was so high she couldn't retain a thought for too long. She was getting distracted... any minute now she would forget that the message had been sent, she would make her decision... she would disappear with the "cool" random stranger.

I willed myself to do something - anything - to take part in this unfolding saga. If I didn't, I'd get what I deserved. If I did, I was going to get caught being a lurking, peeping Tom, who was violating the trust we had in each other. I wanted her to go home with him, I could feel it in my bones. The excitement of it was climbing up my body, like a wild animal with a fierce grip scaling a tree, squeezing me painfully each time it dug into my flesh.

I lifted my thumb to type something just as a shoving match broke out right behind me.

And there was no longer anything I could do about any of it, because my phone tipped, and I watched it as the front end teetered in my loose grip. Just sat there and watched it, until it was nothing more than an

intermittent gleam in the air, falling, falling, and thankfully disappearing into the black maw of the floor, without hitting anybody's head.

*

I found it, placed on a low wall separating a hallway to the bathrooms, where some kind person had scooped it from the floor and left it for the unfortunate sod who had dropped it. This was long after the club started clearing out after last call. I'd have thought it was a sign of Good Samaritan-ship, except that the screen was obliterated and there was no re-sale value in the phone itself. My SIM card was still in there, which I thought was nice, at least.

I had gone down to the dance floor and looked for it, but abandoned hope after just a few seconds: people didn't care what I was doing or what I was looking for, and the more I talked to people the more I realized that fully 90% of the people in this club were high on all kinds of shit. It was only then that I noticed the music, which was terrible, but I suppose had quite an appeal if you had ingested whatever these guys were on.

I made my way through the crowded floor to where I thought Lilith had been. She was gone, and a frantic search around me revealed that she, and her platinum hair, had probably left the building. April and the tall guy were also gone.

I stood, unmoving, and utterly unnoticed, adrift in the dancing, stoned-out crowd, totally unsure of what to do next. I couldn't even get an Uber home without my phone. I wouldn't know for days what April had written back to me, if anything. Perhaps she had taken my silence for an implicit green light.

My heart leaped when I saw Jonny walk by. He didn't see me, and he just kept going. He obviously had somewhere to be, a smug smile on his lips. I followed him with my eyes, and then pushed gently through the crowd behind him, but I lost him, and the only thing in the direction he had gone was a one-way exit with a large sign advising patrons they could not get back in that way if they left.

Last call.

I wandered aimlessly back to where my phone had fallen.

And then, some indefinable kind of hope in my heart, I turned and scanned the emptying club one more time.

But April, and Jonny, and Lilith, and the big black man seemed to have all gone.

I didn't know where to, or if they went all together.

And I had no way of finding out.

So I went out the door to begin the difficult task of trying to get home from The Mills without a phone.

CHAPTER 2

"*Hah*," she said, when she looked up and saw me. It was not an expression of surprise, or any other easy-to-identify human emotion. It sounded a little bit like she had found some dish towels on sale at Target.

And then she scooted over, grinning. She could have been smiling about me, or about something to do with the gentleman in the seat next to her. As she moved, her pink dress clung to her ass and rode up her leg, and if she had underwear on, it was not readily apparent.

"This is Thomas," she told the guy next to her, dropping her hand on his knee.

"I lost my phone," I told them, because it felt like something needed to be said about why I was climbing into a cab with them unexpectedly, and I didn't feel like telling the actual story.

It was clearly not a piece of information they cared about.

Lilith gave the address of her house to the cab driver and turned to look at me archly, her chin lifted and her eyes full of a devious mirth.

And then, perhaps after waiting to see what *I* would do, like if I would explain why I was here, or how long I had been here, or why I hadn't just come over to talk to her or April, or ask where April was, she settled into the middle seat and leaned back, closing her eyes.

"I am so *sleepy*," she said.

Her hand was busy, running delicately along the seam of her friend's pants.

Don't get me wrong, I wanted to know who this guy was. I wanted to know where my wife was, and if she was also going back to Lilith's place, or somewhere else. I wanted to know why Lilith was so *infuriating*, because it was just now rising to the forefront of my mind that fucking Lilith had known I was coming all along, and she had not bothered to look for me, and still didn't seem to care that I was here.

I wanted to know what Lilith's *fucking deal* was. But asking her was always pointless.

More than that, I wanted to know where my wife was.

"You know where April went?"

Lilith opened her eyes slowly, stretching her legs out, like she was waking up from a really peaceful nap. "She went home with Chaz," she

said, simply. Then she grinned at me, and still looking at me, she told the guy whose cock her fingers were gently tracing through his pants. "April is Thomas's wife."

I couldn't help it; my eyes dropped to take in the voyage of Lilith's fingers over that guy's cock. The air in the cab seemed to crackle as she saw it, and her eyes glittered when I hastily jerked my gaze back up to her face.

"You want to come back with us, Thomas? Or are you going home?" she purred.

"I... home," I managed to say. I faced forward, staring at the back of the seat in front of me. Lilith's bare thigh was dangerously close to my leg. I was chilled: I had gotten sweaty in the club and the cabbie was mysteriously running cold air through the cabin. I stifled a shiver that crept up my spine.

"Actually," Lilith hummed, some time later, "I'm glad I ran into you. I have something I need to talk to you about."

It took me a few seconds to realize that Lilith was talking to me. Entranced by her voice, her filmy, transparent dress and her shining skin, my head rotated toward her, no longer controlled by my mind. "Oh-yeah?" I said, using my fake-jovial voice, the one I used to start, and then extract myself from, fights in my twenties.

Lilith was amused by this. Her hand was still wandering around the contours of her "friend's" lap. "It's about Greg," she told me. She knew I wouldn't know who she was talking about, and she was enjoying letting me squirm with all the possibilities while her companion nuzzled her ear. "That's the guy who paid for the video. Mr. *Smith*."

I faced the front again and nodded. Of course she had something to tell me about that. Now. In the back of a cab, sitting next to some guy she was evidently hooking up with.

A parallel line of thought was treading along in my brain. This guy was older, not particularly great-looking, and had the same semi-moronic demeanor as Mike, the perpetually blasé, perpetually high character she had taken to Mexico with her.

"You're preoccupied," Lilith said dismissively, reaching up to put a hand on the man's chin and whisper something to him.

She had scooted over toward me, both hands on either side of her body, within moments.

She crossed her arms over her crossed legs at the forearms and leaned in to chat with me, her voice slippery with excitement, the kind of breathy, feckless excitement wobbling in it that made it impossible for me to not be drawn into whatever she was about to say, no matter what I was "preoccupied" with.

"He has..." she told me, her voice almost pulsating in the air, "another proposition for April. I think you're going to like it." Her eyes shot to the rear-view mirror, and then back. "I told April about it, but she seems like she might not remember the details."

"Who is this *guy*," I said loudly, "that she went home with?"

My voice revealed my lack of composure in all its fine, gritty detail. Lilith's text (*my bad ;)*) percolated up through my thoughts, and anger at her nonchalance was brought to a simmer by the thought of it. Fucking Lilith, she was too much.

"Chaz?" Lilith asked, innocently, a frown of disdain forming on her lips. "He's cool, I told you." She smiled sweetly.

"April's *high*," I told-asked her.

Lilith's lips were slightly parted, smiling. Her tongue flicked inside of her mouth, and she emitted a small, absolutely infuriating click.

"You want me to take Urbana or Federal?" the cab driver practically screamed, out of nowhere.

"I'll talk to you about it later, Thomas," Lilith said to me, and then leaned forward, putting her arms on the cabbie's seat. Her dress was practically falling off her by then - nothing new or surprising for Lilith, but disconcerting, somehow, nonetheless. She paused, scanning something - perhaps the smell of discomfort and fear and sexual excitement that must have been sweating off the cabbie at that point. "Urbana is faster, right?" she slurred sexily next to his ear.

She poured herself back into the back of the car and smiled at me. "If April doesn't have the details, give me a call."

She let me sit with this, and I stared, disbelieving entirely that this was an actual scene from my actual life, at the headrest in front of me for a few beats without saying anything. Lilith was the kind of person who would toss you around like a ball of yarn if you let her, and while there wasn't much I could do about that, I could at least not jerk myself around any extra.

"I think you're going to like it," she purred, just before the cab rolled to a stop. I looked over at her, she gave me one final, inviting up-and-down glance, then smiled as if she had just heard a very funny joke for the millionth time and already knew the punchline. Her liquid, shiny, barely-clad body moved languidly out of the cab.

"That's a hot shirt, by the way," she said, but she was facing another direction and so I had no idea if she meant it for me.

I gave the cabbie my address.

Lilith, naturally, had not paid him, so I stared viciously at the meter as it ticked up over \$100 before we even left her neighborhood.

CHAPTER 3

My head was ringing, something I only noticed when I closed the door behind me and stood in the darkness by myself. Silence becomes loud in the dark, and it wrapped itself around me.

I was drunk, I told myself.

April was not home.

I fished my broken phone out and pressed all sorts of buttons on it uselessly, before giving up.

April was not home. April was somewhere, with some guy named Chaz, and she was high on a drug that made almost anyone inclined to feel great if a breeze so much as caressed them.

I wondered if April had taken that MDMA of her own accord, or if Lilith had sneaked it into her. And then I wondered again, and again and again, about fucking Lilith: what was she up to? Did she have any overarching, terrible plan? Or was she just being a mischievous little imp?

It was hard to know if Lilith even remembered that she had gotten me into the club, let alone if she had some nefarious, over-arching plan behind it. I only thought she did because *I* only did things when I had a plan, or at least the sense that there was something I wanted out of doing them. After all the events that had taken place since I had met Lilith, it was truly hard to know where she was on the spectrum of good and evil. It was entirely plausible to think she was a psychotic fucking bitch trying to ruin my life in some cruel way, and entirely plausible to think she was trying to help in some sexually supercharged way, and also entirely plausible that Lilith gave a total of zero fucks about any of it, one way or the other.

Which I found more infuriating than if she was evil.

I made myself a drink, even though it was unwise. I could *call* April: I was one of those people who still had a landline. I knew her number.

I stared at the phone.

But what would I say if she answered? What would I do if she was breathless when she answered, her voice punctuated by pulses of air as she bounced on some guy's cock? Or if she didn't answer, and I was then left wondering why not.

Or not so much wondering, as imagining.

There was nothing to *do*, I realized, because only half of me even wanted to do something. The other half wanted all of this to play out; I wanted April to come home in the morning, her dress wrinkled from spending the night on the floor, damp with her sweat; I wanted her to have smeared mascara and disheveled hair, the smell of another man on her, a slightly guilty look on her face as she confessed to me all that she had done. At least, all that she was able to remember...

*

The home phone rang at 9:30 the next morning, rousing me from something that didn't deserve to be called sleep, crumpled in a chair in the living room. When I lifted my head, and tried to see through the miasma of sleep, hangover, and leftover dream-disturbances, a full whiskey glass tipped out of my hand and landed with an unpleasant thunk on the floor. Whiskey seeped into the rug.

I admired my ambition: the glass was actually *full*, like a glass of water.

The phone continued to ring, and by the time I hauled myself out of the chair and paused to remember the events of the previous night, it ceased ringing and went to voicemail.

Ah, I thought. *Voicemail*. A relic of the past that April might have resorted to using when she didn't get any answers to my texts. I could access it from our home phone, if only I knew what number to dial.

The landline started ringing again.

"Hello?"

My voice was craggy, my lips moving too slowly. I had obviously really tied one on last night.

"*Finally!*" April hissed, sounding exasperated. "I've been trying to... did you get any of my messages?"

"No," I told her.

There was a pointed silence. "Uh... why? Okay. Well, I'm on... I was just worried about you since you never wrote back. Or called... or... I should have called you here, I guess? Did you lose your phone or something?"

There was another silence.

"I'm headed home now," she added.

I wasn't entirely sure why I wasn't saying anything.

"In case you were worried," she added.

Another pause.

"Thomas? What is *wrong* with you? Why didn't you answer your phone?"

"Where *are* you?" I demanded. The anger in my voice was disproportionate to the conversation. I myself wasn't entirely sure where it had come from.

"Downtown... look, I'll tell you all about it when I get home -"

"Did you go home with some guy?"

There was a pause, one that seemed the tiniest bit too long to me.

"Not... exactly. Look, I'll explain this all when I get back." She yawned.

"I'm really tired. I've been up all night."

"With some guy?"

April sighed, exasperated. "Did something *happen* to your phone?"

"I broke it."

There was a long pause on the other end of the line. I scowled at the half-empty whiskey bottle I'd dived into and twisted the lid on, trying my hardest to figure out what April's silence meant.

"When?"

"Huh?"

"When did you break it? You know what? Just... I'm headed back, I'll just... we'll sort this when I get home."

"Okay," I said.

"Okay."

Silence.

"Fine, see you, then... uh, soon."

"Bye."

It was a slog, trudging through my molasses-like thoughts, trying to figure out what had unsettled me about the conversation and April's question. I departed from the premise that asking someone *when* they broke their phone is abnormal.

But what did it imply? What was bothering me?

I went to the bathroom and took a shower, cursing at the shower curtain as it clung to my teetering frame each time I leaned unsteadily in one direction or the other. I vowed to the ceiling that I was going to "finish that fucking real shower" next thing.

Then I sat in the same chair I had slept in and waited for her to come home.

It was only when the lock turned on the front door that I realized what it was: the only reason April could care about when I lost my phone was if she knew - as she would, if she had reviewed her own messages - that Lilith had taken her phone from her to send me a text telling me April was going home with some guy.

I didn't, and I don't, want my wife to lie to me. I could say that with a straight face and mean it.

But a sliver of delicious angst cut through me as the door opened, and April, dress rumpled just as I had imagined it, stepped into the house. Her mascara was smeared beneath her red-rimmed eyes. The knife of angst twisted in my gut.

I didn't *want* April to lie to me. But inside, I was shaking from the excitement of the possibility.

She *might*.

CHAPTER 4

April held her hand up as though she wanted to stop me from talking. "Before you say anything," she said, "I sent you like three texts. And I called."

She was wearing the dress from the club; out of the context of the seedy, strobe-and-colored light infused miasma of the night, it looked almost as ordinary as her previous dress. She still had a trashy quality about her, one that was embodied in the subtleties of her makeup, the way it all looked tidied up after use, the way her skin seemed to be sticky with the same film that coats any bar or club at four am after everyone leaves.

"So you went home with somebody," I said, almost like a prompt.

April sighed. Her appearance was deceiving: she was tired-and-cranky April, slightly impatient about clarifying her questions. "When did you lose your phone?" she asked again. "Because Lilith sent you a text -"

"I didn't get it," I lied.

I was a little surprised to hear that come out of my mouth. Or maybe I wasn't. It went against everything we had agreed upon in this relationship, but thinking over it quickly, that wasn't all that much. We hadn't, as Lilith herself had urged, hammered out the precise details of our arrangement.

Now that I thought about it, that was very unlike me.

April did not seem particularly disturbed by this piece of information. She didn't seize upon it or look relieved. She reached out to a table and found a hairband, held it in her teeth while she pulled up her hair, and then removed the band to tie her hair off. Some of her trashy veneer fell away. "That's probably for the best," April said.

I raised my eyebrows.

April rubbed her eyes. "Oh God, I'm so tired, I didn't sleep at all."

My cock swelled instantly to full arousal.

April dropped her hands. "It's not what you think," she told me, and had her mouth open to say something else, when her eyes dropped to my burgeoning erection. Her lips hovered in a meaningless expression, before deciding on a devious smile, changing shape as a light of mischief lit up in her eyes.

She kicked off her shoes and walked toward me. "Or maybe it is..." she said, in a sultry voice.

The power dynamic in our relationship was one that I don't think either of us really ever had a feel for, prior to this chapter of marriage. So it was strange the clarity with which I could see - as she walked toward me, hips moving seductively, fingers playing with the high hem of her dress, mouth confidently grinning - that the dynamic had shifted.

I had felt the rumblings before. Watching the way she walked, seeing the subtle changes in her clothes and her makeup. In those infinitesimal trembles I had sensed the coming earthquake, and now it was here: April, who had always had me wrapped around her finger but never *known* that, was now a fully-formed monster of a woman, the light of her knowledge flickering devilishly in her eyes.

Now, she knew.

As she walked, she lifted her skirt - fractions of an inch at a time, playfully. When she reached the chair she glanced at the whiskey stain, the still-overturned glass - but went back to my eyes, smile unflinching. She chewed on her lower lip. There was a sexual consciousness to the way she did this: she was doing it on purpose, not absent-mindedly.

It made me think of pre-chewed food.

She put her weight on one leg and extended it to pull my left leg in to the center, and then she did the same with my right. Her body poured onto my lap, taking the skirt up to nearly her waist, revealing the black strip of her thong underwear, the soft mound of her pussy beneath it. A puff of air brought her scent to me - sweet, a little sweaty.

Absent from the tones emanating from between her legs was the acrid scent of cum, or even the mingled sourness of sex. But that meant nothing: April could have taken a shower. I couldn't tell, as I clung desperately to that thought, if I did so out of desperation or desire.

I put my hands on her waist, moved them over her body. The material of the dress was shockingly thin, like something a negligee would be made out of. Her skin stuck to it in patches, and it was impossible to tell if that glue was dried sweat or something more dirty.

"Where did you go last night, April?"

April rolled from the hips, pushing her breasts toward me, a bit of cigarette smoke and the cloying scent of club air escaping from her clothing with the motion. She was looking down at me, smiling her maddening

smile. "Where do you want me to have gone?" she asked. She tipped her head. "Home with Jonny and Rog? They were there, you know."

If I was managing to play this cool on my face or in my body language, my cock was ruining the illusion for me. It throbbed through my pants, against April's thigh, and without looking I knew that precum was pouring into the jeans I was still, for some reason, wearing. April's smile throbbed in time with it, the corners of her grin twitching with every pulse of my desire.

In April's eyes was the powerful knowledge that I didn't necessarily want her to have: that I would probably do anything at all to see her fuck Rog and Jonny again.

"They were there, and I thought I was going to go home with them... at least one of them..." she continued. "But then, Lilith had a friend show up."

"Yeah," I said. It didn't sound like a question, or a prompt, so much as the incoherent begging of an adolescent male. My hands were traveling up her back, supporting her weight as she leaned back, stretching like a cat, her head tipping back. Her mound brushed against the lump in my jeans. She shook her hair loose without touching it.

"He was really persistent," April said. She leaned toward me. "Really big, really tall. Black. I didn't want to go home with him, but he won me over."

My chest was cold as ice, and every breath seemed to burn. My mouth was open, for all I knew I was salivating like a dog. April was resting her arms on my shoulders.

"How's that?" I said, my voice dull, parched, wanting only for her to keep talking.

"I danced with him..." she continued. "And then... I'm not sure what happened, I just ended up in a cab with him. And we went to his place, and then we got in his hot tub."

I was staring at her. She smiled. "Remember when we had sex in a hot tub?" she asked me. She was grinning. "I said I would never do it again?"

I did. It had been a bad-ish idea, because the water had washed away any lubrication at the outside of her pussy, and so each thrust had been a little more rubbery, a little squeakier, and her pussy had gotten sore, inflamed, and we had never done it again.

"But you did," I whispered.

She shook her head, which seemed more like a way of shaking her hair than saying no. She squirmed some more on my lap, driving me wild. "It wasn't anything really crazy," she said. "It was just me..." she paused, moving a hand down to my crotch, tracing her fingers over the shape of my dick, smiling when she found the wet stain of precum. "...riding him... but he had *such* a huge cock..."

I sucked in my breath.

I was picturing the giant man from the dance floor, his arms thrown across the back of the hot tub, April riding his cock, buoyant in the water, the soft contours of her pussy rubbery on the outside, but her center as creamy as he could want.

I moved my hand under her dress and stretched my fingers toward her panties. I was pleased when they were damp, and I clawed at them a little clumsily, my drive to see her red, swollen pussy wreaking havoc on my coordination.

I gave up and grabbed her thighs before - with an enormous effort that I was pretty certain I would feel for a long time - standing up, April wrapped around my waist.

I didn't take her very far - only to the couch, and I would be a liar if I said that I set her down with any grace. She fell from my hands, mostly, but her hair spread out beautifully around her face and she smiled, because she seemed to like it. I ripped her panties down her legs, and they tore audibly somewhere by her calves. I hastily got out of my jeans, all while pushing her legs open... I don't remember the details, because it was a blur.

April was smiling up at me, watching me with a kind of lurid fascination. Perhaps she was reflecting on her infinite powers, on how she could reduce me to a salivating, bumbling fool.

I looked down at her spread legs as I guided my cock toward her, at the molten center of her cunt between them. A flicker of confusion traveled through me, because she didn't look particularly used, or sore. But she glistened and I could almost feel the heat of her body closing around me, so the thought disappeared, and I sank into her.

"Did he fuck you full of cum?" I asked her, but I didn't give her a chance to answer. "Say it, tell me about it."

"He fucked me *so* full of cum," April told me, smiling. She mewled, and I moved as slowly and as rhythmically as I could, while her

pussy quivered to a boil and then clamped around me, her mouth open as she came.

Her eyes closed, and her arms went loose on her sides as I fucked my cum into her. She purred a little, and I thought she would open her eyes once the intensity had passed, but her mouth slowly melted into a neutral expression.

I propped myself up on my elbows, still inside of her. "April," I said.

"Mmm," she murmured. It was an inchoate sound, and it faded away into a deep breath, and I realized that April was practically asleep.

I watched her for a bit, and then I begrudgingly slipped from inside of her. I wanted more: more details, more of her with this Chaz character. I wanted to hear that she had fucked him over and over, that her pussy was sore and she was overflowing with cum.

But she was asleep.

So I covered her with a blanket, considered carrying her to bed, and then felt a twitch in my right thigh from having stood up with her, and decided against it.

I sat back down in the chair, and stared at my wife, until I fell asleep as well.

CHAPTER 5

"Thomas," April said, leaning her head back into the stream of hot water from the shower. "You didn't actually think I was *serious*."

I didn't say anything to this. I was leaning against the counter in the bathroom, holding a toothbrush with paste on it, like I meant to use it, watching glimpses of April's wet skin through the part in the shower curtain as she washed her hair. A sliver of her bottom, the impish peek of a nipple. The long curve of her neck and a glimpse of her plump lower lip.

April continued to wash her hair and I was treated to a snippet of her elbow and shapely arm.

"Thomas?" she asked, when the silence continued.

She turned off the water and peeked out of the shower curtain. "Can you hand me a towel?" she asked, and barely paused before continuing, "I just told you all that stuff because I thought we were, like, playing a game." She dried herself off and asked for another towel for her hair.

I said nothing as she tipped her head upside down and toweled her long, dark hair. This gave me a very lovely view of her back, ending with the sweet dual curves of her bottom, the peach-cleft indentation between them winking out of sight where she was folded.

She stood up and looked at me, holding the towel atop her head. She frowned. "You aren't serious, are you? You didn't take me seriously?"

Well, I was in a pickle now.

I think we need to talk about last night, I had said, standing in front of the mirror with the toothbrush in my hand.

Yes, I had taken April seriously. Completely and totally seriously. In part, because I had wanted to take her seriously, but also in part because I knew that some or most of what she had said *had to be* true, based upon what I had seen with my own eyes at the club.

Which I hadn't told her about yet. And which I didn't know if Lilith had told her about yet.

So I couldn't really toss those cards on the table and call her bluff, because her very first question would be: what the hell was I doing there.

But hence the needing to talk, I guess you might be thinking.

None of this was really going the way I had envisioned. I didn't want to be sneaking around on my wife, spying on her. I didn't want my wife to be taking drugs and dancing with strange men and then going home with them... in quite this way. Something about it bothered me, or felt like it should, and so I had marched into the bathroom with that incoherent thought and decided to confront her.

Hence: "We need to talk."

Now, certainly, being a man who has been married for quite some time, I was not ignorant of the fact that conversations beginning with this phrase were unlikely to go as planned. By "planned" here, I suppose I am referring to the tendency I have to think that if I just tell people what's what, they will agree with me, and tell me I am totally right, and we'll be best friends in under five minutes after resolving everything to my satisfaction.

So sure, it wasn't going to go like *that*, and I knew that, even if I didn't listen to my better judgment.

But one thing I had certainly not expected April to say *at all* in response to that was:

"Thomas. You didn't actually think I was *serious*."

Well, I still couldn't think of anything to say, so I stood there, disbelief on my face, and April did something even worse: she crumpled and made an "awww" sound, and frowned her frown for puppies who have taken a shit on the kitchen floor.

She tightened the body towel around her body, doing one of those jujitsu non-knots that women make in their cleavage, creating an indestructible and shapeless dress from the towel. She stepped out of the bathtub, her hand coming toward me. "I just said all that because you seemed like you were into it."

She was using the voice she used for naughty puppies as well. I quieted a flare-up of irrationally fierce anger in my chest and glowered at her.

April became serious. "The truth is so much more boring than that. I was going to talk to you anyway... and confess. But not about... like... sleeping with some random stranger. If that's what you wanted to talk about..." She trailed off, a cloud of confusion or worry crossing her face.

It dispersed like a lonely summer raincloud, and she stood next to me at the counter. "I do have to tell you one bad thing I did," she said.

And then she opened a drawer and pulled out a tube of something she began to dab on her face, without saying anything else, and looking for all the world like she had asked me to go make some coffee.

I looked down at the toothbrush in my hand, then at April. She was nonchalantly dabbing a white liquid beneath her eyes and looking at herself in the mirror.

I'm pretty sure you've had some friends who, or at least watched a movie in which, two people are communicating really poorly, and you feel like screaming at them, because you're sure that you could distill whatever their problem is and just say it and get it over with.

That's likely how you feel right now. Hell, it's how I felt.

The thing is, you can only do stuff like that if you are not one of those two people and have no emotional investment in the situation.

Also, it helps to not have any roots of guilty behavior in that situation, which I did sort of have.

So I just raised my eyebrows, instead of telling April that, while I had this fantasy and she was amazing for enacting it, and while I realized that it wasn't entirely fair, I felt like I was losing control of her and of myself.

Ah, yes.

In order to say something like that, you also have to have some insight into yourself, and I think I might have been lacking that, at that particular moment.

"So," April said, smoothing the cream into her skin and turning her eyes toward me, while keeping her face aligned with the mirror. "I did something kind of bad, which I won't do again, but I didn't realize I had done, you know, all that much of it..."

"Drugs," I said, icily.

April turned to look at me now, one hand still touching her face. Her mouth fell open a little. "Uh... yeah. That. I mean, not *hard drugs*, just MDM...A or... whatever it is. X."

"Okay," I said testily, as a prompt.

"I thought you didn't get Lilith's text?" she asked, confused.

This caught me a little off guard. "I didn't," I said, confidently.

April looked at me funnily, but then seemed to decide, as she often did - bless her - that because I was saying something with such an

authoritative voice, and not adding any additional information, it must have been true.

This also works in corporate meetings. You're welcome.

"And so then..." she continued, her funny-face disappearing with some amount of hesitancy, "...you know. I wasn't making the best decisions. And also, I don't even know what really happened... Lilith disappeared on me, and I thought I was going back to her house, and then I was in this cab with this guy, Chaz." She patted her face as though for punctuation. "But I didn't sleep with him."

"You didn't sleep with him," I repeated.

April shook her head. "No. I got to his place and it was wearing off, and I was like, dude, I really don't know what's going on here, so I think I have to go home... and he was like, no, you're too high, let's just watch movies or something and then you can leave when you're more sober."

Watch movies. That was the oldest trick in the book.

"And that's what you did," I said, my voice dull.

April nodded. "Sorry to disappoint you," she said cheerfully.

I wasn't sure what April thought the joke was, but she was smiling.

"And he just... sat there and watched movies with you," I said.

"All night?" I added, when April moved her head noncommittally and wiped something off her cheek.

"He fell asleep eventually. I couldn't sleep. I watched all three Matrix movies."

If this was a lie, it was pretty great. April hated The Matrix: she hated hearing about it, she hated watching it, she hated that I re-watched for reasons I can't explain.

"On DVD?"

April snorted. "Why *else* would I be watching The Matrix? I couldn't figure out his TV."

This smacked of the truth, because April is perpetually confounded by all modern televisions. I fumed a little anyway.

"Nothing else happened," I dictated dubiously. "He didn't try to put the moves on you again or anything."

April dropped her hand to the counter and leaned on it as she turned toward me. "You say that," she said, her voice a dangerous sing-song, dripping with a false cheer that was the harbinger of a serious clawing, headed straight for me, "like you don't *believe me*."

I laughed. It escaped me before I even knew it was coming. "April," I said. "Seriously. Every guy I know has said to some girl who said she was too high or too drunk and making a bad decision, 'oh, that's cool, we can just watch movies.'"

April looked at me incredulously. "Huh," she clucked, and turned back to face the mirror. "And then what, every guy who has ever said that just goes ahead and what... date rapes her? You too?"

That seemed like a bit of an escalation to me. So I said so.

"That's a little bit of an escalation."

"Hmm."

This was not going at all like I wanted it to.

"I'm just saying," I clarified, "that I find it hard to believe that this guy was just sitting in a corner, twiddling his thumbs, watching a movie, with some super-hot chick in his apartment, especially when -"

I cut myself off. I had been about to say, "especially when she was letting him finger-fuck her on the dance floor a couple of hours earlier."

Because if I said that, then I would have to explain why I knew about it.

And sure, I planned to come clean about having been at the club... eventually. I knew I *should*. I sensed it was going to be one of those things that would come back to bite me in the cock if I didn't.

But there was one thing I didn't like about any of this, even more than I didn't like feeling like April was out of my control - and it was the feeling that *I* was out of control. And regardless of how one measured "control," I was pretty sure salivating off a balcony and dropping your phone because your wife was letting a stranger finger-fuck her on the dance floor of a club you weren't even supposed to be at, with an enormous erection, didn't hit even the lowest watermark for "being in" control.

"Especially when, what?"

"Well you were high," I pointed out. "On a drug that people hand out specifically because it makes people horny."

April carefully replaced the cap on her tube of whatever. "That's fair," she said. Then she shrugged. "Whatever. He was a really nice guy. Also," she added, her tone getting testy. "I mean... he also wasn't a total stranger. Lilith knows him really well. He said that she told him not to push any boundaries. Or something. So, like... it wasn't as dangerous as just, I don't know. Any old guy."

She had a new tube of something now, and she was putting it on her fingertip. "God," she commented bitterly. "I can't believe you think I'd be stupid enough to just... fall for that with some random guy." She looked at the mirror and stretched her jaw down as she patted some of that latest potion on her chin. "It's not like I never met another guy in my whole life, Thomas."

I was feeling queasy. April had introduced a dimension to this new chapter in our relationship that I hadn't actually considered until that very moment, probably because everything had always happened with people Lilith had "vetted." Professionals, you might say.

I wasn't sure why Lilith - of all people - having vetted something had made me feel secure, but it had.

It occurred to me, as April was talking, and for the very first time, as unbelievable as it sounds, that she might someday run into a guy who was not one of Lilith's "friends" or "professional contacts."

And if I thought about that guy from the night before as just *some guy*, it put a dangerous spin on everything.

Because most guys *wouldn't* just watch movies with some X'd up hottie in their apartment.

But, all of this was just a fog of thoughts, mostly feelings, at that particular moment. So I didn't say any of that. I said, instead:

"So you didn't do anything at all with this guy," in a flat, disbelieving voice.

April was now bringing a medieval torture device to her eyes. It was an eyelash curler, because her eyelashes are about three inches longer than anyone else's and straight as the rest of her hair, and if she doesn't curl them they give her a very sleepy, slightly dopey appearance. I like it, but she hates it.

"I didn't say *that*," April said, and it was hard to tell if the note of caution in her voice came from the subject at hand, or the fact that she was doing something so apparently dangerous next to her right eye.

She cast a glance in my direction before switching to the other eye. "I sort of... you know, danced with him, and some other stuff, at the club."

"Some other stuff," I repeated listlessly.

April set the eyelash curler down and pressed her lips together. "I thought... I mean, I assumed you'd be okay with that," she said. Then she

narrowed her eyes and sort of glared at me. "I mean, you *seemed* okay with... you know. This morning, anyway."

I sighed as I tilted my chin up to explain things to April.

But then wisely, I shut up.

"I think... see this is why I said we needed to talk," I told her, authoritatively.

"*Okay*," April snapped, turning back to the mirror.

She sounded like a sixteen-year-old girl, sassing her father about taking the car out. A small nuclear explosion took place inside my head, and then all the blood in my body went mysteriously into my dick.

Well. Not *entirely* mysteriously.

"So what *did* you actually do? With this guy?" I turned around, and moved behind her, sliding my hands down her arms.

April looked for a moment like she was going to get angry. Then she smiled. "Wouldn't *you* like to know?"

I kissed her neck. It seemed less humiliating than nodding like a child and saying, "Yes, yes! I really do want to know!"

She laughed and wriggled away from me. "Sorry. I don't really have the details. It was just... dancing. You know? Like, really close, maybe I kissed him, he had his hands all over me... but that's... all the detail I have."

She turned back to look at me. Her face was suddenly serious. "I'm sorry," she said. And she sounded genuine. "I shouldn't have done that X. I probably... shouldn't go out with Lilith, alone, I mean."

She pushed on the towel wrapped up like a turban on her head. Her hair spilled over her shoulders. "Can I make it up to you? By letting you take me out to lunch?"

She was flirting. It was irresistible, even if I felt terrible for reasons I couldn't quite clarify to myself at the time. That feeling, the one that had been creeping in lately - of April being *conscious* of how much power she held over me, and, worse yet, *willing* to use it - started climbing into my deepest thoughts.

I felt pretty unwell, to be honest. Like I might barf.

But I smiled instead.

"I have the biggest hankering for sushi," April said cheerfully, accepting my smile as an agreement to do just that: take her to lunch, and

forgive her, and not tell her that I had seen her in the club doing much more than what she had described.

I couldn't know if April knew what she had done, or if she had just been too high to remember it well. And after the serious turn this conversation had taken, it was too late for me to come clean about myself sneaking around the club.

Too late to find out if April knew about all that, and was just fucking with me now.

"How about that place in the Highlands?" I asked her.

A steakhouse and a sushi place, where we could both be happy with our lunch, because April loves sushi, and I do not.

CHAPTER 6

I had a few problems, I realized, as we drove to The Highlands to eat at Sushi Compromise, which is what I called the restaurant in my own head, due to my chronic inability to remember the names of most things.

There was the quagmire of my own desires. The disappointment that I was feeling instead of relief, and a desire to see April with another guy, again. The deep-down truth that I had sort of wanted her to have gone too far with Chaz, and remember it, and maybe even lie to me about it, as little sense as that made.

And then there was Lilith, always slinking around in my life and April's, offering tantalizing tidbits like this "proposition" she had wanted to run by me last night. Lilith, who had her fingers (playfully) in every cookie jar around, and who I did not trust, and who I did not know if she was on my side or not.

Lilith seemed to see the world as a place of no sides, unless maybe hedonism was squared off against everything else.

In which case, that was her side.

I wanted to, as Lilith had purred at me to do, ask April about this new proposition. And I almost did. It was burning inside of me as soon as I remembered that part of the evening, and my mouth was open before I had authorized it to be, and I was saying, "Hey, so I wanted to ask you about something -"

But luckily, a tripwire somewhere in my logistician brain went off, and I acted like I had forgotten what I was going to say. April had turned to me, sweetly, blinking her long lashes with interest.

The problem, of course, was that I didn't know what Lilith had told April. She sent me a text from April's phone, so I knew that April knew that Lilith had written to me. But I had to pretend like I hadn't received that text, because I had lied about it.

I also didn't know if Lilith had told April that I had gone slinking around at the club.

And this was all so stupid, I realized. I was like one of those characters I hate in a movie, who goes around making all his own problems.

"This is so stupid," I said aloud.

"What?" April asked.

"This... detour," I said, pointing at a conveniently located detour that happened, in fact, to be stupid.

April didn't even respond. Topics like "why traffic detours are inefficient and therefore stupid" were not interesting to her, for whatever reason.

I remember thinking that I should come clean. *April*, I would say. *I actually got weirdly and insanely jealous last night, and I went to that club because...*

Because what?

This was the real problem. If I wanted to be honest with April about *what* I was doing, I needed to be able to tell her *why* I had done it. Not just for my own sake, or the sake of fairness in discussions, but also because that was definitely going to be the first question April asked me.

It was a fair question.

So, Thomas Roberts.

Why did you go to a club last night, creep on your wife, and then lie about it?

This was all because of the phone.

But what would I have done if I hadn't dropped my phone? What if I had said, "yeah, I'm cool with it" and then April had gone home with Chaz with full permission to fuck him all she wanted?

What *would I have done* if I hadn't dropped my phone?

The answer wasn't readily available.

*

April always ordered a huge margarita at this sushi place, called "Japan in The Highlands," which is a lame name and explains why I am always forgetting it. Why they serve a distinctive pink margarita in a fishbowl-sized container is anyone's guess, but she saw one going to someone's table the first time we went there and ordered it.

I drank most of it, because April couldn't possibly drink that much booze, and isn't really a big drinker. And so I usually end up drinking this margarita, which is pink and gross, but is also like \$23, which I feel is too much to let it go to waste.

I had previously asked if there are margaritas in any other size. There are not.

On this occasion, April placed both hands on her giant fishbowl margarita and downed almost a quarter of it within a minute of it arriving.

"Shoot," she said, almost gasping for breath. "I'm really thirsty. I should have had a water first."

I got her a water and eyed her suspiciously over the enormous glass. She was draining it, which wasn't terrible, because it magnified her cleavage and allowed me to have a very adolescent titillation, even amid all of my adult angst.

"So, I don't want to pick at this... you know, argument we had this morning," I began, after we'd ordered our food. "Really. I don't. But I just want to ask... what was Lilith sending a text to me about?"

April had spilled some of the semi-frozen drink onto her thumb, and she sucked on it and released it with a pop, her eyes on mine. It was sexy, and it seemed staged, but I was aware that I was partially losing my mind.

Not everything she was doing was necessarily something she was doing to fuck with me, I told myself.

"What are you talking about?" April said, but something behind me caught her attention and her eyes lit up. "Oh God, I'm so hungry, I want that fried ice cream." Her eyes came back to mine.

"You said Lilith sent me a text," I continued.

"Oh," April said.

She seemed to understand what I had said, and remember the text.

"Yeah, she sent it from my phone," April told me, pulling her phone out and swiping her fingers over the screen. She flipped it to face me. "That one."

Indeed.

"So..." I said, after giving it enough time that I could claim to have been reading the text for the first time - which was something I felt couldn't ever be a problem for me, because even if April found out that I was at the club, I was the only person on earth who knew I had seen that text before dropping my phone.

"...what would you have done? You know? If I had written back?"

April leaned her face against her hand and smiled at me, and I felt that disturbance in the force again: a shimmer, a paradigm shift, all of it wrapped up in April's smile. She had all the power, and she *knew* it.

"I guess that would depend..." she purred. "On what you had said."

Her foot rubbed against my leg under the table.

Anything April did under the table, or thoughts of tables and April even remotely near each other in time, made my mind fill with fresh, visceral memories of the night she had popped underneath the table at *Tres*, and sucked Rog's cock, her arm moving against my thigh as she bobbed her head in the tight space.

My cock was hard as a rock again. April was smiling, like she knew that, too.

"Well," I said. "You went home with him anyway."

April made a face at me. The face she made when I was, legitimately, pouting like a baby and needed to explain myself. "Are you saying you didn't want me to go home with him?" April asked. She drew her fingers from the side of her face to her teeth, and bit gently into the length of one. Much like she was nibbling on a cock.

A cold sweat broke out all over my body.

"I just assumed," she said, "that you *did*. As long as I told you what happened. As long as there was no *sex*." She was speaking in a very sultry voice, and had slipped the shoe from her foot and leaned back against the booth to move it up my leg, into my crotch, where she felt the hard shape of my dick with her toes. A flash of triumph shimmered in her eyes. "Are you telling me you didn't?"

I said something like "Noh," and shook my head.

She leaned forward and took a sip of her margarita. "Are you disappointed that I didn't do anything with him?"

I inhaled deeply. In truth, I was feeling a little faint.

"Because I can always make a situation like that happen again," April said.

Then she put her hand down and looked at me. "Are you okay?"

I nodded. I had a pain in my chest and I wanted to punch myself a few times in the sternum, but I didn't want her to know that.

"You look pale."

"I'm... um... not."

Whatever that meant.

April's foot burrowed around between my legs, stroking my dick. She smiled, thinking that was the sole reason for my heart attack symptoms.

April studied me for a minute, her foot playing with my dick, which pulsed occasionally as some memory of all the filthy, sexy, dirty, hot

things she *had* done squeezed through my mind in detail so fine I could almost smell it. "Chaz was actually a pretty hot guy," she said.

My cock throbbed.

"But listen... there is something else."

I gulped. This is the kind of thing I read in books all the time or saw in a cartoon and thought was ridiculous. But my throat was so dry that I felt like I was swallowing a fucking walnut, and I really needed to swallow.

"Something else with this guy?" I asked, after picking up my water and gulping it. I was pretty sure my hand was shaking. April's foot was still massaging my dick, and she was grinning ever more devilishly with every passing second.

She leaned forward and put her elbows on the table, after sliding her margarita from between us. Her foot eased off a little, but she was still moving it in slow circles, just grazing the material of my jeans, which was almost worse. "You know that guy? The one that commissioned the film?"

"He wants another one," I said, my voice monotone. Inside, I was flying to new heights. Another film, another twisted, deviant, porno starring April. This time I would write the raw footage into the contract, because I was still disappointed (though not really *that* disappointed, to be fair) by her last film.

April pressed her lips together and squinted. It was a face she made rarely, and it was reserved for when I had something not quite right.

So obviously: rarely.

"Not another *film*," she said, a hint of mystery in her voice.

"Okay I have the sushi boat for two and... oh. There's only two of you," a waitress interrupted. She stood in our semi-cubicle and looked down at our table, perplexed.

I was unable to say anything. In fact, I wasn't fully registering that she was there. My mind was still doubling back, listening to April's voice, thinking of her lips: not another *film*.

"He has the meat plate," April said, smiling, and for some reason, pushing her foot into my dick, slowly but with terrific force. "The boat's for me." She smiled pleasantly.

"You eat whole boat? It's for two people," the waitress said, apologetically. "I got the order wrong," she said sadly.

April waved at her frantically. "No, no, I'm just really hungry."

The waitress set the boat down and stared at April, mouth slightly open, as April poured soy sauce into a small dish and began to dunk massive amounts of wasabi into it.

"All okay?"

"It's great," April said, plunging a California roll into her soy sauce and then to her mouth, and nodding, because she could no longer talk. She waved her hand. "I'm just really hungry," she managed to say.

The waitress left. I stared at my wife.

"I'm so hungry," she said to me, grabbing another California roll.

April seemed to have forgotten, in her glee for California rolls and an entire boat of sushi for two people that she apparently planned to consume by herself, that she had dangled before me the prospect of some devious sexual act, something *other* than a porno in which two black men fucked her in every hole.

She finished almost all of the margarita and then calmed down.

"God, I haven't been this hungry in my whole life. Sorry. I'm eating like a crazy person." She dabbed at her mouth daintily with a napkin, returning to her ordinary form.

"Uh..." I said.

So I started eating my meal, because I really couldn't think of anything else to do. I wanted to get back to the subject April had tantalized me with, but she was so busy eating that I didn't dare interrupt her.

Not a *film*? Not a film.

What in the hell else could it be, and why did April think eating was more important than telling me?

At last, halfway through the boat, she leaned back, her appetite evidently sated. "Okay," she said. "That's better."

Her margarita was empty, which was a little insane. She had a glassy-eyed look that she got whenever she was fairly intoxicated.

"So..." I said, broaching the subject. "You were saying?"

April looked over my head as if she saw something in the distance, squinting a little. "What?"

It was perhaps in moments like this one that I found my predilection for this sexual game most titillating, even if it was in kind of a perverse way. I don't think April could know, and I don't think April could understand, how exquisitely infuriating, and therefore weirdly erotic it was to me, that she could ask a question like that at time like that.

What.

What, as if we had been discussing a grocery list. For April, this was a fanciful, interesting, pleasurable part of her existence. She liked it, she was obviously having fun with it, and maybe we had tapped into some lurid, flourishing, sexual and slutty side of her.

But it wasn't burning her up from the inside-out like it was me. *She* could have news about what the man who had commissioned her to make a porno wanted now, and be interrupted by a boat of raw fish, and then forget what we were talking about.

Or was she messing with me?

Either way, I was getting a third-degree burn on the inside of my body from my molten, ignited desire.

"*Oh*," April said, her eyes focusing as she remembered. I was pleased that she sat up and leaned toward me, gently nudging the sushi boat out of her way. "The guy. So, Lilith told me about this last night. It turns out he has a proposition."

I doubt that words can accurately describe my impatience at this point, so I won't. I sat there, sweat oozing out of my pores, a chill traveling all over my skin as the over-amped air conditioning clung to it. I was feeling positively unwell, to be truthful: inside I thought I was going to be cremated, and I was covered by an icy sweat. My cock was straining against my pants and felt like it might just actually explode - not with an orgasm, but like an overcooked fucking sausage.

I started seeing double while April veered off on side stories about how the conversation came to happen, a rambling story that seemed to last forever and included details about a cocktail that Jonny had made.

"... so I guess the film really did it for him, but he wants *more*. And he was talking to Lilith about it and she had an idea, because I guess she knows him pretty well and so she knew that he has an apartment in the city. And so she was *thinking*..."

April paused, looked at me coquettishly, and stretched a hand across the table to caress the top of my hand. I felt like I was going to vomit, but I managed to do something with my facial features that must have indicated interest on my part.

And I waited. What seemed like a long, long, time. Deep down inside, I wanted to scream at April to spit it out. *What was she fucking thinking, April?*

The following sentences, uttered by April, were delivered with pauses of such infuriating, stratospherically, Shatneresque lengths between the phrases, that she almost caused me to stroke out. At each pause, April made a small circle with her fingertips on the backside of my hand, which had developed a sudden, curious connection with the surface of my cock:

"She was *thinking*... if he just wants to watch... his wife... and you and I... are doing this *anyway*... then if I were to go to... you know, his apartment... and he could *be there*... *hiding*, you know?... and watch... then he would feel like... you know... he had watched his wife... and also... he's willing to pay.... and since it isn't, like... something we're not doing *anyway*... I mean... at first... it sounded like prostitution... and I was like... no *way*... But then... I don't know... I thought about it... and... Lilith has a point... I'm not doing anything I wouldn't be doing anyway, right?... and so if... you know.... there's extra money in it... then... why not?"

April's fingers stopped the maddening movement on my hand. She was poised in partial shrug, batting her eyes.

Why not?

She waited, and it's anyone's guess what I did during that interlude.

She leaned back, looking a little sheepish. "You think it's a bad idea."

I had no idea what I thought.

I *felt* like I could hear every particle in the air crashing into each other all at once. I *felt* like my heart and my cock were going to explode simultaneously.

Thoughts? I asked myself.

My throat was so dry that when I opened my mouth to speak, I made a terrible sound. I reached for my glass of water.

"So," I managed to say. "He wants to... pay you? To... go to his apartment? And have sex with... who?"

"It's a terrible idea," April said. "Now that I say it aloud, it's..." she waved a hand at me. "Forget it."

"No, I mean... I think I just... don't understand."

April shook her head fervently. She brought her hand to her mouth. "No, now that I say it, it's... it's ludicrous."

"Honey," I said, and now I was reached for her hand. "I want to hear it, I just don't... he wants you to have sex in his apartment. But not with him. With...?"

April laughed, and covered her mouth, and then leaned closer. "You know. Like... Jonny, or Rog, or something like that. Like, he wants to hide somewhere, and watch. That's it."

Well... that wasn't *entirely* it from this Greg guy, if April remembered correctly, which she apparently didn't. Ordinarily, I would have felt the need to correct a misremembering this glaring: previously, this guy had eaten Jonny's cum out of April's ass, which, if anyone were being technical, was not "just watching."

But details, amirite?

I swallowed, mostly to keep myself from saying something stupid.

"I dunno," I said, slowly.

April leaned back. "I know, right? It's sort of... seductive. But... no, it's too weird."

Oh, sweet April.

After all of this, she actually thought that there was some nadir to my "weirdness." That there was an abyss in which my dirty thoughts were poured, and she had reached the bottom of it.

It was a lot like believing you'd somehow reached the end of all the porn on the internet.

"Uh... it's... I mean... it's *weird*, for sure," I said.

It wasn't. I didn't mean that at all. If my own wife hadn't been willing to participate in this fantasy, and I was as loaded as this guy seemed to be, and there was a woman out there who looked like my wife, with whom I had no prenuptial agreement, and she was willing to put on a wig and fuck some guys... who knows? It wasn't *that* different than commissioning porn.

"It's not that different," I said cautiously, "than commissioning a film. Really. Right?"

April laughed, leaning her head back against the booth. It was a sharp, strange laugh. She rolled her eyes. She was really tickled.

"Oh my God," she said, in a strange kind of hokey drawl. "That is literally *exactly* what Lilith said."

My having done something identical to Lilith Stephanapolous caused a peculiar clang somewhere in my chest, but I put the thought away for some other time.

"Of course, if you think it's too weird," I said, "then you shouldn't do it... but - and don't get me wrong, my immediate thought was, no way..."

..it wasn't...

"... but, I mean... if you were thinking of doing this, you know, anyway... then maybe, I don't know. It isn't all that crazy?"

April seemed to be pleased that I had said this, if not somewhat mistrustful. She didn't seem to know what to say.

"Like... how much was he thinking of paying you?" I ventured.

As if I cared.

April closed her mouth, and looked in both directions, which was hysterical, because this place had walls around each of the tables to look more authentic. She leaned forward again. "That's the really, I don't know... the part that makes me think about it, seriously."

I waited. She rubbed her lips together and lowered her voice. "It's so much cheaper than a film, right? And Lilith says he's really, really gagging for it - her words - and so, you know - and he's really loaded, with like, money to burn. So I could probably do what I did before. Set the price."

She tipped her head even closer to mine. "Like... *thousands*. Per time. Cash."

Naturally.

I raised my eyebrows. April raised hers.

Per time? I wondered, as the waitress came back.

CHAPTER 7

We talked about it some more, and April was surprisingly low on details. She hadn't really believed I would go for the idea, and so she hadn't pried Lilith for more information.

My main concern, in all of this, was for myself. If April was going to get paid to do something she'd be doing anyway, then I wanted to be in the picture somehow. And something told me that Mr. Greg Smith, Moneybags, didn't want another "husband" lurking around in his apartment.

I didn't say this to April, but I did tell her I'd rather get some more information before making a decision one way or the other.

And who do you go to for that kind of information?

Lilith, of course.

*

As usual, my text to Lilith went for days with no response, and then, in the wee hours of Wednesday morning, while the rest of us normal people were tucked safely in our beds, Lilith responded:

*Come out
Habanero
Friday*

Habanero was a new, expensive restaurant that also sported a cigar room, the sort of thing you needed extremely expensive special dispensation for from the city and the state, and Lilith evidently knew the owner.

"Oh yeah," April said. "That's the place with the cigar room. Lilith's friends with the owner."

When you make a date with Lilith, you never know what you're in for.

I had seen Lilith show up like a lawyer to hammer out details of April's porno production, and I had seen Lilith walk around the city in what would barely pass for a negligee, paying for nothing, and dragging dozens

of hapless men in her wake. I had also seen Lilith conducting business in the hottest club in town like a gangster.

So perhaps it is more apt to say, if you made a date with Lilith, you never knew which one of her Hollywood gangsta-madame selves would show up.

I had an additional problem with this particular date with Lilith, and it was banal and unlike me to even consider: I was fresh out of cool clothes. Not that I believed that Lilith noticed or cared about what I wore in general, but since she had approved of my *Zaouk Klub* getup via photo, I suspected she would remember it. And that was the entire line of fashionable shirts in my wardrobe.

"Fuck it," I told the closet. I'm a working-class guy, I don't have clubbing clothes.

I put on the same thing.

April looked me up and down. "That's a hot shirt," she said. "Very... I don't know. Hipster? No... it's a little cooler than that." She laughed, and played with the collar, which was not unpleasant at all. Then she kissed me on the cheek, and I tried to throw her on the bed to make mad, passionate love to her, because she was in a new, orange-red dress with matching orange-red lipstick, and her legs were everywhere, and she looked elegantly slutty.

I got as far as cupping her ass in my hands, and starting to bunch up the fabric of her dress in my palms, inching it up, exposing her legs and her satin panties.

She wriggled away. "No way," she laughed. "I don't want to mess up all my makeup."

Pushing me away she winked and drew a hand down the center of my chest, fluttering over the seam of my jeans as she squirmed free. "But later..."

So began the hard-on that I was pretty sure would last all night.

I've been a responsible semi-drunk since I had my first beer at age 13 on the roof of my buddy Dan's second stepfather's trailer home. Maybe you belong to a class of people who offer you a coffee, or a cordial, or even a whiskey when you show up at their house. But these are people who expect you to bring your own case of beer, and it should be suitably crappy. Drinking five or six of these a night is generally considered "not drinking." Everything else flows from there.

April, on the other hand, was not a huge drinker. Since we had been married, I'd been somewhat tempered in my habits. I was sagely advised that consuming 5-6 Coors Lights was not, in fact, "not drinking," and I'd been nudged gently in the direction of pouring things like wine and whiskey into glasses when invited to parties or dinners outside of my own circle of friends. But April had been, before Lilith crashed half-naked into our lives, not only a somewhat tempering force on my blue-collar, light beer-swigging ways, but also a reliable sober driver.

Not so anymore, and because April was not quite as "seasoned" as me, she was completely useless as a potential source of transportation if she drank at all.

So we Ubered it to *Habanero*, because I think ahead. Really, in the grand scheme of things, this was probably cost-effective even if I didn't get a DUI, because *Habanero* was in a part of town where parking spaces, if they could be had, were as expensive as staying in a decent hotel for the night.

Habanero was not a club, but it did have a lot of people milling around outside who were apparently waiting to get in.

The whole place was really something. It had been designed with a nod to the Havana of old, which was something even a guy like me could recognize. Ferns were standing in for tropical plants, which seemed like a good bet, but everything was glammed up like labor was cheap and Castro hadn't been born yet.

"Classy," I said.

The hostess, like the bouncer at *Zaouk Club*, did not need our names. You think whatever you want, but having someone recognize you before you say anything to them at a hot club makes you feel baller as fuck. If you are walking around with a woman as hot as April on your arm, it's a good high. Even if April is your wife, and she's slightly dusted with a trashy, ephemeral powder of something-or-other that is vaguely reminiscent of strip club glitter, and you feel mildly uncomfortable because you're possibly showing up to discuss kinda, sorta, prostituting her to a cuckold voyeur.

"She's in the VIP room," April said, in reference to nothing, as she put her phone into her tiny purse and pointed in the direction of the cigar room.

"Have you been here before?" I asked.

But April was already moving along with an efficiency that is unlike her, hair swinging, heels clacking sexily on the tiled floor, absorbed into the murmur of the lively crowd around us. A live band full of horns abruptly began blasting away, and April walked on like she hadn't heard me. So I followed.

Lilith was draped on a big, leather chair in a dress that for her seemed almost conservative (this was a trick of the light and the position of her body - later, when she stood up, the permanent pleats would rise and rise to just below her ass, and cast in a different light become the most seductive degree of transparent - opaque enough to be clothing, sheer enough to detect that she had no underwear on - and I would commit to memory the pleasant crease where her thin but sculpted thigh met her spherical ass). The pleats were vaguely reminiscent of a parochial school uniform, though all white - as only Lilith dared - perhaps comically, perhaps unconsciously - to wear so frequently. The top was a close-knit sleeveless lace number, almost like the top half of a racy wedding dress. The confluence of schoolgirl and bride was flavored with a hint of whoreish underbelly: sharp, impossible white heels that belonged squarely on the stage of a strip club. It was all very typically Lilith and definitely disturbing.

Her legs were draped over the fat armrest, crossed at the ankles. She was, as was in no way a surprise, smoking a cigar.

She turned her head, sending her shiny, platinum hair cascading to the side, catching the light like a disco ball. Lilith seemed to be living in a separate world, one drenched in glaring camera-flash, as if she alone was glued to the pages of a men's magazine. She smiled, and a now-familiar shiver traveled down my spine, mingling with the arousal April had inspired, and then radiating throughout my body as half fear, and half arousal.

She was all the way across the room, which was large, and as we crossed it, she slowly poured herself into a new position, and reached for a drink. She stood up. "April," she said to April breathlessly.

We both stood there, hanging on, as I suppose everyone did, to hear whatever it was that Lilith's vaguely filthy, breathless voice promised she was going to say next. But Lilith, as usual, didn't actually have anything to say.

Her eyes went from my face to my shoes and then back up, the very corners of her mouth turning up minutely as her eyes worked their way back up. "Hot shirt," she told me.

It gave me a bit of a jolt. I had decided to wear the shirt anyway, and I had expected it to be dangerous, because Lilith seemed to be the only person who knew I went to *Zaouk Klub* that night, but even with all that thinking ahead, even when I had basically opened the door to this sort of knife's edge of secrets that didn't really even need to be kept, it gave me a wild thrill.

April smiled at me.

Lilith leaned close to April, her hand falling into her long hair. "Go say hi to Jake," she said, stretching a long finger away from the snifter clasped in her free hand toward the bar. I followed her finger to the bar, my mind racing with all sorts of calculations and memories: was there a night when April could have come here, and met Jake already? And why didn't I know about it?

But April was stalking away, and Lilith was looking at me, amused, and the full effect of her schoolgirly wedding dress hybrid was singeing my balls.

"Hot dress," I told her wryly.

She tapped a beautifully manicured fingernail against the glass of her snifter and otherwise did not respond to this comment in any way. "She told you about the offer Greg made?" she asked.

Then she stepped back and poured herself into the chair again, retrieving the cigar she'd left in an ashtray that looked far too expensive to be left on a table getting filled with ashes.

"Want a cigar?" she asked me.

"Can I smoke a cigarette?"

Lilith rolled her eyes. I sat down across from her and rested my arms on the fat armrest of the enormous chair.

Lilith ashed and took a puff of her cigar, which unsurprisingly left her mouth in a dense plume, let go and not expelled, curling into a shape that reminded me of a cock.

"What do you think?" she asked, leaning an elbow on the small table between us.

"I need a drink," I told her.

She pointed at the bar. "But don't go now."

I had to turn slightly to see the bar, where April was smiling warmly at a man in a very expensive suit.

"That's Jake," Lilith said, as if it needed explanation. When I turned back to her she smiled, and her mouth cradled the smoke for a moment before she expelled in a perfect "o."

"He's mostly gay," she said. Her eyes flickered from my face to the bar. "Maybe you're into that," she commented dryly. It wasn't a statement of curiosity. She pointed the cigar at the ashtray to tap away the ash. "What did April tell you?"

Business Lilith.

I liked her.

"Just that... Greg?... uh, wanted to... pay her. To sleep with guys. At his apartment."

Lilith regarded me with eyes that had glazed over with boredom. "So why did you need to talk to me?" she asked, also dryly.

"I just wanted to get into a nice place without waiting in line, Lilith."

Lilith liked this. She chewed delicately on the end of the cigar, and though there was no earthly resemblance between them, George Peppard came to mind. "What's your dilemma, then?" she asked. "He's willing to pay *a ton* of money for it."

I stared at her.

"It isn't that you don't want April to sleep with more guys," Lilith mused.

Though I tried hard not to, I did it anyway: I turned and looked around me like I was about to tell a racist joke. "I mean, Lilith," I said. "It is *technically* prostitution."

Lilith moved her head slowly from side to side, looking at the ceiling almost thoughtfully. I had no idea how to interpret the gesture. Surely, she wasn't only thinking of this only now. Not Lilith.

She looked back at me and shrugged. "It's not, really," she said, with authority. "And even if it were, he'll pay in gifts, so you have no legal exposure." She leaned back and crossed her legs, and I didn't bother looking away from the glimpse of her snatch that I was treated to. A night with Lilith without one such scene would have alarmed me. "Is it about the hair?"

"Whu... *what?*"

"The hair," Lilith repeated.

And when I continued to stare at her without comprehension:

"April's hair. Dyeing it red?"

"April's not dyeing her hair red," I said authoritatively, even though I had no idea what the hell Lilith was talking about.

"I can talk to him about it," Lilith said. She leaned out to look at April and squinted. "I don't really see her as a redhead, either."

"Lilith," I said, exasperated. "What the *hell* are you talking about?"

Lilith was distracted by something within her own head, her eyes unseeing. This lasted only a moment, and then the sharp glint returned to her gaze, which was terrifying. "His wife," she said, her breathlessly excited voice having returned, "can probably be talked into dyeing her hair back to black. She falls for absolutely anything if you say it's high fashion." Lilith tipped her head. "Slovenian." She looked at the ceiling for a moment, head still tipped. "Greg will probably thank you for it. She has this -" Lilith waved her hand over her own head, "*communist* red color going on."

I looked at Lilith, probably blankly, still wandering around in her previous sentences like a recently awakened coma patient.

"It's strange," Lilith said whimsically. "She's only like twenty-four." Her eyes returned to mine and the whimsy left her voice and her demeanor. "I'll take care of it. Anything else?"

I turned my palms up in exasperation and shook my head a little with my mouth open, in the universal sign for "what the fuck?"

"Thomas," Lilith said, mercurially annoyed. "What is your *problem*? Logistics? Payments? Moral quandaries? Where to park?"

She laughed at this last one, though honestly, I didn't find it very funny. Parking was a serious problem in this town.

"Parking is a serious issue in this town," I told her, seriously.

I could see this amused her, but did not illicit any other sort of response.

"No. I don't need to know where to park my fucking car, Lilith."

A puff of smoke left her lips as she smiled at that. I suspected a sexual joke of some sort had occurred to her, but I had no patience for it.

I glanced back at April, who was leaning on the bar, engrossed with the "mostly gay" Jake, and then to Lilith. "How is this supposed to work?"

"Logistics," Lilith said, as if I had answered her question and she was now clear on where to take the meeting. She ashed her cigar and looked at it. "Are you sure you don't want one? They're from -"

"Cuba. Right. Logistics, Lilith."

Lilith gave her head a little shake to emphasize each of the following sentences, like I was an idiot asking my HR rep questions about passive-aggressive notes taped to the communal microwave.

"What's to know, Thomas? April goes out on some specified date, she does her thing, or she meets Jonny, or Rog, or really whoever she wants... and then she goes to the apartment, and she texts ahead so he knows she's coming, and they do what nature intended, and then she collects a bag from Tiffany's and goes home."

"Uh-huh," I said. And then, because it was a question that had burned inside of me almost from the moment I had met Lilith, I went ahead and asked her, "And what, exactly, is your part in all of this Lilith? You get some kind of commission or something?" I didn't really expect her to answer.

Lilith formed another perfect ring of smoke and watched it floating toward the ceiling, and if I hadn't known her and her shtick by then, I would have thought she was looking for the answer in the shapeless remains of the smoke.

"Thomas," she cooed, in the most saccharine voice she'd dispensed thus far. "Let me ask you a question: why does it *matter* to you what my role in this is?" She leaned back again, pointing her cigar at me. "*You* ought to think about *that*."

"You really are a crazy bitch, Lilith," I told her. It was a pre-fab comeback. She grinned and took it as a compliment, nodding in agreement.

I certainly wouldn't want Lilith to ever know, though, that I would give that comment a lot of thought. That maybe she was right: I probably should think about why it was that I cared so much what Lilith's involvement in "this" was. (Questions, to ponder, that would surface in the dark hours of the night: Was I engaged in a power struggle with Lilith, and if that was the case, what did it say about me? Et cetera.)

Lilith's eyes lit up about something behind me, and then she flashed me a look that appeared to be a warning, just before April placed a hand on my shoulder. "Are we staying a while?" she asked. "Jake wants to show you the humidor."

"I need a drink," I said, to no one in particular.

*

"So? Nice, huh?"

"It's the most impressive humidor I've ever seen," I responded truthfully.

The humidor was the only humidor I'd ever seen. I tried to look duly impressed, and then we scattered into the cigar room, and the whole place began to fill up while I helped myself to as many drinks as I could, because Jake had told the bartender they were on the house.

I was having a pleasant and terrible time, drowning my general personality, the personality I get after I have a few drinks but haven't passed out yet, and the great weighty discussion of the evening and all of its implications in whiskey I could technically afford but was getting a cheap thrill from knowing I didn't have to actually pay for.

It's odd the way paying for, or not paying for, things, whether you can afford them or not, infuses them with some ill-defined quality that makes them more appealing, attractive, satisfying.

So it probably went with my wife, and Mr. Smith paying for *her*.

The fear that at times lay dormant and wet, and at other times slithered through my body, kept me from enjoying the show of my wife, in her orange-red dress, commanding the attention of every male in the room. Sure, Lilith was the same way, but Lilith was actually *too much*. April, on the other hand, with her austere, crisp beauty, and the fact that she didn't broadcast her status as the star of a porno, seemed to attract men to her, after they watched, were blinded by, and realized that Lilith was too much of everything.

April had beauty, and mystery.

She came over to the bar and stood next to me, so I slipped an arm around her slender waist and pulled her toward my face to kiss her ribcage through the material of her dress. April laughed. "What was that for?"

I was staring at her breasts with a goofy smile, unrepentantly. "Just being friendly."

April sat on my right thigh, and I steeled my leg so that I could support her. She is a lightweight person, but it was still uncomfortable as hell.

No matter! I told myself. It was all worth it to have April's firm bottom on the top of my thigh, the curve of her breasts right at the level of my mouth.

She leaned over and down a little, letting her hair swing away from her face, to get her mouth closer to my ear. "Did you talk to Lilith already? About the deal?"

My interest was piqued even more than before. It was one thing for April to be gently nudged along some path to stratospheric sluttiness by Lilith, but it was quite *something else* for April to be bringing it up, of her own accord, and not after returning to the privacy of our own home, but rather there, at that moment, at a bar.

"I did, as a matter of fact," I told her. I tried to cover up my enthusiasm with my Jovial-Thomas act.

April dismissed this act with a flutter of her eyes. "So?" she whispered, a reluctant smile flirting around on her lips. Her pulse quickened, visible above her shoulder blade, if only for a breathless moment.

When I didn't speak immediately, she put her hand to her nose. It was a gesture April used when she wanted to distract from something she was saying. "It's crazy, isn't it."

Her eyes, only for the briefest of moments, fluttered away from my face and out into the bar somewhere. They met whatever she was looking for - and I would never know for sure, but had to assume it was Lilith - and then returned to mine, limpid and un-telling.

I was gripped by a moment of terrifying vertigo, but it traveled through me with lightning speed.

"It's... well. Something," I said. I leaned back to get a better look at her face. "Is it something you'd think about doing?"

April put her hands in her lap, and for an extremely disturbing but also arousing moment, she looked appallingly young and a little bit like she was sitting on Santa Claus's lap, which the filthier, darker corners of my mind managed to take to a dirty and extreme ending within nanoseconds.

"It's just that..." she put her arm back over my shoulder, and I was both relieved and disappointed by the end of the dirty story playing out in my mind. "I mean... we *were* going to, you know... keep on doing... *things*. Weren't we?"

There was no point in even acting like I had some other answer than the one that my cock, attempting to flop like a beached whale beneath the pressure of April's bottom, must have given her. My heart was bursting at the seams, excitement shredding it in one direction, a vague sense of defeat or terror pulling it apart in another.

"I guess so," I said bravely, and my voice sounded odd to me, but it must not have to April.

April met my eyes again, having looked off into the intricacies of the ceiling during her Santa-Claus act.

Her incisor, a glassy-white dagger that was the only slightly crooked, and charmingly so, tooth in her mouth, peeked out to bite slowly into her lower lip as she contorted it with a hesitant tremble. "It's just that..." she said. "Lilith *has the keys*, you know. Here. Tonight."

I placed my hand on April's back and pushed her toward me, so that my lips grazed her red dress, and I could feel the heat of her skin against my lips through the fabric. "Of course she does."

I wasn't sure - and still am not, to this day - if I actually said that or not. April laughed, because my breath, whatever I was doing with it, had tickled her. Where her sternum ends, and her flesh becomes all soft, April is ludicrously ticklish, but only to the most feathery of touches.

I wondered, briefly and yet for all too long, how many other men knew that besides me.

Her arms had goosebumps and her eyes looked damp when I tilted my head up to her.

"Don't *do that*," she seethed. "I'm going to pee my pants."

She giggled some more, and then became serious. "So?" she asked suggestively.

So.

So...

"So..." I mumbled, pressing my face to her torso and inhaling the scent of her body.

"Do you want me to get the keys? And then we can just... you know... check it out?"

The next exchange between us would be one that I thought of often: how it was at once so like us, in our ordinary, married life, and how it was so bizarre at the same time. I didn't really answer, just moved my face around on her dress. Thomas, when confronted with suggestions from April

that were "fun" but which he wasn't really sure about, would sometimes do this.

April ruffled my hair and patted me like the silly puppy I was. And then she kissed the top of my forehead and strutted away, smiling.

It was the kind of scene that had played out between us before: April suggesting something, like a roller coaster, or a potluck, and me refusing to commit or de-commit to it. April, exasperated with my indecision, ruffling my hair and taking off to go set "it" in motion.

But this wasn't - literally, anyway - a roller coaster, or a potluck, or any of the things that I refused to play ball about. And so as she walked away, the confident strut of her step making her hair sway sensually, I had the sense of a sea change coming for me.

*

"Why are you here?" I asked Lilith, which only made her sniff derisively and take a sip of an expensive-looking drink she had sent Jake to make for her.

It was even less clear to me why Jake was there than why Lilith was there, because Lilith had already provided a plausible answer to this question before I had even asked it.

"Did you look at the closet?" Lilith asked me, after enough time had passed after my question to make it clear that she wasn't answering or changing the subject. She pointed at it with her drink in the same hand. "It's really something."

The apartment of "Mr. Greg Smith," wealthy voyeur, was actually a bit of a let-down. I didn't know what, exactly, I had expected the apartment of a man who could commission his own pornos to look like, but not this.

It was large, spacious, and had an expensive feel to it. An interior decorator had obviously had his way with it, and everything in it looked expensive. The art was probably real and valuable, and all the furniture had the appearance of rich-people furniture: the kind that you would never own, because it cost more than your house, and it just kind of radiated its stateliness from wherever it had been expertly placed by some very Feng-Shui type.

A wall of herbs, perfectly coiffed and watered, lined the kitchen, illuminated by the light of a grow light hidden cleverly enough that its provenance was unknown. The view of the city was expensive as well, and in this trendy neighborhood, every square foot of the place was worth forty times its value somewhere else.

But in the end, it was a *studio* apartment. Sure, the bed evidently went up into housing in the ceiling, a feat no one had bothered to prove by doing. I suppose I had expected more... space.

Lilith had not been willing to turn over the keys to us just yet. Being told "no" by Lilith is quite an experience. But she had pockets of extreme professionalism amid the blackness of her soul, and she couldn't just hand me the keys. "Unless you're willing to make a commitment, Thomas."

Jake had just come along, and he had the sort of personality that made it impossible to decline his self-invitation.

But now that we had seen the place, and the elaborate system for entering the building and opening the door and de-activating the alarm (all the details of which we would be given once we were "committed"), and now that we were just standing around having somebody else's cocktails in the apartment where my wife was going to fuck guys in exchange for jewelry, while another man watched and pretended she was *his* wife, it seemed a little weird to be there with Lilith and Jake.

April was seated on the bed, which was enormous, and Jake was leaning on the enormous window, telling her something that was making her laugh.

I sipped my drink. Lilith had poured the drinks, helping herself to Mr. Smith's well-stocked cocktail bar. They had large, round spheres of ice in them, which made me wonder what kind of arrangement rich people like Mr. Smith had for their housekeeping. Did some woman come in here and re-freeze his ice balls, or what? Water the plants, fluff the pillows? Keep every speck of dust out of the place?

"The closet?" I mumbled, my attention on April, who had her arms spread wide, was leaning back on the heels of her hands, and sat coquettishly in front of Jake, one foot turning circles lazily, her heel dangling from it.

"Yeah," Lilith said, her interest piqued suddenly. She set her drink down and grabbed my hand. "It's really cool," she said excitedly, pulling me

across the room.

"Voila," she said, after pushing against a wall with a large, framed mirror on it and causing it to click and pop out. The door swung slowly open, and a room that looked nothing like a closet glowed slowly to life as some kind of funky lighting around the top warmed up.

I stepped inside, and Lilith followed me, pulling the door closed behind her. There was a very comfortable chair, and a side table, and even a fridge. "Some closet," I said, not knowing what else to say.

When I turned around Lilith was standing to the side of the door, smiling like a wicked cat. In fact, when I recall this memory now, I often think of a tail swishing behind her, even though Lilith is obviously not an actual cat.

My eyes went up in surprise.

"Nice, huh?" Lilith said. She rolled into a turn and touched something in a console that she seemed to have a very good feel for, and the sound of April's laugh, and Jake's rambling, filled the small room.

But more importantly - the "nice" that my eyes had been indicating - the hung mirror on the door was a tasteful, framed, two-way mirror, and so one could sit in this comfy chair and watch whatever happened out there in minimalist luxury.

Lilith gave me a few moments to contemplate what all of this meant, and maybe she even would have allowed me to ask any of the questions that should have been burning in my mind.

Instead of any of those, I came up with: "Lilith, did you tell April I went to that club the other night?"

Her eyes glimmered for a moment, and she smiled one of her more infuriating smiles, saying nothing for a moment while she let me wonder.

"Whyever would I do *that*, Thomas?" Lilith's voice was next-level cloying.

"Well, that's kind of what I'm wondering. Why *wouldn't* you?"

Lilith grinned and switched off the intercom. For a startling moment, I wondered if it was a two-way device, and the conversation had been pumped into the room for April to hear.

"All I can take this to mean is that *you* didn't tell April that you went to the club, Thomas. So quid pro quo. Why are *you* sneaking around on your wife like that?"

I blinked slowly, because the question was a surprise, but also because I didn't have an answer.

"You first."

Lilith seemed to find something about this amusing as well. She tilted her chin, and looked contemplative for a moment, before shrugging. "I guess it just never came up."

"So you would have told her, if it had come up?" I said, my voice a little more demanding than I meant for it to be.

"Why would it come up, Thomas, do you think?" Lilith retorted. "But yes. If she asked me one day out of the blue, 'Was Thomas at *Zaouk Klub* that night?' then I would have to say yes." She pouted, her frown a hollow imitation of repentance. "I'm devastatingly honest."

"Lilith, what in the hell is your deal?"

"You said you'd answer *my* question, Thomas darling. So? Why are you sneaking around to watch your wife, and then not telling her about it?"

She waited, hand on the door handle, one leg stuck out to the side, her kooky parochial-wedding dress disturbingly alluring. I stood there like an idiot with my jaw hanging and no words leaving my mouth.

But Lilith didn't let this go on for long. Instead, she released the door handle and walked toward me, giving me the impression that certain death, or some other terrible fate, was coming my way. I was transfixed by her, by the all-powerful light in her eyes, by her tan, shiny skin overflowing from her costume.

She reached for my collar and lifted it so that it stood up. "I think," she said, stepping away to survey her handiwork, "that you *like* the idea of April *cheating* on you -"

"I do not," I protested immediately.

" - and so you *like* to set up situations like that one."

I jerked the collar down and glared at her. She smiled in return, stepping backward toward the door.

"I can help you out with that, Thomas. All you have to do is ask."

I was, for probably the first time in my life, so flabbergasted that not even my witty rejoinders of last resort came to my rescue.

Lilith turned and pushed on a secret spot to open the door, which clicked and popped open. "This latch is right here," she said, waving a hand over no particular part of the door. "So you don't lock yourself in." She

tossed her hair as she looked back at me. "Unless... you know, that's what you want."

"Lilith, what in the hell are you doing any of this for?" I said, exasperated.

Lilith stopped and turned fully around, pulling the door with her so that it was only open a crack.

"I'm not really the one doing anything, Thomas. Am I?"

She must have seen something in my eyes, because she quickly reached for me and patted me affectionately. "I like to bring people together so they can get what they want."

She looked at my reaction and her eyes flickered with amusement again. She patted me twice. "And the money."

"The money," I scoffed.

"Yeah," Lilith retorted, turning and pushing the door open. "The really, really good money."

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April turned around like she had just noticed that we weren't there. "Oh!" she exclaimed, and waited so long to say the next sentence that it seemed like it wasn't connected. "You showed him the closet, you know, room thing?"

Lilith just kept walking, and I saw her smile in a mirror across the room.

"I want to see it," April said, standing up. She hurried across the room and stood next to me. "Show it to me."

So we went inside, and I closed the door. I was still thinking about Lilith's accusation, or hypothesis, or whatever you wanted to call it. April was gazing all around at the expensive, and clearly single-purposed room. But she hadn't turned around to see the one-way glass.

"Wow," she said, dropping a hand to the chair. "This guy really has a thing for this. Lilith says he had this specially installed like, two days ago or something."

"Oh he did, did he?" I grumbled.

April turned quickly around and smiled at me. "What's that supposed to mean, Grumpy?"

Her eyes were on the glass, though. I stepped out of the way so she could see better, and she moved herself in front of the chair and plopped down. I went behind her, trailing my fingers over her shoulder, pulling her hair to one side. "Just, I'm guessing he did this without hearing back from you about whether you'd do it or not. It's a little presumptuous."

April rested her arms on the arm rests and tipped her head to look up at me. "I guess it is," she said, not at all displeased. Then she dropped her chin to look out the mirror into the room. "This is really something," she said, her voice almost a whisper.

I was leaning on the back of the chair now, my hand moving down her bare chest and running along the collar of her dress. From where I was standing, I could see her face, and the glazed look in her eyes - it was similar to how she had looked watching herself in her porno.

I think you like the idea of your wife cheating on you, Lilith's voice interrupted.

But the thought of my wife cheating on me, while it infuriated me, and I could say I categorically did *not* want that - *not really* - was making the tips of my fingers hot, and an anxious desire was clawing inside of me.

"So you're going to be okay with this?" April asked. "I don't really know how you'll be able to actually *watch*. I sort of thought there would be a place for you to... you know... hide."

I cocked my head to the side and moved my hand beneath the dress, stroking April's skin lightly. "Who says I have to do that?" I murmured. My fingers found the way to the ultra-soft skin of her areola, and then passed over her nipple, bringing it to life.

April tilted her head back to look up at me. Her mouth was in a smile, but it was the kind of smile she reserved for confused dogs and toddlers. She put a hand on my arm, stopping the motion of my fingers. "I thought you... you know, knew."

"Knew what?" I asked, moving my fingers a little.

April squirmed away from my grip and sat on the edge of the chair to turn her body and face me. "I thought you talked to Lilith," she said, uncertainly. She looked out into the room, and then back at me. I was shaking my head slowly.

"Lilith isn't exactly a fount of information and clarity," I told her.

April bit into her lower lip and looked at the back of the chair. She nodded vaguely, which I supposed meant that she agreed with my

assessment.

"It's just that... you know, you being there isn't really... like, I don't know... in the script."

"There's a *script*?" I shrieked.

April was not as taken aback by my tone or my question as I thought she would have ordinarily been. This could have been because April was no longer the same person I had married - her adventures had emboldened her, given her an air of confidence that she hadn't possessed before. She looked up at me.

"It's not so much a script," she said, "as a list of must-haves. I guess."

In her explanation, I could hear Lilith's coaching almost as certainly as if Lilith were sitting next to her, feeding her words, not even whispering.

"And they are?"

April looked at me with exasperation for a moment. But I could see that she almost immediately had another thought, and she changed her tone and her tack. She put a finger on the back of my hand and smiled. "He is *paying* for it, right?" she teased.

I found my voice somehow, and when I heard myself talking, I sounded like a really creepy weirdo. "What does it *say*? What are they?"

April laughed. "No one actually wrote them down."

I was sure that someone had, but I didn't want to quibble over something that would only impede April telling me what this Mr. Smith guy was going to demand that she do, with another man, as his prostitute.

"He wants two guys. And they have to be... black. Or... he would like them to be."

She waited for my response.

"Okay," I said. "What else?"

"Uh..." April looked a little uncomfortable. "He wants some... like me to say some things."

"Like?"

April was losing her cool. I thought she was going to be too embarrassed to say.

"Like... you know. How much bigger this guy is compared to my husband, how much I crave their cock... uh," she laughed nervously. "Kind

of... you know, saying this stuff *at the time* is so much easier than... you know. Here."

"Sure. Things you say while you're having sex are pretty strange outside of that context," I assured her.

But I was still hungry for more details. I also still had a pressing problem, and it was one that no one seemed to care about but me: this was all hot as hell, but I wanted to be in on watching. At a minimum.

"So," I said imperiously, "he doesn't seem to have a problem with, say, three guys. Why couldn't I be one of those?"

April blinked, her mouth falling open. The question seemed to have taken her aback. "I don't..." she said, and flapped her mouth uselessly.

"He doesn't know what I look like, right?"

April looked flummoxed.

At that precise moment, the door behind me clicked open, and Lilith came cascading into the small room in her layers of child-bride whoreishness. "Huh," she said. "I fully expected to catch you two doing it." She looked from April to me and then back at April. "Oh, what's going on here?" she complained.

April looked at her blankly. "Thomas was kind of... confused about... the logistics, I guess..."

"Always with that," Lilith sighed, turning to me. "What's the matter?"

"You didn't say anything to me about a script," I said angrily.

"What script?" Lilith asked, innocently.

"Just the... you know, requests," April offered helpfully.

Lilith's eye returned to my face. "Thomas, it's a *transaction*. Of course the man is going to have some requests. But what the hell is your problem with them? It's everything you like -"

"The problem, Lilith, is that I was under the impression that I would be watching, like I usually am."

"You do more than that, so I'm told," Lilith snorted.

I had no response to this, but that was fine, because Lilith didn't linger on it. She put a hand on my chest and moved her fingers in a dangerously arousing way. "Maybe this is just a new twist on things," she said sweetly. "You could maybe even think of it as... I don't know. Kind of like another fantasy. Where your wife is cheating on you." Her left eyelid

dropped in a plausibly deniable wink. "Some guys really get off on that, you know."

I could feel that the back of my neck was getting hot, and an unusual feeling of unease was brewing in my abdomen. For a moment I thought I would barf on Lilith, and that was actually kind of a fun thought.

It was unbearably hot in the room suddenly.

"Thomas," Lilith said, patting me with her hand, which had never left my chest. "If you're going to back out, now is the time. But I say, quit being such a fucking pussy, try something new, and also... am I going fucking crazy here or can someone just... call you on Facetime or something?" She made her pouty lips at me briefly and then erupted in a dangerous smile, her eyes glinting with the hawkish professionalism she had possessed when she had brought us the contract for the making of the porno. "I've made all parties agree to not *record* anything, which is just par for the course -"

"Par for the course?" I asked her.

Lilith rolled her eyes and continued. "But having some kind of unrecorded call going, provided it was done discretely, doesn't really fall under that definition."

"What is this?" a male voice said loudly. It was Jake, who had evidently gotten bored waiting for us. He whistled as he stood in the doorway, looking around the room. "I have to get back, Lilith, you ready to roll?"

"Always," Lilith said, without taking her hand, or her eyes off me.

April stood up, and edged past us toward the door. "We're all done," she told Jake.

Lilith's eyes were still on mine. She leaned close once April and Jake were headed back into the main room.

"Don't be a fucking pussy, Thomas. This guy is paying a lot of money to watch some guys bang a woman who looks like his wife. You just don't fit the bill." She looked me up and down. "*That* bill, anyway." She grinned at me and an uncomfortable heat started creeping down my spine. "But that doesn't mean you can't have fun, does it?"

"Maybe this isn't my idea of fun," I retorted.

Lilith kind of snorted - I say kind of, because it was a derisive and elegant sound. "I think it is, actually," she told me.

And then she walked out of the room. "*Don't* be a pussy, Thomas," she called over her shoulder, quietly enough that Jake and April would not have heard it.

CHAPTER 8

"If you don't want me to do it," April said, for the fifth time, "then I won't. Okay?"

I was driving. I really shouldn't have been, technically, but something had sobered me up. "That's not *it*, April," I said, exasperated.

"It kind of is," she countered, also for the fifth time. "I mean, Lilith can't control what this guy, you know, asked for -"

"Oh, I think Lilith could probably control whatever popped into her mind," I said testily. "But that isn't the point."

"So *what is?!?*" April said, exasperated. "Either say no, don't do it, or just... you know, stop being... I don't know. So wishy-washy."

Wishy-washy.

"I'm not being wishy-washy," I said, suddenly very serious.

"You are," April said. "You know what? It's driving me crazy." She fished her phone out of her purse and made like she was going to send a message. "I'll just tell Lilith that it's off."

I drove with both hands on the wheel, saying nothing, while April typed away.

My hand, acting almost entirely off the power of my reptilian brain, shot out and slapped the phone from her hand, without me taking my eyes off the road. "Just... wait a minute," I said, annoyed.

"Thomas!" April said, looking down at the phone like I had just crushed a baby squirrel with my bare hands.

"Sorry," I said, and April glared at me as she picked up the phone and rubbed it on her thigh. "That was... unnecessary. Just. Just wait a minute, I need to think."

April folded her arms over her chest. "Forget it. I think if this is making you... slap phones out of my hand, it's gone too far. Okay? I'll just tell Lilith to forget about it."

She started to type again.

"Fine," I said, as casually as though it were totally *fine*. I gripped the steering wheel.

This was good, right? It was what I wanted. It was what we had agreed on, albeit vaguely, when we began this whole adventure. That if

anything made either one of us uncomfortable, or we started fighting, or having bad feelings about any of this, then we needed to stop.

So this was good.

I was having bad feelings, and April was stopping.

"Fine," I repeated.

April put the phone face down on her thigh. "Well, you don't *seem* like it's fine."

I sighed audibly. "April, Jesus. All I said was, I need a little bit of time to *think*."

"So you don't want me to send this message to Lilith."

"Just... not at this moment. Maybe. Maybe not. I need some time to think."

April became quiet, shaking her head and looking out the window.

At some point, without saying anything more, she picked up the phone and did something with it - but she didn't say anything about it, and then dropped her phone neatly into her purse and continued to look the other way.

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We filed into the house still not talking to each other. It hadn't been a really long drive, but April hadn't said anything, and she seemed to be fuming. I hadn't had enough time to think about what was really bothering me - other than not being able to watch like I wanted to. Or about why, if that was really my only problem here, why I didn't just let April send that text message and call the whole thing off.

Or why - if I let myself believe that she had done just that in the car - I didn't like that solution.

It wasn't really what I wanted.

April headed straight for the bedroom.

It was about this time that Lilith sent *me* a text message.

Thomas are you serious?

I heard the shower water start down the hall in the en-suite.

What's that supposed to mean?

I didn't expect to get an answer back from Lilith, because she seemed to text with the attention span of a five-year-old. She'd be off doing something dangerous and fun and forget all about Thomas and the text she had sent him.

I was surprised, instead, to get a call from her.

I answered it and didn't say hello or anything at all. This seemed to be something Lilith had expected, because she just jumped in.

"Are you serious," she said, like our conversation had begun hours ago. "About telling April she can't do this?"

"Maybe," I said.

I could have sworn that I could hear Lilith rolling her eyes over the phone. Some Latin music was on in the background, and I could hear several voices, a lot of laughter, and what sounded like a risqué after-hours party going on, probably at *Habanero*.

"Thomas, you're putting me in a sticky situation, which is fine, that's your prerogative. But I can't help but call and try to talk you out of being such a bull-headed ass, because I sincerely think you're doing it for *all* the wrong reasons."

"I'm doing it because it's not... what I wanted," I hissed, one ear cocked for the sound of the shower.

Lilith laughed. "Does April know you're talking to me right now?"

"What?" I stammered. She had an accusatory, know-it-all tone to her voice that sent a flash of red-hot anger through my temple. "That's... what are you... she doesn't *not* know, like I'm not hiding it from her..."

"Blah blah blah," Lilith said, talking over the last half of my sentence. "Do you see, this is exactly what I'm talking about, Thomas. You sneaked *into a club to watch your wife hook up with some guy, and then you didn't tell her about it*. And now, you made her text me - *text me, Thomas* - to wimp out on something I had all arranged. Something beneficial for everyone -"

"That's just it, Lilith," I said, highly annoyed. "It's not beneficial for *everyone*, since it's not what I want."

"This is what I'm trying to explain to you, Thomas." Lilith's voice turned into her gravelly, sexy, cadence, the voice I was starting to see she used to get whatever she wanted. That voice felt like sandpaper being drawn ever-so-gently over my balls. "It *is* exactly what you want. Isn't it?"

What you would really like, more than anything, is for April to tell you she's not going to do it, but then for her to, oops! do it. You would like that, wouldn't you Thomas? What you really want is for me to convince April to do it anyway, even though you've told her not to. Because you didn't really mean that you didn't want her to do it. You just didn't want to give her permission to do it."

My cock was ferociously hard after this little conversation, and I stood there with the phone to my ear and my jaw slack.

"Lilith -"

"Thomas." Lilith's voice was still softly grating on my balls, dangerous and unrelenting, making me hard and making me angry. "Your real fantasy would go just like that. Just admit it."

I laughed sharply. "And how would you know what -"

"Know what you want?" Lilith chirped. "That's *what I do*, Thomas. Now, please - " Lilith interrupted herself to purr like a cartoonish sex kitten in a b-grade porno, "Save one of those for me," she said.

I was about to respond, and just realizing she hadn't been talking to me, just as her attention came back to her phone. "Just let me work my magic, Thomas. You tell your wife not to do it, and I'll tell her *to do* it, and then we can all sit back and enjoy."

"What?" I hissed. "Lilith, this is... crazy."

"You know what, Thomas, sleep on it. Better yet, lay in bed and think about it. Think about what it would be like laying in bed and waiting for April to come home after I talked her into becoming a whore and going against your wishes."

"God," I said, unable to think of anything else to say.

Lilith laughed. "Bye, Thomas."

I stared at my reflection in the kitchen window, long after Lilith had disconnected the call. The shower was off, as far as I could tell. I could hear my own blood pounding in my ears again, as well as the rasp of my own heavy breathing.

I walked down the hallway, not sure what I was going to do when I got there. I'm not sure why I began to creep there, hoping to see April without her seeing me.

She was sitting on the edge of the bed, a towel wrapped around her body, hair loosely wrapped in another. The towel on her torso was slipping, her legs were stretched out, and she was perched at the very edge of the

bed, twisted at an odd angle toward the night table. Her phone was in her hand, and she was typing with one thumb, absorbed in the conversation, having obviously reached for the phone in excitement, coming straight out of the shower.

She typed, and smiled, and then bit into her lower lip, her finger hovering over the send button. This moment seemed to last forever, but she finally sent it, and then set the phone down.

Her hands went to the towel on her head, to adjust it, as it was slouching to the side. I hadn't moved, or probably even breathed, but she turned to me as though I had stepped on a branch in the dead of night.

I began walking toward the room at a normal pace, hoping she wouldn't notice that I had been standing there.

"You scared me," she said, putting a hand to her chest.

"Who were you texting?" I asked jovially.

April pulled the towel from her head and let her wet hair fall about her shoulders. She very slowly pulled it around one shoulder and looked at the ends, a strange look on her face. She surprised me by tossing herself onto the bed, wriggling to rest on her stomach. The towel around her body came loose, and hiked up to the middle of her bottom, so her creamy skin was peeking out alluringly, tipped up slightly because of the angle she was lying on the bed.

"I'm in a little bit of a dilemma," she said. Her blue eyes had a particularly purple hue to them at that moment, and her cherubic face was scrubbed freshly clean, giving her an incongruously innocent appearance.

The effect made me dizzy. "A dilemma," I repeated. I didn't bother to say "what about?" because she knew that I knew what it was about.

April stretched her arms out in front of her, and then stretched the rest of her body, seemingly unaware of how maddeningly sexy she looked while she did that. But her face did not match these sentiments: in her eyes, a non-innocent, fully aware spark glimmered. "Lilith tells me," she began, her voice sexily ambiguous, "that I should just make a date with Rog and Jonny, and not tell you about it."

I unbuttoned my shirt, heat radiating from all sorts of strange places on my body. "She does, does she?"

I cast the shirt off, and April rolled fully onto her stomach to rest her chin on her hand and look up at me. Her eyes were imploring, big and damp, the picture of naive, sweet April Snow, the clean and pure April I'd

believed I had married. But on her lips twitched the smile of the lurking porn star she had become.

"She does. She says you don't understand what you want. And that you'll thank me for it later."

April rose up onto her knees and let the towel fall down around her hips. Her skin was fresh and still damp in places from the shower, her nipples pebbled in the cool air. A little river of water snaked from her hair over the curve of her breast, and then lingered on the small nub of her right nipple, before coalescing into a droplet, sparkling for a moment, and spilling over into the center of her chest.

"She says all that," I said dully, staring at my wife.

"She does," April said.

She edged closer to me on the bed. Her hand dropped to my belt, and she slowly unthreaded it from the buckle with one hand while she stared me in the eye. She unbuttoned and unzipped my jeans, and tugged at my boxers so that my cock could spring loose. She closed her hand - warm and damp - around me, and squeezed, as she leaned in close enough for our lips to touch, without actually kissing me. "And I think she's right."

She held on to me as my cock throbbed in her hand. I felt precum ooze from the tip, slippery against her skin as my crown grazed her forearm. I knew that the veins of my cock were straining against April's palm, that she could feel in her hand that there was an undeniable measure of truth to what she was saying.

"She told me to just do it," April said. She tipped her head and looked down at my cock, releasing her firm grip on me and moving her fingers lightly over the length of shaft. She watched as my cock bounced and flexed, a lie detector test of sorts. She seemed enthralled by it. She swirled her finger over the crown and brought her hand to her lips. I could see a smear of pearly cum glistening on the tip of her middle finger.

I shook as she closed her lips around her finger and sucked off the cum.

"So what... what's the uh, dilemma...?" I stammered.

April smiled. "Well," she said. "Do I listen to Lilith, who seems to be right about everything else? Or do I listen to what you're *saying*?"

This question would have been a great deal easier for me to answer had I been able to think of what I had been saying, or anything at all, besides April's lips and the way they had closed over her fingers.

I stared at her, and didn't say anything.

"She says to do it, and lie to you," she said, leaning forward to kiss me on the neck. Her hand moved down to my cock again, and she grasped it as her lips dragged over my shoulder and then back to my neck, down my torso, stopping to kiss my chest along the way. She had to walk herself back on her knees as she kissed me lower and lower, and her ass ended up propped up in the air.

Finally she reached my pubic bone, and then poised her lips just in front of the tip of my cock as she stroked me with her firm hand. I could feel her breath on the head of my dick as she spoke.

"So what do you think?" she asked, pulling on me until my dick grazed her lower lip. She continued to stroke me, and I stared, helpless to move or think, trying to tamp down the burgeoning orgasm I could feel coming within seconds. "Should I let you think I told him no, and go get my brains fucked out by Rog and Jonny again...?" she closed her lips around my cock and swirled her tongue around as she sucked hard on just the very tip.

I groaned and lifted my hand to her head. My fingers clutched her hair and I pulled hard, almost subconsciously, because I was trying to delay coming, or maybe salvage some measure of dignity, of self-determination, of not being utterly enslaved by her every slutty word.

She released me from her mouth, licking slowly at my cock while she stared at it, watching the precum ooze, her hand tightening at the base, which thankfully stopped what had seemed like an imminent orgasm.

"Or should we just stop while we're ahead?"

Her tongue left her mouth and swiped over my cock. I groaned and gripped her head harder. Her knees were folded underneath her, her bare ass up, visible in a small mirror over the dresser, her drenched pussy glistening between her legs.

"Fuck," I said. "April..."

April smiled just before she took my cock into her mouth, sucking it back into her throat, her tongue swirling around my shaft in ways I could not understand.

It was seconds before I came, and April, a wife who hadn't traditionally given a whole lot of head to her husband, swallowed my cum with the expertise of a street hooker.

Then she tossed herself back on the pillows and stretched her body out beautifully for me. I was panting, dizzy, hypnotized, my mouth getting dry because it was hanging open. I could feel the skin on my forehead bunched up in an expression of utter, hopeless confusion.

April spread her legs a little and drew her elegant fingers down to her slit. This was something she had never done - not in our years of monogamous marriage, not in a porno, not on any part of this wild ride.

I stared at her fingers as she deftly rubbed her clit with a practiced motion, looking at me, smiling her new, hot, and utterly terrifying smile.

My cock started to come back to life, a real middle-aged miracle.

"So," April said, a hitch in her voice, the marker of her own excitement. "What do we do?"

Her pointer finger slowed its rapid rhythm on her clit, and she peeled her labia open so I could see her pussy in all of its engorged detail, her finger swimming in her excitement. A throb in my cock almost sent me keeling over.

What was the question? I wondered, as I fell forward onto my hands and knees, and crawled toward my wife, who was spreading her legs wide, drawing her wet fingers along her torso, up to her head. Who could answer any question put to them this way, in any other way than the way that I did?

I sank into April's hot, wet body, and she wrapped her legs around me.

"Do you want to fuck Jonny and Rog again?" I breathed in her ear.

She smiled, I could feel it on the side of my face. She smiled because she knew that I wanted her to say it, that when she did my cock would swell inside of her and burst.

Her lips moved over my cheek, her voice grew strained as she was gripped by another orgasm. Her heels were digging into my lower back as she growled, in a feline staccato that by itself might have made me come:

"I want to fuck them again. And I want to get paid for it."

I was in the middle of an orgasm so intense that I have no idea now if she said this or not. But I think she did, after she bit into my shoulder hard enough to leave a bruise, and her pussy sucked at my cock, and her body went rigid as she went over the edge.

"Because I can."

CHAPTER 9

"So?" April asked me, posing in the doorway with her hands on the frame. She gave her hair a toss, and jutted her chin, a combination of gestures and movements that looked like a cubist copy of Lilith. She was wearing her black cocktail dress, the one that hadn't made the cut for Zaouk Klub. So she should have looked much like herself, but with a little bit of garnish.

But she didn't. Again, I stared at her, and scanned her, looking for the details that made this April different from the April I had married. Could it be something as simple as a shade of lipstick? There was some range of purple-red that hinted at hookers and sex-crazed cougars in basement bars, but she wasn't wearing it. Her hair was slick and smooth, shiny, and perhaps that was it: it had the glossy, expensive appearance of an expensive escort? But April's hair always looked like that. Were her eyelashes thicker? Her heels higher? Or was it in the tilt of her chin, the puckish smile she was giving me? The fact that she stalked toward me with her confidence notched up just ever-so-slightly, just enough to make her swagger in a way that only I could notice?

Or was it all in my head?

She walked toward me and smiled, and her look had a dusting of the predatory in it. My heart, as it had been doing lately and which I suspected was probably not-so-good, throbbed and turned to a chunk of ice, before warming again and fluttering arrhythmically. She was lifting her skirt when I remembered to breathe.

"The dress isn't very racy," she was purring, as I stared at her, still trying to figure out who she was, and when everything had gone sideways, "because I figure, Jonny and Rog are a sure thing." The dress was above her thighs now, so that I got a glimpse of the band of black lace that held her stockings tight to her thighs. She continued to pull on the dress, until her underwear were revealed.

Pretty, lacy, in places transparent. I stared. She was moving her right leg as she did this, folding it outward, opening her legs.

As she did, as I was wondering why, it became apparent. The glistening pink of her pussy peeked through a seam in the panties. My heart went icy again, dropping through my chest to my balls, and blood rushed

inexplicably to my ears, where it pounded so loudly I could barely hear her words over my own pulse.

Her fingers fluttered over the seam, grazing her pink gash, and then the curtain fell on the whole thing.

I wondered if my face looked like it felt, like a puppy someone had ceased to throw a ball for.

"You like them?" she said, her voice a sticky, whiskeyed throb beneath the hum in my ears.

My hands went out to her hips, and I pulled her down to my lap. She went willingly, her laugh a lilting, teasing sound that meant nothing to me at all: April, my wife, had laughter that warned me off, laughter that said she had no time to play with me, laughter that invited or gave in, but this laugh was none of those things. This was the laughter of April Snow, porn star and kinky prostitute.

My hands were making their way up her skirt, and I expected her to try and stop me. She couldn't mess up her make-up, she wouldn't want to do anything to her new, crazy panties. She held on to my shoulders and leaned back, her eyes full of mirth and mischief, disturbingly reminiscent of Lilith.

Well. Maybe in retrospect. I honestly wasn't thinking much at that point.

She leaned close to me, her painted lips inches from my mouth, something foreign in the way she was talking to me that let me know she was a little like a stripper, and I wasn't meant to kiss her. Her breasts, cradled in the expensive black material, drew my eyes to them, and I felt the heat of her body on my chin.

She moved her lips just centimeters from my skin, never touching me, until they were close to my ear. "I don't see why," she whispered, her breath traveling down the whole side of my face and my shoulder like fingernails raking on my back, "it would be out of character if Mr. Smith's wife showed up with a pussy full of cum before she even got home. Do you?" Then she leaned back again to assess my reaction. Another toss of her hair, as she leaned back and stretched her long neck open to me. "Just don't mess up my makeup," she said, her voice a mixture of serious warning and mirth.

As she hung on to me, my hands went into action, fumbling to unbutton and hastily jerk down my pants. April watched, her arms draped

on my shoulders, the faint smile on her lips disappearing, replaced by an open, hungry mouth when my cock swayed, freed at last, above my lap.

There were things, I realized, that I could imagine doing to my wife, that I wanted to do but simply couldn't. They flashed through my head in quick succession as I stared at her open mouth, at her tongue as she ran along her upper teeth, a wild glimmer in her eyes.

And then her thighs squeezed against my hips, and she rose up using this force as leverage, edging her pussy, encased in her slitted panties, toward my cock. I helped lift her a little, staring at her face as I felt the soft needlework of the lace, the rough mesh of the transparent part of her underwear, and then the soft, juicy, dripping flesh of her pussy graze over the head of my dick. She paused, her silky hair slipping from behind her shoulders and falling toward me, grazing my cheek, before she sank, ever so slowly, onto my lap, her cunt engulfing me in her superheated nectar.

The truth is that I don't think I lasted very long from that moment: April had set the cum in my balls to boil the moment she showed me that slit, and from there, it had all been an effort to keep from ejaculating before I was even inside of her.

She ground against me, her head tipped back, a warbled mewl building in her throat. I came and she kept on going, which was torture, but a very sweet kind, and my cock stayed hard for her as she bounced her way to a smutty, open-mouthed, panting, orgasm. I winced and gripped her hips tightly as her pussy clenched around me, and then seemed to turn to pure liquid, with a spasming softness cuffed around it. Her come, mingled with mine, seeped from inside of her and trickled into my boxers and over my balls.

April panted at the ceiling for a moment, her pussy still pulsing around me, before tipping her head forward and leaning over my face as though she was going to kiss me.

But she put a finger on my lips instead. It was the one she had dragged through her gash and I tasted the flavor of her cunt when I pressed my lips together. She smiled. "That's perfect," she said. "I think he'll get a kick out of it. I'll make sure to have Jonny point it out."

The hand was her left hand, she moved it to her own mouth to tidy up her lipstick. Her words, as unbelievable as it might sound, had stabbed me straight through the heart. My cock throbbed inside of her.

This was a woman who had sucked a stranger's cock under the table at a restaurant, I reminded myself, staring at her hand, a feeling of blinding-cold jealousy creeping over my shoulders and closing around my neck, searing through the back of my head and blurring my vision. A woman who had let Jonny fill her ass with anal beads that she wore all night, a woman who had let two guys fuck her until every orifice was overflowing with their cum. So why would this, of all things, drive me so wild?

It was *my* cum that would give Jonny a sloppy, sloshing ride.

I stared at her hand. My own hand snatched it before my brain even knew what I was doing, or why.

"What the hell?" I stammered.

My cock was still inside of her, and she rolled forward again, her hot flesh squeezing the underside of my cock, cum spilling over my balls. She flipped the back of her hand toward me, making a funny face. "Can you believe this guy?" she said, carelessly, her tone a true emissary of her utter cluelessness. "He wants me to wear this, it's a replica of his wedding ring."

The ring was huge, the diamond, it seemed to me, real. A fucking huge, gigantic, stone. Tacky. Nothing that would have appealed to a girl like April.

She tipped her head to the side as she draped her arm over my shoulder. "It's part of the deal," she said. Then she laughed and slipped from my cock as she scooted back and put her feet down. "I hope it's not real," she said, fingering it the way she fingered her own wedding ring. "I would be too freaked out about losing it." She smiled, and then mused. "Do you think I'd have to work it off?"

She was standing, smoothing her dress, looking at the ring.

I was falling, falling from the edge of the earth, into an abyss of my own making, and my mouth was open, useless, flapping in the wind.

"Thomas," she said, ruffling my hair. "I won't *actually* lose it."

She leaned down to me and moved her mouth in front of mine, without kissing me. "Jonny's going to try and get the whole thing for you, but we have to do it sort of... surreptitiously. So wish me luck."

"Good luck."

At least I think I said that.

And then she was gone, and the question I had really wanted to ask was left like lingering smoke in my mouth, bad taste and all.

What did you do, April, with *your* wedding ring?

*

It wasn't what I had envisioned, I realized.

Had I really ever envisioned anything *this* depraved, though?

I'll admit that my imagination, even when I had let it run at its most wild, had never gone to these extremes.

I'm here. At the bar, that is.

Waiting for Jonny and Rog

What do you write back to that?

My thumbs hovered uncertainly over the screen of my phone.

Perhaps I would have known what to write to April, my wife, months ago, before any of this had ever happened. But the April of commissioned pornos and "dates" that were essentially prostitution? I hadn't a clue what to say to her.

Good luck?

Have fun?

No drugs?

I love you

I wrote this and hesitated before sending it, but I finally did.

Somewhere in the low orbits above earth, my message crossed paths with April's next message, like two ships in the night. She sent me a selfie taken with Jonny, a smug look of satisfaction on his face - he was too cool to smile - and April's lips on his cheek. Her left hand was strewn over his shoulder blade, the diamond that was not April's gleaming on her finger.

It bothered me that they had gone to a bar to meet first. I wondered what that sort of meeting was like, what they talked about, how many drinks they had. What kind of working relationship did these three "sex workers" have amongst themselves? And was it just "professional?"

It felt like something much more sinister was at work between Jonny and April, but I reminded myself that I only had this feeling when I

was at home, alone, waiting on April to return from Jonny's clutches.

And so, in fact, it was a feeling I had basically flagged down on the highway and held at gunpoint.

Sebo, my buddy, took huge pains to keep people from knowing that he was Chicano while we were growing up, because we didn't grow up in a "diversity is great" kind of neighborhood. People still said *spic* loudly in the grocery store, or to describe someone to the police or a friend. Sebo probably employed it more than anyone else.

But in the end, it was impossible to hide the fact that he spoke Spanish at home.

Anyway, that's why I know that in Spanish, you don't say "you reap what you sow."

It's something like, "if you plant wind, you reap storms."

Which really seemed more like the proverb I deserved.

Like any storm, there was first a long, boring wait in a still landscape tingling with electricity and the scent of impending disaster. I poured myself a drink and watched the slow and unstoppable course of the minute hand on a weird analog cat clock April loved, until it became too cartoonish and I began to watch the ceiling.

How long would it be before somebody called me? I had my phone in my hand, my drink at the ready, and the pain inside of me was, like the pain of holding your breath, worse with every second and also something I didn't think I could survive for one more second.

I was slipping back into dark places: April would deliberately fail to call me, or Jonny would talk her out of it, or perhaps that had all happened a long time ago. She would get so caught up in the moment that she would just run off with her two – or more- lovers and I would never see her again.

I was in the middle of a morbid fantasy, in which April simply never came home, when the phone in my hand at last rumbled.

It was difficult to discern what was happening at first, because the camera was blocked off by someone's body. I could hear April's new laughter - the quivering, reckless giggle of a woman I didn't know - and the low but unintelligible voice of Rog.

"This is a sweet place," Jonny commented, and I realized he was the one arranging the phone.

"My husband has a lot of money," April said, her voice strange and theatrical, the voice of her porn star persona.

The camera cleared, and I saw Jonny walking away. His shirt was off, the black shapes of the tattoos on his back coming into focus. He stopped, blocking the view of a bed for a moment.

"Pretty cold, don't you think?" This was Rog, also sounding unlike himself.

There was a pause, and movement in front of Jonny. April's hair, being tossed in the air. Her feet, still encased in her devastating shoes, on the bed. I wondered if Jonny was standing in the way of this scene conscious of how he was blocking my view, just to be a jerk.

As if he read my thoughts, he moved, painfully slowly, to the right.

My wife came into view. She was on her knees on the bed, her legs spread apart slightly, pulling up the sides of her dress, working it like a stripper. "He's rich," she said, "but money can't buy you everything."

Rog made a sound, one I had heard before, a low rumble of approval. "Mmhmm. And what happens if your hubby comes home and finds you here with my dick in your ass? Hmm? What then?"

"He's away on business," April purred. "Anyway, I'll tell him," she said, bringing her ring finger to her lips. "You didn't know anything about me being married." She closed her lips around her finger like she was taking a cock into her mouth and pulled the ring off with her teeth. Then she tossed it at Rog, who caught it.

April smiled. "Don't lose it," she told him, pulling her dress up over her head.

Jonny had moved back into the scene and was unzipping his pants. He let his jeans fall and beckoned to April with a crooked finger. April dropped to her hands and knees and started to crawl toward him. Rog moved around the bed and behind April, his eyes on her ass, lower lip sucked up under his teeth.

"You want some of this?" Jonny said, edging closer to the bed. His dick was in his hand, though I couldn't see it.

As April crawled forward, she looked up at him. For a second she looked nothing at all like herself, and I experienced a disorienting bout of

vertigo: I was watching porn, I had dipped too deep into my imagination and this is what I had brought up from the depths.

And then another dizzying fall as April smiled, and it was clear that it *was* her.

Was Mr. Smith's experience any different than mine? *This* April only looked like his wife, was paid to act like his wife. April was my wife, but *this* woman was someone else to me.

The April who had let Jonny gently tug her into cheating on her husband was gone, though. This April reached for Jonny's cock, still looking at him, and turned her head as she lowered it, disappearing behind his body so that all I could see was her torso, her tits swinging slightly as she bobbed on Jonny's cock, her back arched, her legs encased in their sexy thigh-highs.

"Oh fuck, honey. Yeah, baby, you know what you're doin, Jesus, yeah, suck on my balls, you little slut, yeah, that's it."

Rog, meanwhile, was climbing behind her, reaching for her ass, turning his hand palm-up, fingers cupped into a hook. "You see these panties, man?" he said to Jonny. But he was immediately distracted, not even really finishing his sentence, as his fingers dipped into April's cunt.

Perhaps it was only my imagination, because the audio didn't seem that great, but I thought I heard the sticky plunge of his hand into her pussy.

"You already fuck somebody before you come here?" Rog asked. He lifted his hand to his face and sniffed at his fingers. "You dirty little slut. Her pussy's already full of cum. Who'd you fuck, you little slut? Hmm? Not your husband, he's out of town." Rog put his hand back and pushed roughly into April's pussy.

She released Jonny's cock with a wet slurp and panted, flipping her hair to turn back and look at Rog. "Oh," she moaned, her hips pushing back against him.

Rog grinned. "You like that, huh? Yeah? You like this?"

It wasn't clear what he was doing to her, as his thick forearm pushed forward and flexed. I was left to imagine, as my wife mewled and squirmed, pushing her ass back against him, how much of his hand Rog had shoved inside of her, and what he was doing with his fingers - clawing at her g-spot? fucking her with two fingers while rubbing his thumb over her clit? Slipping a finger into her ass? Fisting her pussy? - was a mystery to me, but I let my imagination run wild as April howled.

Jonny reached for her and tipped her chin back toward him. "Don't forget what you're working on here, baby." He pushed his fingers into her hair and tilted her head as he did, pulling on the roots, which he held in his fist to keep her head tilted as he crammed his cock into her mouth again.

Rog was watching his own hand with fascination for a few moments, the sticky sound of his finger-fucking crackling in the air, between the hungry mewls and wet slurps of April swallowing Jonny's cock.

I couldn't see what he was doing, but in a way it was even more deliciously painful like that: knowing that April could swallow his whole cock, hearing the *gluck* each time his fat crown struck the wet back of her throat.

"Hey man, slow down a little, don't make her come just yet," Jonny said. "I don't want her biting... me... yeah baby, keep on sucking it, suck all that cum up and then you can have a nice treat. You gonna swallow for me?"

I heard April's gasping as she released his cock and took several wet breaths, before going to work on Jonny again. Rog had his hand in her pussy, but he had slowed his rhythm, and his eyes were now on April sucking Jonny's cock.

I heard Jonny inhale sharply, saw the muscles of his back contract. "Shit, oh fuck, that's so good, you suck cock like a fucking whore, baby, keep going, suck it right out..." he inhaled again, and April's tits bounced as she worked hard on his dick, her head hidden behind his clenched ass.

Jonny groaned and pushed April's head into his groin, tipping his head back as his seed filled her throat. He grunted, clutching her head to his pelvis, jerking into her face, as several final squirts left him, a shudder traveling through his body all the while.

Rog reached forward and pulled April away from him by the hair, setting her on her heels like a limp rag doll. He clamped her cheeks with his free hand and pushed her jaw open, peering into her mouth. He said nothing, only grinned, and tossed April back on her hands and knees.

"You want some of this cock now, little girl? Hmm?" Rog asked her.

April flung her hair again, and kicked up her heels behind her, twisting her ankles above the bed. It was a playful, slutty gesture, an invitation for Rog to not only give her some of his cock, but whatever else

he came up with. I couldn't see her face, only her hair, and her playful feet, as she rolled back and forth on her knees and her hands.

"You gotta beg me for it, you little slut."

"I want it," April said, her voice breathless, convincingly whoreish. I had never heard anything like it outside of professional porn. "Please, I want your big cock, I need it."

I swallowed for the first time in several minutes, and my throat had a lump in it, and was dry as a bone. My cock was hard, dripping cum into my sweats, and a bead of sweat rolled from my temple into my eye. For a second, I wondered if I was about to have a heart attack: I had been so absorbed in what I was watching that I hadn't paid any attention to my heart, which I could feel beating in my chest, too fast to be doing its job.

April was pushing her ass back toward Rog, who placed his hands on her butt and pushed her cheeks apart. Real or imagined, the sticky sound of April's wet pussy lips, sticky with my cum, with her own excitement, tore through the electronic hum that dominated the audio.

"Hold that ass for me, baby. Get those hands up and spread it all open," Rog said, in his smooth voice, as he used his hands to undress himself. Jonny had disappeared, maybe to a chair off to the side. Maybe he was standing, like he often did, stroking his cock, getting it ready for April's insatiable pussy again.

April had lowered herself to the bed, ass in the air, and had her buttocks cupped in her hands. Rog stared at her as he slowly removed his clothes, a hungry, disdainful look in his eyes.

"I was really lookin' forward to getting some fresh pussy, you know that?" Rog growled, after shaking his boxers down his legs. He had dropped all of his clothing but his tie - Rog, unlike Jonny, had been wearing a shiny, expensive suit. He wound the tie around his hand with a sinister expression on his face, but didn't do anything with it just then. His other hand dropped to his cock, and guided it to April's slit.

He swiped her gash with the head of his cock, making April mewl. "Tell me you're sorry, you little slut. Sorry you were such a slut and you had to get your pussy all fucked full of cum."

"I'm sorry," April panted. "I just couldn't stop myself."

"What are you gonna do to make up for it?" Rog asked her, still moving his cock in the folds of her pussy.

April howled. She moved her ass toward him, and I saw her feet twist. "Please. Please, I just want your big cock inside me. I need it. I want you to fuck me, I'll beg you for it."

"What you gonna do," Rog repeated slowly, "to make up for getting your pussy all dirty before I got to get my dick wet? Hmm?"

"Whatever you want," April moaned. "I'll do whatever you want, if you just give it to me."

Rog chuckled and looked over to where, I guessed, Jonny was watching. I heard the low rumble of his laugh.

"Your husband know what a slut you are?"

April moaned again.

"You want me to fuck your dirty pussy with my big black cock, baby?" Rog asked. "Yeah, you do. But I want you to say it."

"I want you to fuck my pussy, please, I want it."

"I'm gonna fuck your pussy til you come, just like you want. And then I'm gonna fuck this tight little ass, because I think you need to learn a lesson, don't you?"

April mewled.

"Let me hear you say it," Rog told her. "Get that hand back up there, spread that ass open, I want to look at what I'm gonna hit, yeah that's it. I like that. Now let me hear you say please."

"Please," April begged, her ass moving in a circle as she held it open for Rog. "I want it, I want your big cock..."

"You want me to make you come?"

"I want you to fuck me until I come," April moaned.

"And then what are you gonna do?"

"I'm going to take it in the ass."

"You're gonna like it, too, aren't you?"

"Yes."

"Mm-hmm," Rog murmured, pushing himself forward. He dropped his hands to April's wrists, and held onto them as he slowly fucked her squelching pussy.

April howled, and squirmed, and Rog took his time, slowly fucking her as she tossed her head on the bed. Her whimpering rose and fell, became a shrill trill, and then she smashed her face into the bed and screamed as the sticky kisses of her pussy changed to sloshing, sloppy smacks with her cum added to the mix.

"Now I'm gonna fuck that ass," Rog told her.

"It's too big," April panted. "I can't take it in my ass."

"Oh, you can do it baby. And you're gonna do it, just like you promised me you would. Hmm? Kick those heels up, I like to see that."

Rog unfurled the tie that he had twisted around his hand, which I had forgotten about, with a quick snap, as April kicked her heels up toward her ass. Rog jerked her backward by the hips, then pushed her legs wide, and wrapped the tie around her right ankle and thigh, pulling it hard to tighten it, eliciting a throaty yelp from April.

"Mmm, I like that," Rog murmured, holding April's left heel in his hand, pushing that leg against her thigh. His right hand dropped between his legs and April's. April's bound foot twisted, and she mewled into the sheets as Rog began pumping his fingers into her ass.

"Oh hell, that's nice. That's gonna feel *real* good on my cock," Rog mumbled, after a few minutes of mesmerized finger-fucking. "You gonna be a good girl and take it?"

"Yes," April panted, turning her head to the side.

I could see his impressive dick as he withdrew it from April's cunt with a slippery kissing sound. Rog had already enjoyed my wife in every hole, and I had seen him do it close-up, literally within smelling distance, but the size of his dick inspired a brief sense of awe nonetheless: crisscrossed veins strained against its gnarled form as he lined it up with April's tiny eyelet.

"Get up on those hands, baby," Rog instructed her. "You're all slippery, don't want you slippin' away."

April obeyed Rog, as she always did, without reluctance. She flipped her hair to look behind her, precariously balanced on her kneecaps, heels floating at the sides of her hips. Rog grinned down at her as he moved his pelvis.

"Oh!" April squealed. "Oh my... oh, it's so... it's too... it's too big... it's so big... oh!"

"Look at her, she's bucking back at you like a bronco," Jonny said from off-screen. And she was. April may have been protesting – beautifully – her voice a sexy falsetto of curse-less protestation, perhaps you could say it was April's trademark: *oh gosh*, she had said before, as Rog filled her ass with his huge cock, making her milk his cum like an unholy slut.

It was then, just as April turned her head to face the camera, and looked right at it, though with her eyes absorbed into a vacancy, or maybe the complete consumption of her body. But I only got to see this April, consumed by lust and pushing herself back against Rog, heels bouncing next to her ass, for a fleeting moment.

Jonny floated back into the scene, and climbed onto the bed. He had his cock in his hand, and I could see him guiding it to April's mouth, briefly, before he blocked my view again with his body.

All I could see then were glimpses of April's heels, her hands on the bed between Jonny's legs, glimpses of her hair as she tossed it. The sounds of smacking, April moaning and slurping, Rog groaning in approval and delivering his instructions to April in a low voice, were all I had to piece together what they were doing to her.

"Oh fuck yeah," Rog said, after they had pulled a train on her for a few minutes. "Oh yeah, baby, squeeze it tight, there you go. You do a good job, squeeze that cock, oh fuck yeah, just like that. Oh, don't stop, honey, keep it tight, mmmm."

The slapping of Rog's thighs against April's ass increased in frequency, the slaps wet with sweat. Jonny shifted his body, and I heard April's gasps for air as he pulled her from his cock by the hair. He moved a little so I could see April's face as he held her up, the roots of her hair straining at her scalp, while Rog continued to drill her from behind.

"Oh! Oh! Oh!" April shrieked, her mouth wide open.

Rog groaned as he slammed deep into her and emptied his seed in her ass. Jonny languidly held her by the hair and used his free hand to slap his cock all over April's face. She tried to catch him in her mouth, her tongue reaching for him, licking whatever she could touch.

Rog slapped her ass, and looked down at her. "That was nice, baby." He winced and grunted as a last shudder of his orgasm gripped him. Then he looked at Jonny. "Got that *all* ready for you, man"

Jonny tilted April's head and swiped his cock over her lips, her panting mouth, strands of saliva rolling down her chin, clinging to his cock. Her mascara was smeared, her lips raw pink, her sluttiness only deepening with each wet defilement of her face and makeup.

"Oh God," I said aloud. What I meant by it, I have no idea.

"You want some more?" Jonny asked her. Her eyes were on his, her tongue extended, laid out for him to slap his wet dick on. "Suck on it

like a good girl if you do. Suck it real good and I'll give it to you."

April opened her mouth as Jonny gripped her disheveled hair tightly and pushed her back onto his cock. He pumped April's head on his dick in a few rapid, jerky moments, making use of her like she was a toy. But just as quickly, he pulled her off and pushed her to the side.

She fell over on her right side, her ankle still pinned to the back of her thigh. Rog was stepping away, watching with interest, his cock still full and hard, twitching a little with the remnants of his recent orgasm, but otherwise, he seemed unspent, ready for more. Ready to fuck my wife for hours more.

Jonny made a series of quick moves, untying her leg, pushing her limbs around, folding her ankles up to her face, so her heels were up over her head. "Hold on to those," he told her gruffly.

He slid April's doubled-over body onto his lap, her lower back resting on his knees. "Yeah hold onto your ankles like that, good girl, if you're real good I'll give you a treat."

Jonny tugged on April's hips, and adjusted a little, but soon April was howling sexily as Jonny's cock disappeared into her ass.

He fucked her, holding onto her hips, while April's feet bounced just above her face, and she held tightly to her ankles. Jonny licked his fingers, and dropped them to her gash, playing with her clit as she screamed and begged him to make her come.

When she did, Jonny looked pleased. His cock was still inside her ass, and he rode her slowly, obviously enjoying her slick, velvety interior. "That was good," he told her. "Yeah, that was a good girl. Now you gotta do it for *me*, baby, just hold still and I'm gonna give you a big load of cum."

I stared at the low-quality image on my phone: April's heels falling to either side of her head as her legs spread in her final, complete submission to Jonny, who methodically fucked her ass while she lay there, exhausted, trembling with the shudders of her orgasm, taking his hard thrusts like a limp rag doll.

I saw Jonny groan, saw his abdominal muscles ripple as he dove deep and then leaned on April's thighs to ram his load into her.

He paused, cock still deep in her ass, and sat back on his heels, dragging April's limp body with him. He had a smug, satisfied smile when he reached down and pushed April's tangled hair from her face. "You like that, little girl? Yeah, she liked it. You get enough, you little slut?" His

fingers dropped to her spread gash, and he fingered her again, making April whimper and squirm. Jonny smiled, looking to his left, where Rog must have been in the wings of this sordid scene, waiting.

I was gripping my phone like it weighed a thousand pounds, pain radiating down my arm. I watched Jonny's mouth open, heard a final sultry moan from April, and then everything disappeared from my screen.

It took a few moments to process what had just happened. I stared at the black screen, unable to believe that I had been disconnected from whatever would happen next. I waited, my cock aching, my heart throbbing angrily in my chest, vision blurred, for someone to call me back.

But no one ever did, and so I was left in the dark, both literally and figuratively. My fingers hovered over the messaging app as I racked my brains for a way to tell Jonny the feed had been cut, a way to beg him to connect me back to the scene without seeming desperate. But as the minutes, and then the hours, ticked by, I realized that whatever was happening in that room downtown, no one was checking their messages, or their phones. I would have to wait for April to tell me what happened, to live off the scraps she fed me as details.

I didn't sleep, I only stared at the phone, and the walls, my eyes red-rimmed with drink and fatigue, simmering inside with the only thoughts that I could complete: that my wife was somewhere downtown, being thoroughly and filthily fucked by two men while another got to watch. But not me.

*

Headed home

That was April's text at 4:30 am, almost four hours after the connection had been lost. It was one rule we had agreed on that was still in place: that she would let me know when she was coming home.

I stared at her message and could not think of anything to write back. The thoughts I was having were adolescent, and I knew it, and I hated myself for it: the impulse to play games, to tell April I hadn't even gotten her text and thereby show her how un-obsessed and un-jealous I was, were the thoughts and actions of a twenty-year-old me. But I couldn't shake myself free of them.

I was lying in bed by then, staring at the ceiling. I had gotten the text, of course I had: my phone hadn't left my hand and the buzz of the text electrified me. I set it down on the night table, though, and folded my hands over my chest, trying to not be ill, trying to ignore my aching cock.

I had the memories of the night April had returned from her "audition" for Mr. Smith's porno in my mind, when she was so exhausted she fell asleep. The nights she had come back from filming, which seemed to have taken a very long time, when she had complained of being too sore to have sex with me. I wanted to fuck April senseless right now, but that had already happened, and if she were to turn me away, after the night I'd had, I didn't know what I was going to do. I was already feeling pretty unhinged as it was.

Even though we'd obviously reached a place where I had come clean with April about my dark fantasies, there were depths of the fantasy I still hadn't plunged into yet. I wanted to fuck April while her pussy was full of cum and I could still smell other men on her, I wanted to feel the loose, sloppy flesh that Jonny and Rog had already degraded. I wanted her to moan beneath me because her flesh was like a bruised peach, ripe and soft. It was a part of the fantasy, though, that I didn't dare to speak outright to April about, because there was a fear inside of me - unnameable, without any real form - that April would reject something about *that* level of debased desire. Maybe not outright, but deep inside.

You may say to yourself, *surely* she knew this already. But when we participate in other people's sexual fantasies, we know only what occurs outside of their mind. April enjoyed being fucked like a whore, you could see that she liked the rough sex, the complete submission, the humiliation. But I could never know what occurred inside her mind - what dark corners of her *own* fantasies were being satisfied by her own dark thoughts. Maybe she wanted to share them, but maybe she wanted to keep them secret.

My phone buzzed in my hand again, and I read April's text, ice-cold jealousy and fury pouring over me, my cock throbbing painfully to a new state of distension, precum oozing messily over my crown.

I'm so sore I can barely walk

How many minutes passed? I somehow rose and sat on the bed, phone in hand, bent over, mouth dry, staring at the screen. My limbs had

become detached, they would no longer move for me. For a few moments I was breathing too quickly, I could feel my respirations, shallow and too rapid, and I had to talk myself down from hyperventilating and maybe passing out.

And then the door opened, and clicked shut. I heard keys being set down on the table, sliding, then falling to the floor. The clack of shoes as she kicked them off. A thump. A giggle. And then her footsteps, soft, maybe like she was sneaking home, sneaking in, trying not to wake me up.

By the time she reached the door, my thoughts had turned almost venomous. She opened it and stumbled through, saw me sitting in the bed, and her eyes flew open in alarm. Her hand flew to her chest and she shrieked, jumping a little. "Jesus!" she yelled.

She flipped the light switch, her hand still on her chest in a balled fist.

"You scared the crap out of me," she laughed, pushing her hair back from her face. "I thought maybe you were asleep."

April, from the neck down, looked much like she had when she had departed that evening: her dress clung to her, was on neatly, her breasts displayed in the yawning neckline. Her skin had an unusual patchwork of matte and shine to it, though, the kind of film you get from sweating and then drying off, sweating again, and drying off again. Her normally unflappable hair had acquired a humid volume to it, a messiness she didn't have even after a night's restless sleep. I didn't think, in fact, that I had *ever* seen April's hair like that: you would have to pull it, smear cum in it, sweat on it, pull it again, and drag her head across the sheets over and over again to get that effect. Her lips were puffy, pale pink, worn-out: they had been stretched and rubbed by two big cocks, who knew how many times, and it showed. The dark mascara and eyeliner, that had given her the vaguely smutty look earlier, had seeped from its clean outlines and lay smudged beneath her eyes, and the contours of a black-tinged tear that had rolled from the corner of her eye to her ear remained, even though she seemed to have tried to brush it away.

"The feed cut off," I said simply. My hand had gone to my cock. "Hours ago."

I don't know what I had expected April's reaction to be. Usually I say things only because I know, at the very least, what I expect to elicit

from whomever I say them to. But now I had no plan, I wasn't even thinking.

Maybe I had expected April to be concerned. For her hand to fly to her mouth, for her to feel bad. Who can say what I thought at that point?

April leaned against the door frame, and a terrifying smile - hot, sexy, coy, and alien - turned up her mouth as the hand at her chest left, disappearing behind her back to tug at the zipper of her dress. "Hours ago," she repeated. Her mouth puckered, her tongue ran along her upper lip. Her eyes had been on mine, and they wandered now to my hand, which was holding my cock.

I was sure that I looked like a sick and twisted character, but I didn't care. April's smile was dangerous, and I didn't like it one bit, but at the same time, I also didn't care. I didn't care that this was a dangerous game, that my wife seemed like someone else, as she pulled the zipper down and the tautness of her dress gave way. The front slipped forward and she helped the dress off by rolling her shoulders forward. She stepped out of the fallen dress and walked toward me, her nipples swollen to twice their normal size and peeking through the transparent material of her bra. Her panties were missing, the skin all around her pussy red, marks on her hips deepening to a shade of light brown.

By the time she reached the foot of the bed, I could smell the scent of her pussy - her own juices, the acrid, faintly bleachy scent of male cum. Flecks of some kind of fabric - maybe the carpet, maybe the linens - had stuck to her knees, and in patches on her collarbone. The uneven stickiness of her skin was more visible as she came closer to the light.

She climbed onto the bed on her knees, hooking a finger under the strap of her bra, which was slightly ripped, and fell away because it was loose. Her expression had not changed: it was predatory, and new to me from April. If I had felt my control slipping away over the past months, I had always felt like I could get it back, like it was just a momentary slip. With April looking at me like that, right now, walking toward me on her knees, her pussy and ass and mouth full of other men's cum, I had the thrilling but terrifying realization that now, at least, in this moment: April was the one in complete control.

"You missed a lot, then," she said, and the way the words rolled out of her mouth I could tell she knew exactly what that statement did to me. She brought her hands to the straps of her bra and pulled the material away

from her tits, leaving it hooked in back, fondling herself as her eyes dropped to the phone that had fallen from my hand, to my other hand - no longer really controlled by my mind - gripping my swollen cock.

"I see you got my text," she purred, crawling closer, climbing onto my lap. My hands went to her arms but they were useless for doing anything other than that: she had her breasts close to my face. I could smell, distinctly, that someone had come on her tits, could see the dried creamy stain. Her right nipple looked almost like it had been chewed on.

Her thigh rubbed against my cock as she settled onto my lap, pushing my legs into place with her own. She pushed me back onto the bed, and I let her, staring at her as she smiled at me and ran her hands over my chest. Now that she was resting on my hips, I could feel her pussy just above my dick, juices gushing from inside it.

"It's too bad," she said, watching my face, her eyes almost hawk-like searching for my reaction. "I was a very, *very* bad wife."

My eyes closed, squinting, as though I was staring into the sun. The pain in my groin was now wrapping itself around me, snaking through me, almost making me ill. "Oh my God, April." I managed to say, in a hoarse whisper.

She rose up on her knees, guiding my dick to her slit with her hand. I groaned as the gushing tip slipped into the hot, soft, dirtily wet folds of her pussy. She moved me through her flesh, rubbing my cock on her clit, which seemed engorged to twice its usual size. Her mouth fell open and she moaned. "I'm so sore," she told me, rolling her hips so that her pussy sucked at my cock like a teasing blowjob from a sloppily wet mouth. "I'm going to have to go very, very slowly."

My hands were on her hips, and I was straining as I lifted my head to watch my cock disappear into her used, reddened pussy. Her flesh quivered around me, a lot like it did when she came before I did, and her orgasm fluttered away inside of her while I took myself over the edge. I pushed up on my hips and April's half-closed eyes flew open. She squeezed me between her thighs and froze her descent to the base of my cock.

"Mmmh," April complained, moving her hips so that her pussy slid along the top half of my shaft. "I almost can't stand it," she said.

"How many times did Jonny fuck you?" I grunted. "I saw him fuck you in the ass..." my voice trailed off, I was too distracted to finish the thought. Her pussy seemed full of cum. My fingers moved to her ass, and

found a still-gaping hole, oozing cum, yawning enough for me to swipe around it without having to push into her flesh.

"Your ass," I said meaninglessly. I pushed two fingers inside of her, probing. April sucked her breath in, but didn't stop me. She started to lower her weight onto me, sinking onto my cock.

"I don't know how many times Jonny fucked me," April told me. "I came so many times I lost count." She rolled her hips slowly, her body squeezing my cock. I could see on her face that she was almost too sore to be doing this, but she had a hungry look in her eyes as well.

I let my fingers slip from her ass, because I was starting to get muscle pain from crunching myself up to finger-fuck her and watch my cock as she slowly lifted her pussy and then slowly eased me back inside of her, her thighs squeezing me tightly to support her weight each time she rose up.

"Oh my God, April," I groaned, and she smiled. I gripped her ass with my right hand and pushed myself up with my left. I wanted to be deeper inside of her. "Were you fucking them all night?"

April laughed. It was an odd laugh. "They were fucking *me* all night," she said.

Something in her tone seemed almost accusatory, even if it wasn't. Another wave of toxic jealousy gripped me, and I gripped her ass even more tightly, pushing off my left hand, and rolled her violently over, keeping my dick inside of her.

"Keep talking," I told her.

She moaned and closed her eyes. "Oh," she complained. "Oh, go nice and slow, please. My pussy is so sore... Jonny really fucked me so hard."

I moved slowly, each movement complete torture. "Tell me more about that," I whispered, pushing her hair from her face. "What did he do to you?"

April mewled, and closed her eyes, and her fingernails dug into my back. She ran her tongue along my ear. "He just *fucked me*," she said, her voice tense, her body moving in waves of tension that I couldn't figure out if they were the onset of an orgasm or the avoidance of the too-painful stimulus of her over-fucked cunt. "Over and over and over again."

"And you like that?" I said, my own voice shaking. I was fucking her slowly, but it was almost impossible. The pain in my balls felt like a

vice grip, and the temptation to hammer into her sloppy pussy while she lay there like she had for Jonny and Rog was almost too tempting to resist.

April didn't answer.

"Tell me how much you like it," I whispered.

"I like it," April purred. "I like getting fucked like a little slut."

"You like sucking cock," I pressed.

"I like sucking cock and swallowing cum," April agreed, and I groaned, pushing deeper inside of her. She mewled again.

Her fingers traveled over the back of my neck, and her lips grazed my ear as she whispered the next part. "Don't come yet, keep fucking me, I want you to make me come again."

My body jerked and I gave myself a blinding headache as I tried to squeeze my eyes closed and squeeze April's words from my mind. I grasped at any thought I could find to take the sound of her voice, the feel of her pussy, and those words from my head, but I failed, and I also couldn't stop myself from yelling loudly as an orgasm that almost blinded me made me jackhammer my cum into her already abused and overflowing pussy.

April ground up against me, and I pushed away from the bed, watching her, just holding on, as my aching cock burst inside of her. It hurt, but I dutifully fucked her with my sensitive, but still-hard cock, as she fought to make herself come again. Her eyes were closed, her brow furrowed, sweat gathering at her hairline. Her pussy was so sloppy-wet and hot that each fuck spluttered between us.

When she came, it was a quick, fluttering quiver, and barely a gasp, and then her body went entirely limp, and her head fell to the side, a faint smile on her lips.

And with that, April was asleep.

CHAPTER 10

A few days later, I was at a place called Charlie Brown's, because for whatever completely insane reason, I had allowed myself to be carted to an after-work get-together.

I don't really like or dislike the people I work with, they're just kind of who I ended up working with at a job I likewise feel like I just ended up working at for equally unimportant reasons. I get the impression they like me because I have a little bit of a dangerous, bad-neighborhood buzz about me. Some of this bad-boy-in-the-suburbs fairy dust is surely due to the accent, and some of it is because a rumor got started that I was in prison once, and some of it I can't really explain except by thinking that maybe these people watched a few too many Matt Damon movies and have me, my nondescript hair and very far-far-far-removed resemblance to Matt, and Jason Bourne and Will Hunting mixed up in some kind of coworker cocktail they drink to keep themselves from being too bored.

It's a double-edged sword: they find my snubs and refusal to exchange small talk about gardening mysterious and intriguing, and make excuses for behavior that would otherwise be scandalous - like never bringing anything to potluck lunches, not singing at office birthday parties, never pitching in for baby shower gifts, and not saying anything at meetings.

But they also always seem to want to take me to the bar with them, which is pretty tedious. As far as I know, I've never done anything entertaining or like the characters they seem to have me mixed up with when I've begrudgingly gone with them, but the Legend of Thomas (Logistics - Red Team) won't die.

I had texted April, because I'm also a great married man, and expected her to send me condolences and some excuse, like that she had to study. April is great at small-talk, beautiful and interesting, and lights up any room, but she hates going to things with my coworkers. I guess there's only so much light you can throw on deformed, underwatered snake plants and corporate art prints on beige walls before the lights actually make the situation worse.

Also, they *are* really boring people, who do really boring work, and they talk about it a lot.

Anyway, they asked me to pick the bar, so I recklessly chose one I had driven past a million times but never entered. They had a patio, where a bunch of smokers clustered and hung off the railings, and I had an itch to bum a cigarette from someone.

"What's this place like, Thomas?" asked the front receptionist, whose name begins with an "A" but is not Annie.

"Never been here," I told her authoritatively, as I opened the door for her.

That, and things like that, is kind of my shtick.

I looked at my phone shortly after the bar was declared "cool" - the standard they applied seemed to be that I had suggested it, and there were some tougher-looking hipsters leaning on things and looking menacing. I was fairly bored and two beers in within five minutes of arriving. The message was, as was expected, April, but not what I expected her to write.

*Yeah, that's cool
Actually can I meet you down there?*

April wasn't really great for taking the weird shine off my weird reputation, but I agreed anyway.

"Guys, my wife wants to come," I said loudly. This stopped everyone in mid-sentence. I think the fact that April is so jaw-droppingly hot, and cheerful, really added to their Thomasian Folklore. "Tasha, you think I can bum one of your cigarettes?"

Tasha was not sure what to say, so she just held out the box to me.

"You *smoke*?" Receptionist-not-Annie said, incredulously.

I put a cigarette between my lips and let it hang there while I pretended to think. Then I left.

I texted April to please come and save me, then I smoked a cigarette and ruminated on how gross smoking was as I leaned over the railing of the smoker's patio. The bar was on a steep hill in the center of midtown, and it overlooked the city, which was ensconced in a haze that looked like it had crept up on us out of the eighties. The sun was in my eyes, some uncivilized motorists were honking at a red light, and I had tobacco in my nostrils.

Nostalgia overtook me for a moment, so I bummed another cigarette.

April drove, and she parked in the sort of parking space you can only get if you're in a movie, a parallel space you can drive right into on a packed one-way where no two adjacent parking spaces have been empty for more than three seconds since like 1972.

There were a few guys with arms draped over the railing like me, and their attention went immediately to her. Maybe it was the parking space. Maybe it was the way she stepped out of the car and the wind picked up her long black hair, helping her own casual shake of the head; maybe it was her red dress, and the identical shade of lipstick that coated her pouty lips beneath a pair of very expensive sunglasses I didn't remember her having.

I watched her walk up the hill, almost causing an accident because one driver really did crane his neck too hard and came close to taking out a parked car. The guys next to me were making those low, grumbly noises that men who want to call attention to a hot chick, but are too enlightened to do it like a construction crew, make.

April strolled past us, seemingly oblivious to the scene she was making. I blew out a stream of smoke and smiled at the guys next to me while I crushed the butt out.

"Goin' for it, eh tiger?" one of them said.

These were fighting words where I come from, but this guy looked like he went to a Montessori school and lived in his parents' basement freelancing, so I gave it a pass and headed in.

The coworkers had already found April and reeled her in, but she was not looking like her usual breezy self. For one thing, there was the dress, which one of the accounting ladies was gesturing at, like April was the prize behind Door Number 3, and the other was that her smile seemed forced.

She met my eyes as soon I came in.

"Hey babe," I said, sliding my arm around her. I might have taken the time to stay distanced and hope she didn't smell the smoke on me, but the patio guys were wandering in and I thought it was mightily amusing that they'd see how quickly a guy like me worked my magic. "Want a beer?"

I was prepared for April to crinkle her nose and give me The Look, but she didn't. "Yeah, uh..." she said distractedly. "Whatever you're having."

I ordered her a gin and tonic, because April couldn't possibly have meant what she had just said.

A few hundred thousand years of banal chit-chat took place before a pool game started and April and I were semi-alone.

"You look so hot. Someone fell off the balcony turning his head."

I waited for April to get a really concerned look on her face and then laugh at herself for believing something that absurd, but she had other things on her mind.

"What's up?" I asked her, leaning over to take her hands in mine. April smiled, looked around like she was about to crack a racist joke, and then picked up her drink to sip it before starting to speak. "I got a bunch of messages from the guy. You know, Mr. Smith."

I allowed myself a few seconds to marvel at how April thought "the guy" needed clarification in my world, and then I arched my eyebrow and flexed my abdomen, which was an attempt to regulate my blood pressure, since blood was being rapidly distributed to all the wrong places required for reasonable thought.

"Like, he wants to have another...?"

April seemed to need to think about this for some reason, but then she shook her head emphatically. "No, not exactly."

"So he's texting you now? Like, other than dates?"

I frowned.

April slid her phone over to me. The way she carelessly played with her straw, and then spoke, she reminded me, for a terrifying moment, of Lilith, to the point that I almost saw Lilith's features in her face. It was a real *Vanilla Sky* moment.

I picked up the phone. "I'm not sure I like this," I mumbled, and I was surprised to hear myself say it out loud.

"It's just business," April said quickly. "It's just, uh... well..."

I looked up at her. I couldn't get a good read on what her expression meant. She seemed to be teasing me, but also appeared mildly embarrassed, a little guilty, and also a little confused.

"Just business," I repeated, scanning the text exchanges. April had "Mr. Smith" in her phone as "GS."

The content was a little startling. Not because of *the content*, because... well, I'm a guy. What was startling is that this guy was writing all this stuff to April, that he felt like he could, that she thought of it as just business. I rolled upward, into the past from two weeks ago, to start.

That was hot the other night.

I had fun.

It seemed like you did.

*Do you think I could make another request or two?
There's a bonus in it, of course.*

I guess it depends on the request...

*Of course. You don't have to take me up on any of
these suggestions.
But you're so very good, you're a natural.
I would love to see you do any of these things, and I'm
willing to pay for it.*

"This guy," I commented dryly. "Pretty fucking full of himself."
I glanced up at April, who suddenly had a bit of a flush, and a set jaw, which meant she was a little embarrassed. I put a hand out and touched her arm, then continued reading.

*Next time I'd like to see some DP. And more throat
fucking.
That was really, really hot.
I can send you a link of what I really like
Watch it, tell me if you think you can do it.*

A link followed, which I dutifully lifted my finger to click on.
April shot her arm out and grasped my forearm ferociously.
"Don't," she hissed, "watch that here."
"You've already watched it?"
April looked at me over her drink and raised an eyebrow. She set it down. Then she brought the straw to her mouth and let the liquid drop onto her tongue.

I set the phone down, after giving myself another perusal of the messages, as a perverse cocktail of treat and torture.

April seemed suddenly offended. "I don't know what to do," she said, after a long pause.

My stomach had turned to ice, and I was pretty sure my balls were cracking, about to explode. I wanted, very much, to know what was in that video, and I suspected that I also wanted, very much, to watch April do it. But this was at odds with how slippery my grip on any of this was becoming. I didn't like this guy having any, let alone *this level* of, control over what April was doing, even if that was kind of what the gig was.

April was still looking at me.

"I'm not sure I like this guy being this bossy with you," I told her, picking up the phone again. "Even if he is paying."

The link was glaring at me, seducing me. My mouth was getting dry.

"That's what... that's the part I'm not sure about," April said.

This made me jerk my gaze away from the phone and study her. *That* was the part she wasn't sure about?

"April," I said. "I can't really figure out what's going on here without seeing the video."

"It's not anything, like... out there," April said dismissively. "Not like... I don't know..."

I watched as the beautiful, pristine April Snow, recent convert to hotwife slut, looked at the ceiling in the hopes of finding an example of some sexual act that was over the line for her.

"Bestiality?" I offered.

April did not find this funny. Her face was shocked and she gasped. "God, no... Thomas, what the hell?"

"It was a joke. What, what is it?"

"Nothing like *that*."

"Girls?"

"What? No. It's just... look, it's not like, anything I haven't sort of done. It's not that, it's just... I don't know. I don't want things to get out of control. You know?"

Oh, I knew.

"I mean, April, then tell him that. Or I can. This is an ongoing, you know, negotiation. Just because he pays you doesn't mean you have to, like, do every single thing he suggests." I re-scanned the messages and April snatched the phone from me.

"Don't click on it here," she repeated, flushed.

I didn't say anything to that, because nothing at all occurred to me to say.

"I can always tell him my husband disapproves," she said. She cocked her head and smiled, biting her lower lip gently.

But this is the thing, April. Does your husband disapprove?

Being honest with myself, I didn't *like* it. I didn't like the idea of this guy telling April how to fuck in front of him. But I also did. It was all just a question of exactly how far we wanted that to go, how deep we were willing to dive into it.

I cleared my throat. "So is this, uh... like, let's just start with this: is this something you're flat-out not willing to do?"

April bit gently into her thumb.

Now, I realize that I've described a lot of amazing scenes in this story, and that they all should have been somewhere on the order of 1,000 times more erotic than this one. But April, dressed in her tight, hot red dress, biting gently into her thumb while she thought about the answer to that question - I mean, really *thought* about it - was probably one of the most mind-numbingly and cock-torturingly erotic things I'd ever seen in my life. This was a woman, after all, who had made a porno, and took it in the ass from a man like Rog, and let Jonny throat-fuck her upside-down on a bed, until his cum dripped into her long eyelashes.

And she had to *think* on it.

Simmering beneath all of this was, for me, the sort of crazed, frenzied problem that lay at the heart of all of this: I couldn't do these things to my wife. I couldn't suggest them, either. I obviously wanted her to do them, and I wanted to see it, but something stopped me from sending videos like whatever this was to her and asking her to get someone else to do it to her.

And so another man doing that was a weird and twisted situation, because it had a hot side and a side that made me feel like a huge pussy. It appealed to my kink, it was actually a godsend of sorts, but something about it also made me feel deeply troubled.

"I should get back to him about it," April said, without answering the question. "I just wanted to know what you think."

She had set her phone down and had her hand on it now. I reached for it and lifted her hand, phone gripped in it, and set her hand on my other

palm.

She released the phone as I talked to her. "There's nothing in your agreement that says 'you have to get back to him' within some certain amount of time," I told her.

"That's true," April said, sounding uncertain.

I took the phone and dropped it in my pocket. "Why don't we just forget about it for now? When's... you don't even have a date set with him, do you?"

April looked at me. "Tomorrow," she said. "So I'd have to... you know... try to get a hold of Jonny or Rog and like, send this to them, I guess."

My cock throbbed so painfully that I had to bend slightly to keep from yelling. Jonny. What a prick he was, and he'd basically hit a gold mine that just kept delivering. Sweet April, who he'd had to handle with silk gloves, was going to send him raunchy videos now and ask him if he could do that to her.

And Rog. Don't get me started on that fucker.

But these were passing thoughts, they burned like a little too much chipotle powder does, and then I was left with what I seemed, increasingly, to be left with: a really hard dick and not a clear thought in my head. "I can't think straight," I told April honestly.

April still had her thumb between her teeth, biting very gently on the very tip of it. Her eyes dropped to my crotch, and then wandered slowly back up as the look in her eyes changed. She was sultry, suddenly, her long lashes descending slowly and then rising to half-mast, her body turning on her bar stool to face me.

She moved her thumb, rubbing the pad of it across her upper lip. The gesture seemed like nothing, careless, and it took place in slow-motion, but I was reeling from it even before she followed it up by touching the tip of her tongue to the length of her thumb.

Somehow, defying all laws of physics, the entirety of my cock was connected to her finger, and I could have sworn I felt the cool, wet muscle of her tongue running along the underside of my granite-hard shaft as she did that.

"Maybe you *should* watch that video," she said.

There were probably a hundred people in that bar, but they were gone, as far as I was concerned, in a second.

Watch the video? Did she mean *here*?

"Just," she said, stepping off her stool, and worked her way in between my thighs, slipping the phone from my pocket as she did. She cradled the phone and lowered her head, making a little space for us, the screen tipped toward me. "Don't turn the sound on."

So what could I do?

Jesus. I'm a man, for fuck's sake.

I played the video.

Eroticism. What is it, exactly? It wasn't like April was never sexy before any of this. It wasn't like I had never watched porn before. It wasn't like I had never fantasized about a lot of the specific sexual acts that April had performed.

So it's hard to say what it was about watching a pretty standard porn clip - I mean, it was hard-core, sure, but not really that out there as far as porn these days goes - with April's forehead leaning against mine, a whole bar full of people around us, and her lips just inches from mine that was so intensely erotic. I actually thought I was going to come without anyone touching my dick.

Maybe it was the dizzying unexpectedness of it. Maybe it was the feeling that kept surfacing in my mind, each time with greater intensity, that April was turning into someone else. The fear that she might not turn back, that the woman I'd married might be lost to me forever. The unknown of where I wanted her to stop, *if* I wanted her to stop.

The clip was short, and featured a busty, blond woman on her hands and knees, face upturned, being throat-fucked by a guy with a huge cock, the shape of which was disturbingly visible as it moved down her throat. Truthfully speaking, it was the kind of porn I would have clicked on and then never watched again: too over-the-top. But on the screen of April's phone, with the tantalizing possibility that she, April, my wife, would ask Jonny or Rog to do that to her so another man, hiding in his own apartment behind a two-way mirror, could get his rocks off? It was entirely different.

I was ill, teetering on vomiting. It was hard to know if that came from the intense pain building in my dick, or from the sheer horror of what was happening. Or the sheer thrill of it, like a bungee jump.

We were head-to-head, staring at the screen, April with her odd smile and her perfect lips in front of mine. Her hands were on my wrists,

her body hot against my inner thighs.

The video finished, and we remained as we were, the air between us sticky and wet, the faint scent of April's arousal rising from the hot skin nestled somewhere between my legs and the fabric of her red dress.

"I, uh... I mean, you're the one who, uh... has to, you know..." I finally mumbled.

"So you don't think there's, you know... I don't know, like, you don't have any objections to it, I guess, is what I'm asking."

My eyes were glued to the screen, which had gone to screensaver, a floral pattern, typical of April. My mind was busy overlaying the images I had just seen, so it was almost as if I was just endlessly looping the video, the blond woman's hair turning darker, her breasts changing in shape to be more like April's.

"I can't think straight," I told her, simply.

The pleasure that this gave April mapped itself out in her lips, a peculiar quiver of her flesh, something sinister flashing beneath her strange new smile, like a pike moving in a murky lake. She squeezed my hand, smiled her smile, writhed a little between my legs, and then turned. Body first, head rotating slowly with her as she gave me a beckoning smile.

I watched her strut away, through the crowd, toward the hall leading to the restrooms. A swaggering buck detained her for a moment, and April paused to talk to him, making sure to do it in a way that left open all sorts of possibilities. She leaned in to speak to him, glanced back at me and smiled, and then continued on her way.

I was stunned, and incapable of moving very easily. I wasn't sure if I could stand, let alone walk, and yet I knew that I needed to get over to where April had disappeared.

*You coming?
If you don't hurry I'll have to get back out there and
find someone else
I'm in the third one down*

The memory of what happened next is layered in my mind like a montage, all the senses involved. I barely remember walking over there, and yet I would have had to. The guy who had impeded her in order to talk glared at me, a smell of cheap cigarette smoke clung to the old paneling in

the hallway. I knocked on the door and waited eternally for April to unlock it for me.

She pulled me in, and pushed me against a wall. She unzipped my pants, and took my cock in her hand, looking at me with that odd new smile, while she gave me a hand-job that, while lasting in the single-digits of seconds, was the newest, latest, most-erotic thing that had ever happened to me.

That was three in the space of fifteen minutes, if you're keeping track.

When she was finished, she brought her hand up to her mouth, and licked a glob of cum from her finger.

Sweat was growing cool on my forehead, the images of the porno, which had for a brief moment right after I came, seemed blindingly vulgar, were surfacing in my mind again. I stared at April's mouth as she smiled, and absent-mindedly, I reached for her smooth throat and touched it. It was soft, perfectly shaped, and lovely. And she was going to have a bulge of cock rolling up and down the length of it tomorrow.

She spun toward the mirror and straightened out her dress. Someone knocked on the door.

"One sec," April called sweetly. She grinned at me. Her phone was in her hand, almost like she had pulled it from thin air, and she leaned her forearms against my chest as she held it up and typed.

I had a nice view of her lips, her breasts framed by the low cut of her dress, something about which was just now starting to disturb me, though I couldn't say why.

"I'm going to send it to Rog," April said, swinging her hips a little. She tilted the phone so I could see what she was writing.

I want you to do this to me next time

I sucked in my breath. The world actually did feel like it was spinning at that point, all around me. April could have typed anything else, but she hadn't. She could have asked, she could have de-personalized it, she could have stated that Mr. Smith wanted someone to do that to her next time.

She looked up at me. "Well," she said. "I guess we'll see."
There was another, less patient knock on the door.

April dropped her eyes, pushing away from me. Her hand moved from my chest to my crotch, where she played her fingers over the shape of my cock while smiling.

Then she reached for the door and opened it.

"Sorry," she said, laughing.

The guy walking in was looking at April as she walked away, so he almost walked right into me, and actually jumped when he turned around.

"Sorry," I said, with a smug grin.

And then I went out to see what my wife was getting up to while she waited to hear back from a man she had just asked to throat-fuck her.

*

What April did next was diabolical, and she did it with such flawless ease, looking completely innocent of all wrongdoing as she did it, that I started to wonder if the April I thought I had been married to had ever really existed at all.

She installed herself in a game of pool by taking Anna-not-Anna - arguably the least unattractive of my coworkers, with her to the table that had been dominated by a large group of wannabe tough-guys. (Why wannabe? This was a bar for hipsters and people who worked in the downtown core. With the exception of one exceptionally large kid with a Mr. Cup shirt on, which somehow gave him a sinister air, none of them looked like they'd ever been in anything more than a hissy fit).

Then she began to play pool like she had just stepped off the set of a Porno called "Paula Puts All The Balls In The Holes." She draped herself over the table with her ass turned up, she smiled and ran her fingers up and down the length of her stick, her face a sweet, expressionless mask that made it look like she wasn't capable of having a dirty thought, let alone acting on it.

Why was April wearing this red dress? The question surfaced again.

Was this how April dressed now, all the time? Like Lilith, like a high-class hooker?

Why wouldn't she? She *was* one, after all.

My eyes, wandering to give myself a break from the intensity of the scene before me, came back into focus when I saw Anna. She was

looking at me, half-exhilarated, half-afraid. I moved my eyes to the left to see why: April was cozied up with one of the guys, speaking very close to his ear, her hands moving carelessly all over his body.

It wasn't much of anything, really, if you didn't know April the way I did. If you didn't know that she would let men fuck her ass raw, or take on two guys at the same time, if you didn't know that she was able to deepthroat a huge black cock, and make a porno.

What I didn't know - and what I realized, in that moment, as April looked over at me and devastated me with a flirtatious, sultry glance - was how much of what April was doing was for me, and how much of it was to satisfy herself. There was never any sure way to calculate the percentages. I couldn't lie to her about how much it got me off - my cock never failed to spill the beans, as it were. And April *seemed* to have drifted further and further into this sea of sluttiness only because I had let out the line.

But who was talking whom into what?

That, I realized, was an unknown that could never be known. A question, I realized, that no answer would ever satisfy completely for me.

Did I want to know?

Or did I just want to keep experimenting, and tempting fate, and telling myself that the next, next time, I would have some kind of proof that I was in control of April's actions, that I was getting what I wanted, and that I was in control?

And not the other way around.

April continued to play pool, and flirt, not necessarily in that order, but her phone buzzed, and she smiled as she read the message.

My heart dropped as she sauntered over to me, holding the phone and turning it from side to side, the way a person would show a toy to a small child. She moved in between my legs when she came over, and I let her, because I would let April do whatever she wanted, and that was now becoming clear.

She showed me the message the same way we had watched the video, and my gut twisted violently as I read it. The temperature of the room seemed to increase by tens of degrees.

come on over sweet thing

that looks like something we better practice

April kept the phone between us as she typed.

what time?

She spoke as she typed, her voice low and feral, her eyes on the screen. "Is Thomas coming with me?"

Her fingers hovered over the keyboard on the screen, and she smiled without looking up at me, reading my expressions, my wrenching gut and my throbbing cock all without needing to look up. "He'll want to know."

A paralysis gripped me - it wasn't even so much indecisiveness, as a complete and total shutdown of my mouth and possibly my respiratory system, as all of the feelings this was giving me crashed into each other and gripped me in a fist of choking heat and blinding cold.

"Are you?" she asked, smiling. Then she looked up at me. "I can think of one way you could get the same view as this video, now that I think about it."

I tried to breathe and wasn't sure if I had been successful.

Her phone buzzed, but I didn't look down with her at the message. My mind was too full of the image from the video, the image I was creating in my own mind, the phantom sensation of her pussy clenched around my cock, the weight of her body on top of me, Rog's cock slamming into her throat just a few feet above me.

"Any time, he'll be ready," she said, smiling. Her eyes fluttered back up to me.

"So?" she asked. "Are you coming?"

CHAPTER 11

If Rog had any problem with me showing up with April, he didn't let on. I guess if a really hot woman like April sends you a filthy video like that and wants to come over and "practice," it's not really relevant whether her husband tags along.

"Hey man," he said, in a pretty amicable way, after looking April up and down and whistling.

"You get all dressed up for me?" he asked April, after leaving the door open for us to walk in. Rog, like Jonny, lived in an unexpectedly expensive condo in a trendy, high-priced neighborhood known for its nightlife. I supposed that all made sense with what I knew about Rog (which wasn't much, considering how many times he'd had his dick in my wife's ass).

"Just out," April said. I watched her as she entered the condo. Admittedly, I was looking for some sign that she had been here before, that she was familiar with Rog's condo. I could have just asked her - there were, after all, so many unaccounted-for hours during the filming of the porno - but my mind was quick to collapse into a heaving mass of paranoid fantasies about those missing hours.

This is probably about the point in this saga that you, like Lilith, see what kind of man I am: that I have a fetish for my wife cheating on me, and that I was having a hard time identifying it. It's not really that - I maintain, to this day, that I didn't actually *want* April to cheat on me for real - I just enjoyed the fantasy of it. I liked slipping into the darkness a bit. Picturing April being lured back here for a cocktail, her body sore and engorged, and then Rog putting the not-so-professional moves on her. Just one more quiet, personal fuck between them... what was the harm in that? Maybe Rog had a totally different way of fucking my wife when it was just the two of them.

April plopped herself down on the couch and picked up a magazine while Rog disappeared into his kitchen to make us some drinks. I watched her with suspicion, seeing familiarity in her every move. When Rog reappeared, I did the same to him, looking for an "accidental" meeting of their fingers, some shared look between them, some evidence that Rog knew her too well.

April crossed her legs, lying them at an angle, one calf resting on the other, which reminded me of a photo of Marlene Dietrich I really liked. Just the legs, of course. I wondered if April had plotted this whole evening from start to finish: it had been strange that she had wanted to come to Charlie Brown's, strange that she was dressed as provocatively as she was.

But more and more lately, I was beginning to see that April was in the driver's seat now, and I was only along for the ride. It irked me, but it wasn't all terrible.

I sat down next to her and she put her hand out to touch my leg, while still flipping through the magazine. It was a men's magazine, full of glossy photos of cars and hot women, probably *Maxim*. Rog called out something about drinks and April answered, as I sat there with my enlarging dick, my head swimming with terrible and gorgeous ideas.

April turned to me suddenly. "Lilith was in here, once," she said excitedly.

I nodded. Of course Lilith was in a magazine like that once. I was sure that whatever she was in there as would give me no insight whatsoever into what exactly Lilith *was*, and so my interest was not piqued.

Well, that, and the fact that Rog was about to start fucking my wife's face as "practice."

"Where'd you get this idea, anyhow, Miss April?" Rog said, coming back into the room. He looked at me as he handed a glass to April, who took it without looking up from the page of the magazine that she had begun reading. "You cool with whiskey? It ain't no top shelf shit, though."

"I'm not really a top shelf guy," I said amicably, taking the enormous whiskey he handed me. April's drink was pink, and I had no idea what it was. I was wishing I'd paid more attention to her when she had asked Rog for it. Had she said, "the usual?" Did Rog know how to make her some very special drink, a drink they shared whenever they were together?

Rog had a clear, carbonated beverage with a lime on it, and I strongly suspected it did not contain alcohol.

I took a huge gulp of my drink. Perhaps it was not top shelf in Rog's world, but it tasted nicely aged, and very expensive.

April tossed the magazine aside and took a sip of her drink. The discomfort displayed by an earlier version of my wife was not visible in this new April. She would have been acting the same way if we had arrived at her friends' house early for a dinner date.

"It's his idea," April said, answering a question I had forgotten Rog had ever asked.

"What, his?" Rog said, pointing at me.

"No, silly. The *guy*."

"Uh-ha," Rog said, and sipped his drink with a smile. "But you told him you wanted extra, right?"

April did something with her face - a dismissive gesture I don't know how to describe, except to say that it looked like something Lilith would do, but had never done. She sipped her drink. "He had already offered," she told Rog, with a smile dipped in the same dismissiveness.

I looked from April to Rog as this conversation took place.

It seemed a lot like Rog was almost... being a pimp.

"That's good," Rog said. He set his own drink down and rubbed his palms on his thighs. "So what's he want, then? This really ain't that different than stuff you already done." Rog's speech was changing - he slipped easily from a very ordinary, standard English to black English from moment to moment. It was impossible to know which voice was really his.

April smiled. "I'm thinking of asking for a very big bonus," she said, moving her fingers over her knee. "So I want it to be really good."

Rog's eyes switched to my face and he smiled amicably. "You here to make sure it looks all right from all the angles?"

"Something like that."

Rog smiled. Then he looked back at April, as his hand dropped to his fly. "You gonna come get me started off right, little girl?"

April looked at me briefly - I'd have said it was for approval, but she didn't give me time to do much of anything, a detail that was superfluous but burned pleasantly in my chest - and then stood up.

"That's some dress," Rog told her, approvingly. "Let me see the back of it."

April turned for him, and Rog grunted with approval. "That's nice. Your ass looks nice in that. Now let's get it off, but you're gonna leave those heels on for me, right baby?"

April reached behind herself and tried to tug at the zipper. I scooted over without her looking at me and pulled it down, watching the fabric open up to her bare back, no bra, and then down to the dip between her buttocks, all smooth skin and shadows, no panties either.

I exhaled loudly, and then reached up with two hands to pull the dress off her shoulders. It peeled away from her skin, leaving her bare, with nothing at all but her heels on. I ran my hands down the sides of her body, and leaned forward to lick the very highest part of the valley of pure white skin between the mounds of her ass. I smelled her tangy scent and caught a glance of the smear of glistening pussy juices on her inner thighs. I was moving my hand to her pussy when she started to step forward, and so I was only able to swipe at her overflowing cunt before she stepped away, leaving me on the couch to watch her walk toward Rog, her viscous juices slippery on my fingertips.

I brought them to my nose, and then licked them, while April slinked away. Rog's hands went to her thighs, and pulled her toward him. "You already good and worked up, ain't you?" he growled. The ebony of his skin wrapped all the way around April's thighs, making them look fragile and breakable in his enormous hands as he squeezed them.

It took me a moment to realize that Rog had pulled her toward his face, and that he was likely working his tongue into her slit. He had to bend a little to get the right angle. April's head tipped back and she mewled very softly.

Her mewls turned to moans, and Rog gripped her thighs more forcefully. Her hair began to sway as she writhed from the waist up, her lower body imprisoned by Rog's fierce grip and his mouth working away at her pussy. April's moans became hysterical quickly, and the sticky sounds of her pussy became louder; Rog had brought her to climax within minutes.

When she stopped panting and mewling, he pushed her back gently. "Go get on that bed," he told her.

April seemed a little dazed as she turned, pushing her hair from her face where it had become sweaty and stuck to her cheek. She looked down at me, and then seemed to need most of her concentration to walk.

Rog had his cock in his hand - he had taken it out while April undressed, and he didn't release it as he stood up, letting his jeans fall to the floor. He was stroking his cock at a leisurely pace, watching April walk into the bedroom.

Then he looked at me. "You comin' man? You should get her riding your cock while I do this, that'll be some view."

This was one of the few occasions where my usual talent for witty replies was completely sapped, so I just stood up and walked into the

bedroom. I noted, as I walked toward the bed on which April was crawling playfully, that she had not needed any guidance getting to the bedroom. It was true that it was a condo with few rooms, but she had shown no hesitation, not even needing to look around and see if the door was perhaps beyond the kitchen - another room was in that direction, after all.

Now she was naked, her wet slit filling the room with a sweet scent of unadulterated pussy, coquettishly positioning herself for a moment so that we had a nice view of her spectacular ass, and then turning around to face the entrance, and me, and Rog, while raising herself up on her knees.

"Like this?" she asked, in her most whoreish voice. Her eyes looked beyond me, to Rog, as she ran her hands over her body.

I was fumbling with my work clothes, taking off my shirt, and April shifted her eyes to me and smiled. Rog was right behind me. "Yeah man, just get under her and let her ride your cock. Just don't make her do nothin' might make her bite down," Rog laughed.

I was stepping out of my pants, trying not to be overly conscious of the fact that my cock, which was hard and dripping with precum, was only about half as thick and long as Rog's. I climbed onto the bed and had to make an awkward transition, tucking my feet under myself at first, to get underneath April, who spread her legs wide so mine could slip through. But her smile as I did so was worth it.

April looked down at me and guided my cock to her slit, rubbing it between her soaked lips for a few moments, before raising herself up again to guide the mouth of her cunt to the crown. Slowly, as I stared at her, she sank down to the base of my cock, settling her weight and her hot liquid warmth on me. Her hands were on my chest now, and she smiled, closed her eyes, and then opened them again.

After looking at me for a simmering moment, she shifted her weight and looked to Rog.

I felt the bed sink beneath me on my left side, then my right, and April squirmed on top of my pelvis, her silky interior moving around my dick, patches of her wet velvet skin hotter than others, tightening for a moment and then quivering away to a warm bath of pussy.

I sucked in my breath, lifting my head to see what she was doing, then I closed my eyes and let my head rest on the mattress. The bed was shifting all around me from Rog's weight as he moved onto the bed.

April's laugh was what made my eyes fly open. It was a fun, dirty, porn-star laugh - the kind of sound you don't believe is real when you hear it in a porno. The very kind of excited, beckoning, whore's laugh, that welcomes your cock into every hole, a promise of absolute acceptance and pleasure in it. It was the laugh of a woman who *really* liked - cock.

Rog was standing over me, his cock in his hand. At the base of his fist, his huge black balls hung, swinging slightly as he moved his cock toward April's mouth.

April was licking his cock playfully as he held it out to her. Her tongue darted out to lick him, and then she teased with a smile before flicking her tongue out to him again.

"Okay, so for this you gotta tip your head back a little," Rog said, pushing on April's forehead with two fingers. April tipped her head, still smiling, still laughing her wild whoreish laugh, hands on my chest, gripping my chest hair.

Not that I could feel it: I was transfixed as Rog moved himself into position, standing directly over her, pushing her down a little and making her arch her back so that he could feed his cock into her mouth at a nearly vertical angle. April's breasts swung as he moved her around, his dick dragging over her face and lips, as her tongue sought him out in adventurous licks.

Rog put both of his hands on April's head as he crouched a little and pointed his dick at her mouth. April swallowed the crown of his cock and sucked on it as he talked. "Now what you gotta do is the same thing you do when you get fucked on the bed, just open right up and let me slide in. I'll go nice and slow, but once I'm in there, you just let me take over. I gotta really slam it, if you want that same effect. Okay?"

Rog brushed her hair away tenderly. "Just slap my ass if you want me to pull out," he said. And then, almost as if he were speaking to himself, voice lowered to almost a whisper, he added, "But April never wants nobody to pull out, does she?"

I stared as he began to slide into April's throat. Her pussy squeezed tightly around my cock the deeper Rog went in.

From where I was, I had a view of a lot of things, but all I could see was the fat lump of cock slowly moving down April's throat. It seemed as if her neck was swelling, and for a moment I was afraid for her: seeing

this act up close like this made it seem even filthier, even more depraved, than the video we had watched or even my imagination.

April's hands were still on my chest.

"Don't forget to look up here, baby," Rog said, as the final inches of his cock disappeared into April's throat. "Yeah, I like that, that's the best part, you keep that up and Rog will give you a nice bonus too. I like watching while I just slam your face, you're a good girl, April, that's it. Good. Oh yeah, look right up here, I'm gonna let you take a nice deep breath and then I'm gonna start pounding you, you keep those eyes on me."

And then, another comment all to himself, it seemed: "Shit. Girl's a natural little slut."

His wet, dark cock seemed to ooze from April's mouth as he slowly brought it to just in front of her lips. April gulped at the air, and her sticky saliva gathered into a fat drop and slowly fell to my chest, still hot from her body. The sensation burned through me like an absorbed poison, sending a chill down my arms and the back of my neck.

Rog grasped April's head in both hands. "Ready?"

April gave a nod and opened her mouth wide to show her complete submission. Rog pushed back into her throat slowly, and then started to fuck my wife's face.

April gripped my chest hairs until they burned. The fat lump of Rog's cock rolled up and down her throat, each thrust ending with the wet slap of his balls crashing into the underside of her chin. I lifted her right hand to Rog's ass, so she could get him to stop, but she didn't ask him to. It seemed to go on forever, before Rog finally pulled out of her mouth.

He pushed her head down so I could see her face. Her mascara had run down the sides of her cheeks, her lips were raw and swollen, and saliva and precum dribbled down her chin. "Smile for Tommy," Rog said. April met my eyes, and smiled, before Rog tilted her head back. "Let's do it again, baby. Practice makes perfect."

Rog fucked her throat again, until I heard her slap him on the ass, and she gulped for air as Rog rubbed his cock over her face. Spit dripped onto my chest, rolled down April's face and neck.

"Open up, you can take it one more time," Rog told her.

April squirmed on my cock, her pussy squeezing hard. As Rog started to fuck her again I could take no more: I gripped her thighs and stared at the lump moving in her throat as I blasted my load into her pussy.

I heard Rog chuckle lightly. "Guess it looks all right," he commented. "Shit, that's fucking hot you little slut, you're so good at this, mmm."

Rog pulled out of April's throat and grasped his cock at the base. He slapped his meat on April's lips. "Oh she gonna come," he told no one in particular. "Yeah, that gets her all hotted up. Go on girl, ride that cock and make yourself come."

April was grinding her pussy against me. I dig my fingers into her thighs, shuddering with the over-stimulation on my still-hard dick. Her panting grew higher-pitched and she started to sweat as she bounced her way to an orgasm, her eyes on Rog, his cock sliding all over her face. When she came, her pussy clenched tightly around my dick and her juices exploded around me, gushing from her pussy and soaking my balls and between my thighs.

"That's too bad, baby. I wanted to get a little bit of that pussy before it was all sloppy. You think you can squeeze my cock like a good girl while I fuck that pussy?"

April nodded, gasping for air, and Rog toyed with her for a moment, pushing her hair from her face, dropping his balls into her open mouth.

Then, he pushed her backward by the forehead and she fell onto the pillows, tilting my cock at an almost painful downward angle until it popped from inside of her with a spurt. I scrambled out of the way, from underneath the tangle of April's legs, her hot pussy juices spilling all over me, as Rog moved in to stand over her, then dropped to his knees with her squirming body between his legs.

I half-fell off the edge of the bed. I was still shaking from my orgasm, and my cock was still semi-hard. I couldn't tear my eyes away from the scene as I stumbled toward a chair and sat on the edge of it.

Rog moved his knees in between April's legs one at a time, and then pushed her legs up and spread them wide. "Hold them open like that, baby."

April's engorged pussy split open and my cum oozed from inside of her, rolling into her butt crack. Her thighs glistened with her own cum. Rog directed his cock to the lips of her pussy, sliding the crown around in the spurting mess of glistening, crackling, pink flesh. April mewled when

he rubbed his dick against her clit, which seemed to pulse independently, throbbing and tender from her recent orgasm.

He looked over at me. "You like this, huh? I like fucking a pretty girl like April until they just a used-up rag. You lucky, she likes it, too, don't you baby?" He looked down at April. "You like it when you get fucked til you're just a dirty little used up whore full of cum, don't you?"

April lifted her head, still holding her legs wide, to watch Rog using his cock to play with her pussy.

"I want to hear you say it, you little slut. You love it."

"I love it," April panted, her eyes still on Rog's cock.

Rog chuckled and looked over at me. "She loves it." He turned back to April. "She loves Rog's big-ass cock, don't you baby?"

"Yes," April said.

Rog lined up his dick with April's hole and eased himself in. A juicy crackle came from between her legs, and I stared at the clearest view I'd had yet of his enormous girth stretching her wide open. Rog groaned in pleasure.

"Oh, she's still tight," he murmured. "She got a nice tight pussy. Hold on, little girl, you gonna get fucked *real* good now."

Rog started to hammer April, and by hammer, I mean *jackhammer*. He manhandled her, pounding his fat cock into her until she slid into the headboard and put one hand up, to keep her head from smashing into it. Her heels and legs bounced with each thrust, her tits rolled all over her chest. Her mouth was open and her eyes squeezed shut in an expression of mounting orgasmic pleasure that was too much to handle.

"Oh yeah, baby, I can feel it, you gonna come just in time, oh yeah," Rog grunted. His butt tensed and the muscles on his ripped back seized up as he started to tip over. He grasped April's legs and pushed them up and open, making her gasp - in pleasure or pain, I couldn't tell until she began to scream and come.

Rog bounced so hard on her that the headboard slapped into the wall and it seemed like the bed would break. "Oh, fuck. Fuck yeah, fuck!" he screamed, as his body shuddered and he dumped his load into my wife.

When he collapsed on top of April, her legs went limp, her thighs quivering. Her arms deflated similarly, and she seemed to be nothing more than an unconscious heap.

Rog didn't linger long. He rose up, backing away from April and sucking on her right tit as he did. He rested back on his heels and slapped April's left hip to get her to roll over to the side. She moved like a rag doll, her face turning to look at me as she rolled. Her eyes had that vacant look that she often got when she'd been so thoroughly fucked.

Rog slapped her ass playfully. "What a fucking grade-A slut," he said. He moved his hand down her ass and into her ass crack, making sticky sounds fill the air as he played with whatever he could reach between her legs. "She ain't even done yet, neither," he told me, smiling. "She'll take it in the ass now, anything you want to do, she'll just take it like a good little slut. Won't you, baby?"

April mewled and squirmed. I couldn't see clearly, but I guessed that Rog was slipping his finger into her butt. He watched her as he twisted his finger around inside of her ass, probing her insides. His own cock was barely softened, and it began to twitch back to life almost instantly.

He played with April's ass for a while, watching her muted reaction, finger-fucking her until she began to stir, genuinely aroused again.

"See, these chicks that actually like it in the ass are hard to find. But you know them when you fuck them, they get all fucking hot getting their ass fucked."

Rog pushed April onto her stomach, his fingers still in her ass. Now I could see that he had two fingers inside of her, which he dipped quickly. They slid in easily, in part because April was a seasoned slut, and helped along by the sticky cum that had slid into her crack and down to her ass. Her face was still turned toward me.

Rog moved back behind her and grabbed her hips to prop her up, ass in the air. Her head was turned toward me, her eyes rekindling but still fixed on something in outer space, beyond me, beyond this room.

Rog slid his cock into her pussy and April moaned. "Just gotta get my dick nice and wet, baby," Rog told her. "I'm gonna be in there a nice long time, you don't want your ass all tore up, do you?"

Rog moved slowly in April's pussy, coating his cock in the loads of cum that were still spilling from inside her, running down her thighs in opaque pearly streaks.

Rog looked over at me. "You wanna hit this, man?"

I shook my head, or at least believed that I did. My face had melted into an expressionless stare, jaw agape, eyes darting from April's face to

Rog's cock.

Rog shrugged and dragged a glob of cum up to April's asshole with his dick. "Now you gonna see how much she likes it. Go on, baby. Show him how much you like a big black cock in your ass, show him that slutty little smile of yours while you take it."

April seemed stunned as Rog pushed inside of her. It was a tight fit, however seasoned April was, and her mouth opened and her eyes closed, her hand balling up some material on the bed. "Ohhhh," she mewled. She was panting.

"Just let it slide right in, baby," Rog told her. "There you go, now you're loosening up, oh yeah, now you ready."

April opened her eyes.

Rog started to saw in and out of her, taking it slow at first, building to a medium speed. April looked at me and her eyes began to light up.

"Show him that smile, April, baby. I like that too, be a good girl."

I stared as my wife's mouth formed a smile that indeed could only be called "slutty." She continued to smile as Rog started to hammer her.

My eyes went wide. "April," I said, in a whisper. I looked at Rog. "You're hurting her," I told him.

Rog snorted. "That look like a girl that don't like it?" He looked down at April. "Am I hurting you, baby? Your ass hurt?"

April was still smiling. "My ass hurts, oh, oh my, oh my... oh my god," she panted.

"You like it, though, don't you?"

"Oh, oh, yes..."

"You like a big black cock deep in your ass,"

"Uh," April said. Her eyes faded closed, but her smile remained.

Rog slapped her ass. "Look at your hubby while you're taking it, baby. He likes that. He likes to see you getting all the cock you want."

April opened her eyes and stared at me, smiling, as Rog fucked her for what seemed like an eternity. He went faster, then slower, then paused, at one point, staring down at April's upturned ass, trying, it looked like, not to come yet.

And then, after it seemed like I had gone into a time warp, one in which I would be trapped for all of eternity on that chair watching Rog fuck my wife in the ass while she grinned at me, the shape of her smile a

relentless scythe slicing through my heart, Rog leaned down over April's body and whispered in her ear.

The next thing I knew, he was pulling her up by the shoulder and hair, turning as he did, seating her on his lap, his dick never leaving her ass. They came to rest facing me, April's legs spread wide, now, by some miracle of physics, on either side of Rog's legs. She put her hands up around his neck, and leaned back, so her entire magnificent front was splayed open for me to see.

Rog's hands moved all over her, slipping over her skin as though they were both oiled. He mauled her breasts, sucked on her shoulder, licked her face. Meanwhile, April's pussy yawned open, and Rog pushed her thighs apart further, so that the crushed, reddened lips of her cunt stretched apart and the last remnants of my cum oozed from inside of her, slowly dripping onto the sawing snake of his cock.

He said, loudly enough for me to hear:

"You wanna come again, little girl? Yeah, you do. You wanna come with my dick in your ass, I know you do. You like that." He turned to look at me, and grinned, as he said this final bit. "So good," he continued, to April. "You ride my cock, do a real good job, make me come. And then I'll give you a reward for being a good little slut."

He placed one hand around April's neck, holding her up with it from behind. April looked at me through her sweaty, messed hair, her eyes feverish. And then she began to ride Rog's cock, just as he had asked.

At this angle, his dick was pushing forward inside of April's ass hard enough to stretch against the walls of her vagina, the inside of which I could just glimpse in the center of her mushy, sticky petals. April mewled and howled as she worked hard, sweat building at her temples, to milk Rog's cock.

"Good girl," Rog told her. "Oh yeah, keep it up. Ride it."

April's eyes started to close, and her face twisted in concentration. Rog seized her hip and started to jam her up and down on his dick just before he came. April continued to bounce on him as he tipped his head back and groaned, his cum beginning to spurt from her ass with each bounce.

Rog put both hands on her inner thighs and spread her legs so wide that her body looked almost disfigured. April wrapped her legs behind him, and leaned against his back, her hands moving all over his head. She was

moaning rhythmically, almost cooing. "Please," she moaned. She tried to move her hips, but to no avail.

Rog looked at me and winked. He pushed April's hair away from her neck and bit her earlobe. "You been good enough?" he said. "Hmm? What do you think, Thomas?"

But if Rog wanted my response, he didn't wait for it. His hand moved down April's body, and he cupped her mound, two fingers plunging into her pussy. His other hand was on her neck, supporting her head, which it seemed April really needed because she had lost control of it - it rolled on her shoulders as she mewled and gasped.

"She likes this a whole lot," Rog said, though without looking at me.

He finger-fucked April until she screamed. When she came, her body went rigid and Rog laughed. "She squeezin' so hard on my dick, oh yeah..." he said, as he rammed his fingers hard into her pussy. Juices and cum rolled over his knuckles, onto the back of his hand, between their legs, covering his balls.

April screamed and then her cries faded to a heap of incomprehensible mewls, and her body went completely limp.

Rog pushed her forward, and backed away from her, his cock flopping out of her with a wet slap. "Do that thing with your hair," he said, looking down at April.

My wife remained as he had left her, with her ass in the air. She pushed her hair up and away from her face, and Rog admired the view, but backing away, toward his kitchen. "Need a water," he said, and then he turned and strolled away.

April collapsed to the side and then rolled onto her back. She twisted her head to look at me. "Oh my God," she said, drawing her fingers up to her mouth. But this was not a thoughtful gesture. She was smiling. Like the devil.

CHAPTER 12

Rog offered us a drink afterward, but I declined on April's behalf. "I think she's gotta get home and get to bed, if she's doing this again tomorrow night," I said. April was lying on the bed, looking zoned-out, and so I pulled her legs out to the edge and sat her up by pulling on her arm until she rose to sitting.

"Right?" I asked her.

April brought a hand to her lips, the faraway expression still pasted to her face. I fetched her dress, helped her stand up, and pulled the dress down over her shoulders. She snapped out of it as soon as I zipped her up, when a shudder of ticklish pleasure traveled through her body as my fingers passed over her spine.

"You gonna be okay to do this again tomorrow?" I asked, a hint of real worry in my voice. More than a hint of real worry was also in my mind. How many times could April perform these kinds of wild tricks? How many times could Rog shove his huge cock in her ass, before she just couldn't take anymore? Or until she became permanently detached from the April I had married?

It wasn't, to my mind, at that moment, so much of an erotic fantasy question - the kind I enjoyed asking myself because they turned me on - as a real, legitimate question about physics.

April looped an arm over my neck - it was only then that I remembered she had consumed a few more drinks than she ordinarily would - and brought her lips to my ear. "I'll be fine. But we definitely need to go home."

She was quiet on the way home. Halfway there, she seemed to realize that we were in a cab. "Oh," she said sourly. "I need to get my car before I get a ticket."

"I'll get it for you in the morning," I told her.

It was the least I could do.

"I need to go to bed," she said, as soon as she walked through the door. She fumbled with her heels and stepped out of them, twisting her arm behind her back to unzip her dress, and failing. I rushed to help, admittedly in order to make an attempt to put the moves on her, and she smiled and

seemed, for a moment, like she might get into it, but then she wriggled around to kiss me on the cheek.

The scent of sex was everywhere on her, and I knew that Rog's cum lingered everywhere on her body. It was disturbingly arousing, but the arousal was different than the one I had been feeling just a moment before. "I'm too tired for any more," she said. "Sorry."

"Do you want a bath or something?" I asked her. "I'll get it ready for you. Epsom salts and all."

"Yeah, that sounds great," she said, her voice distant and her eyes faraway and sleepy. She trudged down the hallway, her gait impaired minutely by the soreness between her legs.

She tossed herself on the bed, her dress still on, halfway unzipped. The shoes she had picked up were still in her hand. "I'll wait here," she said sleepily.

I heard the shoes, still clutched in her hand, fall to the floor with a thunk. I finished running the bath anyway. But, of course, April was already asleep, still partially clad in her dress, tipped over with her legs dangerously close to the edge.

I pulled her dress off and rolled her from side to side to get her under the covers, and then I stared at her for a while as she slept. I ran my fingers over her legs, over the dried cum between her thighs, and then leaned close to breathe in the scent of her skin.

It was still there, beneath all the layers of filthy sex.

I drained the water in the tub, vowing angrily, as I watched it drain, to finish the shower project, took a shower myself, and jerked off uneasily (there is nothing to grab onto in our shower but the curtain ring, which falls down if you're too... exuberant) with the images that had seared into my brain that night piling on top of each other, melting, distorting, turning muddy and dark, like the first flakes of freshly fallen snow in the street.

*

I fetched April's car for her in the morning, leaving her sleeping peacefully between the sheets that reeked as though we had made love all night. I didn't have to set an alarm. I was up anyway.

It was the kind of blinding, bright morning that the world only seems to bestow upon you when you have a hangover and have misplaced

your sunglasses. We lived east of Charlie Browns, so I squinted all the way home and had a good headache going by the time I got there.

I was hoping to find April still sleeping, and try to nudge her into a very gentle, very loving morning lovemaking session, or to at least have the opportunity to feel the crushing, arousing stab of being turned down by her so that she could properly service Rog again that night, while "Mr. Smith" watched.

But April was already up: coffee was brewing and the shower was running.

I did a thing I had done before, which I can admit to having done: I sort of sneaked up on her.

If April ever asked why I did this, I would say that I was trying to scare the shit out of her. It was the kind of thing that I was immature enough, still, in my mid-thirties, to be credibly guilty of having intended to do.

I even half-believed that story myself. I mean, it really was true: scaring a beautiful naked woman covered in water and soap and making her scream and jump around and call you an asshole is fun, even if you're old enough to understand why it might also be considered a work of complete assholery.

But what I was actually almost always *actually* trying to do was catch April masturbating in the shower. I *hoped* to find her doing that.

I knew that women probably didn't do that in the shower, because there isn't as much as a convenience factor to it as for men. But I also knew that women didn't bounce around in their underwear hitting each other with feather pillows and laughing about it when they had a Girls' Night, but that didn't stop me from creeping into the house if April had friends over, on the off chance that I would discover exactly that.

So I was creeping, wondering if April masturbated, how often, and to what, and if I could ever truly know the answer to that question, when she shut off the water.

"Are you there?" she asked, sounding like she knew for certain that I was.

"Thomas," she complained. "If you sneak up on me..."

"Okay, okay," I said.

"I *knew* it. Hand me a towel, would you? I've been in here like a fish waiting for you to get home."

I pulled the curtain all the way back to hand her the towel. I couldn't get a very good read off her tone: she sounded perfectly normal. This was the voice of Saturday-morning-going-for-a-run-April.

But she couldn't just be *normal*, could she?

"Thanks," she said, putting the towel first to her face and then toweling off hurriedly. "I'm in a rush," she said. "I forgot I'm meeting Margot for a coffee."

"Huh? But you made coffee."

She stepped out, kissing me briefly, and painfully perfunctorily, and then skipped into the bedroom. "That was before I remembered."

April was moving around the way she did when she got into a hurry, which became clumsy at times. She stumbled a little on the way out of the closet, attempting, as far as I could tell, to put a sandal on while walking.

She put a hand on my shoulder for balance while putting on the shoe. She was wearing a sundress that she seemed to have put on in a matter of seconds, with no time to put on anything else. As she leaned forward I caught her breasts swinging loosely in the flowered fabric, unhindered by a bra.

She kissed me on the cheek just as I was getting ready to say something about that - though what it might have been, I will never know, because after thinking about it for a while, I realized I would likely have said something stupid.

"So... see you tonight? Before I go out?"

I took this as an invitation to try one more time to seduce her. But she was slippery, smiling, out of my grasp too quickly. She rushed into the bathroom and did something very hastily with makeup that didn't, as far as I could tell, change her fresh-faced appearance very much.

And then off she trotted, in a fairly conservative sundress, fresh-faced and beautiful, to have an innocent coffee with Margot, who was such a boring friend I couldn't even remember if I had met her.

My wife, who was probably not wearing any underwear under that "conservative dress", and who had been riding my cock with another man's dick in her throat just ten hours earlier.

I went to work dog-tired and distracted enough that people were giving me the kind of knowing looks and elbow jabs that indicated that they believed me and my wife had perhaps left for another bar, or a nice dinner, and had too many bottles of wine. In truth, I wasn't especially hungover, in fact, I could have driven home from Rog's place if I had been in possession of my car. I was exhausted from not sleeping, but the foggy thinking I was exhibiting was a product of my inability to think about anything other than what my wife had done the night before - and what she was going to do tonight.

An atmosphere of cool electricity hovered just above the surface of my skin all day because of these thoughts, making the hairs on my skin actually stand up a little.

Did I like this feeling? I wondered from time to time. In some ways, it was like the obsession of new love, at least in its intensity. In other ways, it made me utterly ill, but I was starting to think that maybe I was just an addict to the intensity of the feeling. That didn't sound like me, though.

A long day dragged on, and then I got involved in a meeting and a conference call, neither of which I had any reason to attend because I had nothing to contribute, so I missed April's text to me at about three in the afternoon.

*Change of plans
G has to go home this weekend*

That was it. That was the message. I read it at 4:45, just as I was getting ready to walk by the boss and see if I could leave early.

What did that mean, change of plans?

What does that mean, change of plans?

I wrote.

And then I sat in my chair, staring at my phone, as the work phone rang away and the minutes ticked by, until something like half an hour had passed.

"Thomas."

Someone had been speaking to me for a long time. A female voice. I looked up. It was Anna from-whatever-department.

"You've been staring at your phone like that for like twenty minutes."

"At least," I noted.

"You okay?"

I rubbed my face. "It's been a long day."

Anna laughed because she thought she knew what I meant by that, and asked me if I was staying late.

"I gotta run, actually," I said.

I called April as I exited the building and was almost hit by a slow-moving delivery truck as a result. The phone rang in my ear and ceded only to her voice, cheerful, innocent, saying her name in the middle of the standard greeting.

"April, I got, uh... your message, just unclear what you mean by that. Anyway, I'm heading home. See you there."

Heading home. Not panicking or acting like an obsessed psycho.

I forced myself to drive like a normal human being, but it only lasted part of the drive. It was getting close to 7:00 by the time I was inching my way off the exit ramp - I had forgotten that leaving my office at 5:30 was no different, in terms of arrival-time, than leaving at 6:15.

April had not called or texted, and I had held the phone in my hand all the way home. My fingers were sore from the absurd grip I had used to hold on to the wheel and phone at the same time. The phone was connected to the car via bluetooth, but somehow I had believed that seeing the message just an instant faster by having the actual phone in my hand was going to change something.

April's car was not in the garage. Relief washed over me before I plunged into an icy pit of jealous despair. I thought I was early, and would catch her before she left. And then I realized: maybe she was already gone. Though quite where she had gone, given Mr. Smith's change of plans, was anyone's guess.

Or maybe I was insane, I thought, bitterly closing the car door and stretching out the fingers of my aching hand.

I set the phone down and stared at it some more, as though staring at it would will April to call or text me.

But there was nothing else I could do except wait.

Ok, I could send her more messages, try to call her again, but if I did either of those things I would seem frantic, untrusting, and - I guess in

my opinion, at least - pretty weak-willed and crazy. After all, what reason did I have to be calling April incessantly, and checking up on what she meant by her text, if I *really* trusted her? What did I expect to discover her doing? *Not* going to "Greg's" peeping-Tom apartment to practice her newly acquired skills?

I poured myself a drink, set it on the counter, and stared some more. I was unable to drink it, unable to perform the simple task of lifting the glass to my lips. My hand was shaking, anyway.

"God, April!" I shouted.

What kind of crazy, demented psycho sends a message like that and *then doesn't follow up* on it?

I shouted this question loudly to the empty house.

Almost as if the cosmos had somehow delivered my angry diatribe to April, the screen of my phone lit up, and it rumbled from the counter top.

But it wasn't April. Or Lilith. Or anyone who could tell me where she was.

It was just a reminder that I had used a lot of data, because, like an idiot, when I replaced my broken phone, I had asked to reduce the data on my plan.

CHAPTER 13

April finally texted me at about a quarter after nine.

*Coming home now
I thought I sent you a message but it didn't go
We went early
I'll tell you all about it when I get home*

I started to type a reply, but I couldn't get past the first few words. I thought about calling her, and then changed my mind, and then changed it again. I dialed.

There's only so much a man can take.

The first call rang and rang, then went to voicemail.

A switch flipped inside me, at that moment. It had happened to me before, though not about April or even any other woman. Once the switch flips, however, *that* Thomas starts doing some truly irrational stuff, and the wiser version of Thomas sort of checks out.

I dialed again.

And again.

Was I acting like a crazy person? Sure. April was on her way home from downtown. She was probably driving. She couldn't answer if that was true, because April is afraid of answering the phone while she drives, even on the hands-free device. Calling her more was only going to make me look crazy and possibly annoy her.

I dialed again anyway.

The third digital ring was cut short and the ambient noise a car full of drunks filled my ear. The phone was moving around; the sounds were alternately distorted, muffled, or too loud. A male voice laughed, and indistinct chatter was audible in the background.

"Honey," April said, after a few too many seconds of this. "What -"

Then a thunk, April's laugh distantly, a scraping sound, the voice of a man, none of it intelligible, and April calling: "Just a second, you fell - I dropped it under... the... seat..."

A low, deep laugh, and a comment. April giggled. The sound was muffled, and then I heard a scraping noise again.

April was panting when she spoke next. "I'm sorry," she whispered, her voice mimicking Lilith's breathless excitement in every way, enough to make me temporarily disoriented. "I dropped it under the seat. Hey. I'm... I'm almost home -"

"Tell him to meet us at that place," someone was saying loudly. A deep voice I didn't recognize.

"I can't," April said, her voice strange. "I can't - they want you to come out with us, I told them no. Anyway, we just have to swing by *mmmrfrfmmsmar* and then I'll be there.. like, I don't know, in an hour. Okay?"

An hour was far too long at this time of night for April to be anywhere but miles past my place of work, almost outside of the entire metro area. And where was *mmmmrfrfmmsmar*?

"I can't really hear you," I said.

Music began playing. A heavy bass beat, rattling windows, the vibrations nothing more than a loud, low roar over the phone. "What? Hey, I can't hear at all. I'll be home soon."

"April," I said, uselessly.

"See you soon, honey, I love you."

Laughter - though I really don't think at my expense in particular - had already begun to erupt inside the vehicle. And then all sound was gone as the connection ended.

*

An hour went by, during which time, the whole time, I thought of the car that April was in, and what she was doing there. Who was the man whose voice I hadn't recognized? Who had April sitting on his lap? Was she seated between her two (at least) male friends, a forearm resting on each man's thigh, like a queen seated on a throne, but with their dicks swelling in her hand, waiting for the promise of her lips yet again sliding down the meaty column all the way to the base? First one, then the other, and then a searing glance for the driver, before diving in again?

Another hour passed. I called her again, now actually concerned about safety.

At 11:37 she sent me a text.

I missed your call

*I'm sorry
I lost track of time*

I stared at the message, fury building up in my chest. Infantile desires blossomed inside my chest: to type something hokey like "how dare you," to spank my wife when she got home, to go looking for her, somehow, to play it cool like I was in seventh grade.

I did none of those things, because she called me.

"April," I said, my voice stern and annoyed. I was unable to change it. I wasn't even sure why I would.

"Babe," she said, sounding intoxicated. Not slurring, just not like herself. "I'm sorry."

She was whispering, but her voice echoed. Loud music was muffled in the background, and then it broke through. I heard a toilet flush and the shriek of some girls. "I lost track of... everything, I really don't, I really didn't know what time it was... now I'm here, so I'm going to, you know, go home..."

"Where *are* you?" I yelled, even though I could hear her fine.

"At a... I don't even know..." her voice trailed off. Giggling, she asked another girl where they were.

The answer was unintelligible. April was unintelligible when she repeated it. The door to the bathroom must have opened again, and stayed that way, because it was very loud on the other end of the phone.

"I'll be right home!" she yelled. "I'm sorry."

And then she waited, maybe thinking I was saying something standard. I said nothing. April was distracted, moving through the music and the place where she was, the sound changing around her, a laugh suppressed in her throat.

"Me too," she yelled. "I'll be right there."

I caught a laugh as the phone cut off.

Twenty minutes later I received another text from April's phone.

*She's fine
Be a big boy*

It was followed by a picture. April's pale skin, framed by her sundress - the same one she had worn out so early in the morning - and her

dark hair over one shoulder, shining and black. Across her chest, the dark skin of a man with large forearms, the fingers of his hand disappearing beneath the fabric of the dress, other hand cupping her breast possessively. The photo cut off just below April's nose, so all I could see of her face was her mouth: lips red, open in a wide smile, like she was in the middle of laughing at a joke.

CHAPTER 14

"What in the *hell*, April?!" I shouted.

April clumsily pushed the door closed behind her, holding up her right hand, which also had the keys in it, to ask me to stop. The keys dropped to the floor and I was pretty sure I heard something crack. "I know," she said, her voice strangely contrite, yet also carefree. "I know," she repeated, and her voice cracked. "I'm so thirsty," she said. "I just need a big glass of water."

She walked unsteadily toward the hallway to the kitchen, and I took a few steps and pushed her down into the sofa. "Just sit here," I said bitterly. "I'll get it."

April drank the water like she had just run ten miles in Arizona at one in the afternoon.

"So?" I said.

April held her fist to her chest for a second. "I know," she said, and then she very delicately and endearingly burped. "I know I... I'm sorry, I know I was, I didn't call you... the time just really got away after the car..." she waved her hand at the air.

"April, are you high?"

April sighed, and let her arms fall to her sides. "I didn't mean to... it just, uh... well, I don't really know." Her eyes lit up suddenly. She dug into a purse - a large, clunky handbag that wasn't really her style and didn't seem to be hers - and pulled out her phone. She reached toward me, holding the phone with a floppy hand. "I have a video for you," she said, smiling.

Then she fell sideways, her feet still on the floor, her head on a big pillow. Her eyelids seemed heavy, and I was pretty sure she was going to fall asleep each time they closed. But she kept reopening them, looking at me, holding the phone out.

I took it from her. She smiled.

"Please don't be mad at me, Thomas. I had to... you know... change plans."

She yawned. I put her code into the phone - I knew it from several "system administration" tasks I'd been given - and went first, under a sneaking suspicion, to her messenger.

"Was Lilith out with you?" I asked.

"Huh?" April said, yawning. "Oh... Lilith. Yeah, she was..." April waved her hand. "There." A long pause, and then April's eyes opened again. "Why?"

"No reason," I said, already delving into April's camera. There was nothing there except some old videos, from weeks before.

"Is it on your camera?" I asked.

I knew that there were about three hundred other things I needed to clear up with April. Like why she had sent so many mysterious and unintelligible texts, who the other guy was, why she had gone to a club after telling me she was coming home, why she was still wearing her sundress from this morning, if she had gone or not gone to see "Mr. Smith..." the list went on.

But I didn't actually care about any of that at that exact moment. I cared about one thing, and one thing only, and that was the "video" that April had for me, the promise of its sexually deviant material, the hope that I would see my wife in yet another depraved act, maybe with someone new she had never fucked before.

April reached out for her phone, smiling, looking for all the world like she was about to fall asleep. I gave it to her.

She scanned, at first casually, then she sat up and frowned.

"Huh," she said, her brow furrowed.

"Huh?"

She held her hand to her head. "Maybe... it was someone else's phone... I was sure it was mine..."

I was pretty lit by this time, because I'm not the sort of man to sit around not knowing who my wife is fucking or whether I want her to be or not, and not have anything to drink. So a picture was coming into focus, but only as in-focus as it could get, given my level of intoxication.

Which wasn't all that clear.

"You said Lilith was there?" I asked.

"No," April said, giving me a quizzical look.

"You just said you saw Lilith."

April was still swiping through the phone, her brow furrowed, fingers to her head.

"At the club..." she said distantly. She was distracted by the phone, shaking her head. "It must have been... I could have sworn I did this, I set it all up..."

"Did Lilith ever have your phone?"

"... I'm sure it was here, it was right - what?"

"Did Lilith use your phone?"

April looked at me and blinked. She was obviously way more intoxicated than I had realized. Her eyes were black, consumed by her pupils. She didn't understand what I was asking her. This conversation was going nowhere.

And anyway, I had a feeling there was nowhere for it to go, because Lilith had her fingerprints all over this.

*

April slept for what seemed like an eternity. In the morning, feeling a great deal more sober and clear-headed, I took her phone and confirmed what I had thought I confirmed before: someone had deleted the outgoing message to me, the photo of the black guy holding April's breast, and possibly whatever video April believed that she had on the phone.

And that someone, I was willing to bet, was Lilith.

I indulged, while making myself a version of a Bloody Mary (warm V8 from the stash in the cupboard, much vodka, almost half a large bottle of Tabasco, and half a shaker of salt) in a fantasy about Lilith. How I would march over to her expensive-ass house like I had before, find her in the sauna naked, and then strangle her while telling her to stay out of my wife's life and mine.

But I knew nothing would end like that, not if I actually went over there to do it, because Lilith had the same gift that I had for talking her way out of anything. Granted, Lilith did it the way all women who have that gift do it: by drawing you into a sexually charged fantasy/nightmare with just her voice.

What I didn't get about Lilith - and what I wanted more than anything in the world to be able to squeeze out of her mouth by squeezing on her pretty neck - was what the hell she was up to. I mean, sure, I had some idea: it was money, and sex, and somehow she was making it rain both those things in what seemed to be a very beneficial plan for herself. But the lack of details irked me - they lurked around in dark corners and places I didn't really want to look into.

And Lilith, I suspected, knew that about me.

Nothing irritates me more than people *actually* figuring me out. My entire marriage was sort of held together with a glue made from a delicate balance of April understanding me and not understanding me.

"Fucking Lilith," I muttered.

April continued to sleep, and I became impatient and crazy, and even got in the car to enact my fantasy trip to Lilith's house. Halfway there, I realized I'd be making a fool of myself: what did I really want from Lilith anyway? It wasn't like the last time I had done that, when I had had something tangible to gain from it.

So I turned around.

And then I turned around again.

Lilith's yard, however, was like a parking lot, full of black SUVs, all of which had tickets on them. Music was still playing inside the house, loud enough to hear but not loud enough to call the cops. Or perhaps Lilith's neighbors were as afraid of her as I was. Lights were still on, and when I went up to the door, I caught a glimpse of entwined naked thighs - none of them Lilith's - on the floor.

Then I heard a voice, and laughter, and it was all deep and masculine.

I made a decision that I look back upon as wise. I left.

April called me when I was about two minutes away. I didn't answer.

"Where *were* you?" April asked, her voice slightly panicked, when I walked through the door.

She had taken a shower and was wrapped in a red silk robe that I had given her a year ago but which she never wore. It was short, flimsy, and very sexy. Her hair was tumbling from a hasty bun and some of it clung to her neck, still damp.

She threw herself at me and hugged me. "I thought you were really mad and maybe... I don't know, left or something."

"I went for..." I began, about to tell a lie. I thought about not telling it, telling April I had driven to Lilith's house, and why. I thought of spilling everything, right there, and letting April see inside of me, see all the perverse things that lived deep within me.

But I stopped myself for some reason. A lesser man would tell another lie here, and say that I stopped myself because my shirt was getting wet, because April was crying, but that wasn't the only reason.

"Hey," I said, holding her closer. "What is it?"

She rubbed her face on my chest. "I'm just... I don't really know what happened last night, I just... I knew you were mad, I know that I stayed out... and then there was all this crazy stuff with my message..."

"What crazy stuff with your message. April, hey." I pushed her gently away from me. "What are you talking about?"

She shook her head. "Okay, so... that's what... I just don't even really know. I sent you a message, you know - wait, do you know what happened?"

This was aggravating. Classic, but aggravating.

"April," I said slowly, because I was certain of one thing and one thing only, and that was that I did not have the patience to listen to April tell one of her disjointed, crazy, non-linear stories. "I do not understand anything you are saying. I need you to start at the beginning, and then tell me the next thing that happened, and then the thing after that, and so on."

Because I still couldn't actually believe that there were people in this world who lived their lives or ordered their thoughts any differently, much less that I somehow loved someone who was like that.

April seemed a little put out by this - and I was certain I was headed for a lecture about My Tone. Which was fine, because My Tone gets all the blame for everything, and I just apologize on behalf of My Tone and then we move on.

"I sent... you a message," April began. "About changing the plans for last night. It was last minute because of his wife - Mr. Smith, or whatever his name is - his wife. He had to be back this weekend. So he wanted to see if I could come earlier, because he was... well, you know. Really looking forward to... that. And I could, and Rog could, but we needed ... uh, you know, another black guy. Or that's what he wanted. And so Lilith found -"

"Lilith," I said. "Why is Lilith already in this story?"

"I mean... she's the one who... arranged all this," April said. Like I had asked why milk had showed up for a milkshake.

I set it aside, temporarily, with a vow to get back to it eventually. I thought of April meeting Margot for coffee, and the meeting took on a

sinister tone. Maybe it had all been part of the plot...

I shook my head minutely to myself. I knew Margot. She was a real person. And Lilith didn't get up that early in the morning, nor would she have had any reason to. I was becoming paranoid, seeing sinister acts in every detail I didn't witness for myself.

"Okay, so Lilith... gets into this somehow -"

"She was in it because she was the one who called me about changing the time. And also trying to get Rog and Jay -"

"Jay. Jay? Who is this Jay? And *why*, April, *why* is Lilith doing all of this?"

"Jay is the other guy. You know. He's... uh, well, the guy from the other night. See the thing is that all of these people have to know what they're doing, be willing to follow all the rules, you know, that kind of thing."

I stared at her.

"Let me finish my story," she pleaded, casting her eyes down. "We had to change the time and I wrote you a message about it... but I somehow didn't send the whole thing, you know, like the last part explaining all that."

She looked up at me. I was thinking, thinking back on the message she had sent me.

"By the time I realized it, everything was already over, so... you know, I sent you the message that I was coming home. And then you called and..."

Her voice trailed off, and she held her hands out like she was done explaining, as if that explained everything.

"Why did you go to a *club* after that, April? Why were you high? Why were you so drunk or high or whatever in the car when I called you?! And why were you still hooking up with these guys *after* you called me and said you were going home?!"

April was nodding along guiltily with every one of these accusations, a fat teardrop swelling to life in her right eye, brimming over. It splashed onto her cheek when she jerked her head up as I said the final sentence, and something flared inside of her - her eyes moved quickly, and her mouth tightened.

But then she seemed to drop it, and she leaned in to my chest, putting her forehead against it. I felt a wet tear on my chest. "I don't know," she said. "I really don't know how it all happened, one thing led to another."

She looked back up at me. "But I wasn't *hooking up* with anyone at that club."

Her eyes narrowed.

I had the option, at that moment, of telling her why I had said that. But if I did, if I told her that Lilith had sent me that text and photo, and that she had also deleted it from April's outgoing messages so that April wouldn't know about it, then I was also going to end up having to tell April about every other thing I had done, somewhat nefariously, somewhat dishonestly, but definitely somewhat behind April's back.

There are two kinds of people in the world, if you ask me: the ones who are reading what I just wrote and screaming inside: *Thomas, you asshole, you have to be honest, and you have to communicate, and you're the real shit in this story.* The kind of person who honestly believes they would behave so much differently. In this category, too, are those rare people who actually would.

These people are all full of their own shit.

Because the second kind of person is the kind of person who thinks all that stuff, for sure. We all know you "have to be honest" and "have good communication" with your wife. But this group of people knows that they, too, do not rise to this standard themselves, and so they are thinking: *Yeah, Thomas, you're probably shooting yourself in the foot here, but I would probably do the same thing... I've done similar things... I'll probably do similar things again someday.*

It was possible that April didn't define "hooking up" the same way I did. It was also possible that she figured letting a guy stick his hand up her dress was not so bad a thing to do, if you had just slept with this guy. I had to admit that I didn't really have a stellar argument against it.

I just *felt* annoyed by it.

April brushed away a tear with impatience and took a step back from me. "You know what?" she said quietly. "This is... not what I wanted. I don't want to fight with you. I don't want to -"

"We aren't really fighting," I said. "It's not - I'm not mad at you, I'm sure all of this has an explanation -"

"No," April said, wiping away a tear. "No, you know what? It's all just... getting a little out of control. It's getting to be too much. You know?"

"I thought you were having fun," I said. I wasn't really sure which side of this argument I was on, or even what it was about anymore. All I

knew was that April seemed to be making one of her decisions, and when she did that, if she did it in a certain way, then there would be no going back from there.

So now I felt the same sense of loss of control, but now it wasn't April or her loyalty that was slipping between my fingers, but rather something else: this whole new adventure.

Did I want it to continue?

Panic started spreading from my chest outward. I felt like I needed to act, to do something, but I didn't know which direction to go.

It's getting to be too much. You know?

April was shaking her head. She held her hands out and let them fall to her sides. "Is this fun?" she asked. She looked up at me. "Like yesterday night. I just... I don't really feel in control of myself. Anymore. And now... I lost that video, or maybe I was too..." she sighed and brought her hands to her face. "I think maybe we should just go back to, like, being a normal couple for a while."

The complete 180 turn that she had just made had given me whiplash. Part of me was sinking, wobbling to the bottom of a dark lake of despair. This wasn't something I had expected April to say, or think.

But April was crying, and hugging me, and she was telling me she wanted to go back to being a regular couple with me, her husband.

There was no reason not to be the tiniest bit happy and relieved about that.

And part of me was.

But standing in the hallway, hugging my wife, I couldn't help but feel a little bit of disappointment for it all slipping through our – well, my - fingers, so suddenly.

I stroked her hair.

"Whatever you want, April," I said. "Whatever you want."

CHAPTER 15

We talked about it in more detail after that, using up the whole weekend lying in bed, talking about the adventure we had been on, having some hot but gentle sex, and generally making up. Things were mostly tame in bed, a series of tender lovemaking sessions, but I can only remember one, because it stands out in my mind and washed all the others away. We were facing each other, kissing, enjoying the sweaty sheen of each other's bodies, and I slid my fingers over April's hip and into the crack of her ass, going further, until I found the slippery, taut pucker of her ass, slick with cum that had oozed from her pussy after a previous fuck. Coated in our mingled cum, my index and middle finger slipped easily into her ass, and her eyes went wide as they plunged inside of her.

I don't know who began the roll that landed her atop me, my fingers still in her ass. She slid her pussy onto my cock, settling her weight against me, and rocked herself gently to a climax while my still-embedded fingers explored the velvet interior of her ass. Through the thin flesh in her body, I could feel the hardness of my own dick, and I stared up at April, and her changing expressions, as I worked my fingers around in her ass like a clock.

"Are you sore?" I asked her, when she seemed to wince. Her mouth was open, her eyes distant.

"I like it, though," she whispered, her mind somewhere else, her eyes seeing some other encounter, perhaps, or maybe she was blinded by her ecstasy. She was grinding against me, concerning herself with her own pleasure, her fingers digging into my chest whenever I hit a very sensitive place in the circle I was traveling inside her ass.

When she came, the tight ring of her anus clamped around my fingers, and the silky hot flesh in her ass pulsed around me. I imagined having my cock inside of her at a moment like this, briefly thought of how I had never sampled that pleasure and didn't think I could do it, and then I came, my own vision momentarily blurry with the pleasure of it.

By Sunday, I felt like we had really grown together again, and I was okay with putting all of this away for a long time, even forever.

After all, I had gotten what I wanted, and more than I had ever imagined possible, and now I was getting my wife back, and that was that.

Did I come clean about everything I had done? No. I had a sneaking suspicion that April had details she hadn't given to me in their entirety, things she had forgotten because of the drugs she had taken or the alcohol she had consumed. We both agreed that we had each pushed the envelope a little further each time, because it was exciting, because it seemed to have a momentum of its own. And of course, because of Lilith.

As for Lilith... April and I agreed that maybe she wasn't the greatest influence. We were going to take a break from Lilith, and all of the crazy things she got us into, at least for a while.

So Monday, April returned to school, and I went to work.

"Are you going to tell Lilith?" I asked her, as we settled in to sleep on Sunday night. April was lying on my chest, her fingers playing with my hair.

"I'll do it," she said, her lips grazing my nipple.

She had the tone of decision and determination in her voice, and so I slowly dozed off, liberated from any dark thoughts by the confidence in her voice, tired from all the talking, and satisfied that my wife was now firmly back in my own house, and mine.

*

We decided to go out for dinner Wednesday night because we were both tired from all of the drama, excitement, and talking. We met at a small taqueria with a bar of salsas that April claimed to love - something I found amusing because she retrieved ten or fifteen little cups of salsa from that bar and only really ate one of them on her food.

It was a hole-in-the-wall, and April met me there because I left work fairly late (I was, unsurprisingly, behind on everything at work, since I had spent so much time zoning out and thinking about her obsessively over the past few months of this adventure).

April had come from home - her classes had let out at four, so she had taken a nap at the house, but she was too hungry to wait for me to drive all the way back and then all the way out to the restaurant. She entered this dumpy little taqueria wearing a sundress - the least conservative of her "former" wardrobe of sundresses, a simple black cotton dress that came to mid-calf, but had a nice plunging neckline and clung to her beautiful figure. It was an inexpensive dress, not even that provocative, but on April it

acquired an aura of elegance, and she looked a little out of place in the taqueria.

I watched her walk in, doing my best not to let my paranoid thinking take over again. She was just April, I told myself, and if she looked really stunning it was because she *was* really stunning. She had changed her appearance a little over the course of this adventure, but that was all just tweaks of makeup, and maybe the effect of the extra confidence she had gained.

She sat down in front of me and I tried not to scrutinize her too much, but something was off about her. Was it the shade of her lips? Did she wear dark black mascara all the time now? It was kind of the difference between a female CNN and a Fox News anchor - she was more like the latter, a little more smokey and sultry, though why exactly was beyond my understanding of women.

She went to the salsa bar and came back with her assortment of salsas, and started dipping chips in them, like she usually did: she would eat a little drop of each one and then finish the chips with the mild green salsa she liked best.

I watched her as she did this, something nagging at me. Was it the way she was eating her chips? It seemed the same. The makeup, the dress? Was it just a leftover film on her, the kind of thing that would never go away, something that was more in my mind than in the physical world or part of anything she would ever do? Was it just that I knew she was a dirty, filthy slut when she wanted to be, and so I was seeing her differently, but not as she actually was?

And then, as she smiled and attacked the green salsa, I had a revelation.

"What's this?" I asked her, reaching out suddenly and lifting her left arm. The bracelet on it was thick, encrusted in jewels, and looked outrageously expensive. I already knew, I supposed, in my gut, what her answer would be - for there wasn't any other explanation for it than that.

April touched the bracelet lovingly. "It's my bonus," she said, with a smile. "I decided to keep it for a while."

A spark of fury lit up inside my chest, which I knew wasn't fair, but I couldn't quash it.

"Oh, okay," I said.

I made no effort to hide the bitterness in my tone, but it still took me by surprise. Just seconds ago I had felt that we had settled everything, I had felt good about it all.

April's naive expression dissolved. She fluttered her eyes up to look at me.

Old April would have said something else, but this April looked apologetic only peripherally, momentarily, before touching the bracelet again, this time with a sensual deliberation that sent cold chills through my arteries. "You're not jealous, are you?" she purred.

Then she smiled. Like this was a joke we were in on together.

I reminded myself, as heat crept from the back of my neck to my temples, that I had specifically told April that jealousy was part of this kink, and so if she was playing on that trope right now, she was only doing it because I liked it. Or had said I liked it.

Jealousy, though, comes in many shades, as I was finding out. Jealousy that I orchestrated for myself was one thing. Mild jealousy another. But April wearing a bracelet that looked like it cost at least five figures, a "gift" from her increasingly encroaching voyeuristic benefactor, stimulated a different kind of jealousy.

There was also the fact that I had really believed we were putting *all* of this on hold. I had felt like we had been on the same page. April couldn't be so stupid, so blindingly insensitive, as to not realize that this bracelet, and all that it implied by her wearing it, was out-of-bounds after all of that.

"How much is that thing worth?" I said, annoyed.

April shrugged and continued to play with the bracelet with her fingers. "Lilith says-ed, maybe ten thousand."

She had caught herself quickly, changing from the present tense to the past, but not quickly enough for me not to have heard it.

Lilith says...

"Dollars," I said, my voice dull.

I meant nothing by that statement. It was just a thing I did in conversations I didn't really like or couldn't control: harp on some point of clarification that didn't need to be made. It knocked April off-balance most of the time.

But April smiled, and then, acting as if I'd asked her to cash it in, sort of cooed at me. "It's so pretty, though," she said, looking at it while she

fondled it. "I just didn't feel like returning it. Yet."

"That's a big bonus," I said. I used that tone for implying things. The "that's-interesting-is-all" tone.

April rested her head on her hand, leaning on the table. She was sitting with her legs crossed, sultry, looking even more like Lilith than ever before. She could have said many, many things here, but her lips parted, and then she laughed, and she said nothing.

"What?" I asked.

She picked up her drink. "I was just thinking... or, the first thing I thought was, like - and Thomas, this is just as a joke... you know what, never mind."

No, no. Joke. Yeah. I want to hear it.

"Oh, just tell me," I said, edgy-like.

April gave me a mistrustful look and smiled. She was about to open her mouth, but seemed to change her mind, and shook her head. "Nah."

"Come on."

"It was tasteless, Thomas, really."

"April. No one loves tasteless jokes more than me."

April chewed on her straw thoughtfully. Now she was more like her old self, a bit silly, somewhat clueless about how hot she looked. Maybe I was seeing things through a kaleidoscope. It wouldn't have been the first time.

April didn't say anything.

I could have dropped it. I didn't even want to know what the joke was, in fact, I don't think I remembered what it was I was trying to get her to tell me, only that I wanted to win, and get her to say it.

"Just say it," I told her. My voice was more pushy than it needed to be.

April let the straw go and set her drink down, looking at me as though she was surprised. "I don't even know what we're -"

"I said, 'that's a big bonus,' and you said, 'I just thought of something, and it's a joke...'"

April looked down at her food and picked up a chip. She dipped it into an orange salsa. "I forget now."

"No, you don't."

"It's too overblown, Thomas," she said, biting into the chip. "Ugh, that's hot."

"I'm dying of curiosity."

April looked at me, and a lot of different emotions seemed to swim behind her eyes. Her face was static, neutral, but it seemed like she was smiling beneath it all. The same mysterious smile that had made me so nervous on so many occasions recently.

"It's out of context at this point," she insisted.

"Got your context right here," I said, reaching for her bracelet again. "That's a big bonus."

April tipped her head and sort of smile-glared at me. She did this when I was being immature, or had had too much to drink and started talking a bunch of smack - neither of these things happened often, but I would have been the first to admit that at least one of them was happening then.

I froze her out with my own head-tip to the side.

"It was a big bonus," April said, touching the bracelet again, her eyes lighting up with the kind of cat-like mischief that seemed to lurk in Lilith's eyes all the time. "It was a big cock."

She sipped her drink and watched me over the edge of her glass, mirth in her eyes, a bit of a gauntlet thrown down.

I sat back and let out a bark of a laugh. "Good one."

April lifted her glass.

"I don't think I like the idea of you keeping this guy's jewelry," I said abruptly. "It's sort of... too personal."

April looked at me for a moment.

"It's soooo pretty, though," April complained, really laying on the "complaint" in her voice. She put her bracelet-encrusted arm under the table, touching my knee, moving her fingers up my thigh. "Please, can I keep it? I'll do something extra, special nice for you."

This was madness. This woman was not my wife at all. I waited, heart in flight somewhere with a comet in space, for her to break character, to smile, to laugh it all off. I imagined it so hard that I almost felt like I saw her do it. Maybe there was a universe in which that really happened: April's sultry lips could not hold their firm, sexy pout, and she laughed, and then slipped the bracelet off and placed it in my hand, saying she was only kidding.

Maybe there was another universe in which Thomas Roberts wasn't such a slave to his cock that his balls didn't become totally useless. Maybe in that universe I made a noise almost like moaning and put a hand in April's hair, balling it into a fist and pulling on it slightly. "Oh yeah? What extra, special, nice thing will you do for me?" I said in that universe.

But in my universe, I didn't have time for any of that. April watched me, and then she seemed to see something that she had been looking for; a light went off, and she got the satisfied look in her eyes of having gotten something.

She slipped the bracelet off and set it on the table. "I'm just messing with you. It is really pretty," she said, looking at it. "But I'll take it in this week."

She looked up at me. "Those days are behind us, right?" she asked.

I know I said something then: I must have, in order for everything to keep moving, for us to change the topic and finish dinner. I was telling April stories, and she was laughing at me, and the bracelet sat on the table the whole time. I was painfully aware of it, and April didn't seem to even remember it.

When we got up to leave, she said she'd pay on the way out, and buy a dessert, while I put the leftovers in boxes (like I said, not the classiest joint).

She had left the bracelet on the table.

CHAPTER 16

Of course, things didn't simply *end* there.

Not for me, anyway.

I left the restaurant feeling buoyed by our "close call" - we had gone out-of-bounds, found ourselves a little overwhelmed, and returned to our comfortable marriage, a little sexier, a little wiser. April was a little bit different - she had that smile, that walk, all those secret folds in the fabric of April; but she was still April Snow, my wife.

And for a week or so, we lived in this banal and blissful bubble, and everything seemed to be panning out just like that. A narrow escape, a wild adventure, something we had a few bumps and bruises from, but overall it had all been worth it, and now everything was fine.

But I had become a different man, which was something I had neglected to pay attention to as this adventure had been ongoing. I had been so caught up in April, in the way she had changed - her clothing, the way she kissed, the way we fucked, the way she walked... I hadn't noticed that Thomas Roberts, on this adventure, had slowly turned into a different person as well.

Was it for the better? Maybe not.

I was hungry, for one thing. I guess after tasting your fantasies, you can't just go back to eating the same old thing.

I was obsessive, for another. It turned out that just shelving a sexual fantasy, setting it aside and being satisfied that the adventure had taken place, was not something that actually happened. And in truth, why would I ever have thought that it might? Did I have sex for the first time and say to myself, oh that was good, glad for the adventure? Putting it on the shelf for now.

This is all to say that I didn't find myself incredibly surprised to find myself sitting in my home office late at night, when April was supposed to be somewhere with her school friends or taking a late night course or doing some kind of clinical hours, hunched up and jerking off while watching the porno April had made.

I wasn't all that surprised to find myself lying awake at night, with April somehow sleeping blissfully beside me, imagining all the treachery that she was actually up to.

After all, if I couldn't just put this away like it never happened, how could April do that?

But there was nothing more to these musings than that. And perhaps they would have eventually ebbed away, and I would have stopped being paranoid and excitedly suspicious that April was somewhere cheating on me when she was away from home.

But then, almost inevitably, Lilith got involved.

*

You're all set for Friday

The message came to me at two pm on a Wednesday, from Lilith's number.

I stared at it for a long time, in some ways doubting it was even real. My phone had vibrated against my thigh at precisely the moment I had been daydreaming about April and her practice session with Rog, feeling the ghostly sensation of her pussy squeezing around my cock while Rog's fat dick rolled down and up the length of her exposed throat.

It was almost as if I had willed the text into existence, through pure fantasy. My pulse jumped and my veins filled with ice-cold adrenaline when I read it. And then I sat there, in a meeting in the coldest room in the office, sweat dripping from my forehead, getting sick and aroused, with my thoughts running wildly.

The guy next to me asked me if I was having a heart attack.

Friday. Friday. All set for Friday.

I racked my brains trying to remember what was happening on Friday, if Friday was an important day of some kind, trying to connect anything in my life to Lilith.

And then, with a rush of relief, disappointment treading closely on its heels, I realized that Lilith must have sent the text by mistake. I wondered how Lilith had my number stored in her phone. Was I Thomas, or April's Hubby? Or something more derogatory. Milquetoast? Mr. Indecision? Tommy Boy?

Was my name next to someone hot enough to be in Lilith's inner circle, or even her stratosphere? Hot enough, interesting enough, to have Lilith setting something up for this person on a Friday.

I was about to swipe the message away, and try to forget about it, but my thumb hovered over it, unable to swipe, my heart beating excessively - both in rate and strength - for several minutes.

It would only be polite, I reasoned, to inform Lilith that her message had gone to the wrong person.

I think this was for somebody else

I typed this message in just under an hour, toying with various permutations of saying the same thing. I had clever responses and clueless responses, invitations to say more, responses that included intrigue and mystique. In the end, I felt like an ass for considering any of those, and just sent the text I would have sent to anyone, had they sent me the wrong message.

And unsurprisingly, Lilith didn't write back.

Of course not. Because Lilith didn't care about me, or anyone else, unless she was plotting something that required my direct participation. The world was Lilith's chess board, and she did not think of her pawns until she sent them out to die.

It was a let-down, to be sure. I felt a lot like I did after breaking up with a girl early on in college. Samantha. Hot in bed, crazy as fuck, and absolutely useless as a girlfriend. But she sometimes called me, trying to lure me into one of her crazy mind games, and I couldn't help but get excited by the prospect of it.

And that was that.

Until Thursday.

*

We had no plans for Friday night, and by Thursday evening, I had pretty much gotten over Lilith's text, and the high it had given me, and the hangover that had followed.

April was late getting back from class, which was nothing unusual in and of itself. She texted me to tell me she would be, that she was going out with friends for coffee, and not to wait on me for dinner.

So I puttered around the house, thinking about making dinner or sneaking another viewing of the porno before she got home, wondering if I

would have to work late tomorrow, pondering actually finishing the shower project that weekend.

I was standing there in the bathroom, staring at the shower, hoping that I would will it into existence, or at the very least, will the tile into existence, since tiling is probably the thing I hate doing most in the world. (Hence the delay in making a shower).

The bags caught my eye in the mirror.

Just white bags, shopping bags, with gold lettering on them and a pink ribbon, untied, that had held the handles together.

I didn't often buy lingerie for April, so I have no idea why I recognized the bags instantly as being from a store called *Roxana*, a boutique lingerie store in a part of town that is so shi-shi I never go there. But I did. And I also noticed that the bags were placed behind the chair in the bedroom, a corner I never frequented, where they would not be seen from any part of the room except this very strange angle where I happened to be standing in the unfinished shower, contemplating tile.

In short: they were hidden in a place that April would have assumed I would never, ever look.

I crossed the room and checked the bags.

Red lingerie, of a degree of skimpiness words fail me to describe, was lying inside the carefully folded pieces of tissue paper in the bag. I held it up and examined it: it was almost entirely transparent, most of the material a very fine mesh held together by the lace bordering its almost non-existent fabric. A thong, and a racy matching bra, all in that blood-orange red that April seemed to favor now.

I replaced the lingerie carefully, and then stared at it, wondering what it meant.

Or rather, fantasizing about what it meant.

So the evening wore on, and I watched the porno, and looked at the lingerie again, and wondered where April was, and fantasized about her with Rog, and jerked off, and then she came home.

Reader, I will be honest: I had not, at all, drawn a connection between Lilith's text and April's lingerie, as obvious as that connection seems. Why? Who knows?

Not until April walked through the door, and kissed me, and we poured some wine and sat in the kitchen while April went on and on about her day, and I was just tipping the bottle to pour myself some more wine

when she said - frightfully, fancifully, off-handedly enough that she waved at the air like she was sweeping away a fly:

"Oh hey, before I forget, we have a huge test next week and we're doing a cram session tomorrow at Mike Palmer's place, which is pretty far out in, you know the new places that are pretty much in Three Springs? The new development. So... yeah, it might go really late, we can't really start until nine because of everybody's clinic shifts and work and stuff. Mike has a pretty big place out there - these are those new suburbs - and he has like five rooms, so he said we could stay over there if it gets really late. So I'll probably just take my stuff and have it in case I don't feel like driving back."

I listened to April, piling detail upon detail unbidden, in a linear fashion one dot connected to the next, until all the pieces finally fell into place, and the ice water of jealousy shot through my veins.

... all set for Friday... all set for Friday...

Lilith's text, my paranoia, the lingerie, and now this batshit crazy and totally rehearsed story? A story I couldn't check (without seeming psychotic), a story that ticked all the boxes (I couldn't object to April studying, after all).

A story so good, so airtight, that it suggested a lie.

Especially the way April - April of muddled details and thoughts that bloomed like algae, spreading to far corners of unrelated and uncharted waters - told me about it: all the times in order, the reasons connected logically, and *not one inexplicable turn or superfluous detail*.

"Oh," I said. "Okay."

April looked up at me. She had been quickly swiping through a newsfeed of some kind, one hand holding her wine glass by the stem, the other caressing the screen of her phone. "You didn't have - we didn't have plans, did we? That I forgot?"

"No," I said. My voice sounded strange, even to myself.

"You okay?" April asked. "You sound... look, if it's not okay, I guess I'm more than happy to skip -"

"I'm just disappointed," I was already saying, "that I have run out of excuses for not finishing the shower."

April seemed frozen for the moment. Uncertainty held her in its grip, and her eyes moved to strange places in the room, her mouth open,

and then she smiled her new mysterious smile for a nanosecond, before shrugging, looking like herself again. "Ha," she said simply. "Sorry."

She returned to her screen, and settled on to her messenger, set her wine down, and began to type. "I'll just let him know..." she said, trailing off in the middle of the sentence.

I tried to look at who she was sending it to, but she lifted the phone and began to type.

Then she set her phone down, and I had to fight hard against the urge to reach for it, seize it, and look at her message.

That would have been unreasonable, Thomas.

"Okay," I said, pouring her a little more wine. "I guess we're *all set for Friday*."

April didn't flinch when I said this, but rather smiled at me like I was mildly insane, and then tipped her glass in my direction. The glasses clanged together so hard I was sure their fine glass would crunch away to dust.

"I guess," she said, laughing lightly, tipping her head and squinting almost undetectably with one eye, like she always does when she suspects I'm thinking more than I'm saying.

She usually follows this up with some kind of interrogation, but that night, she did not.

*

Lilith didn't seem particularly surprised to see me, but Lilith never looked particularly surprised, so I didn't take it to mean anything at all. She was lounging on a recliner next to her pool, just as a large man collecting a lot of cable into neat coils had told me she would be. The man did not seem particularly surprised to see me, either, and he had hooked a thumb behind his back to direct me to her backyard, then carried on about his business.

There were quite a few people in Lilith's house, none of whom seemed to be the sorts who would be at a party hosted by Lilith. They all looked like contractors or film industry dorks, which, I supposed, all squared with everything I did know about Lilith, which really wasn't much.

She had oversized sunglasses on and looked a little like Brigitte Bardot, except for the fact that she was totally naked, and I had never had the pleasure of seeing Brigitte that way.

She seemed to be asleep, because she didn't react to my walking down her fancy steps to her fancy pool and then standing next to her fancy lounge and waiting for her to notice me.

Her mouth twitched, and she smiled. "Did you just come over here to stand in my sun, Thomas? Or are you here about my text?"

I had my hands in my pockets and left them there. Jesus, fucking Lilith. She had a better act going on than I did, and I secretly prided myself on having one of the best. In another universe, Lilith would have been a really fun date.

"Here about the text, I guess," I said.

Lilith shifted her shoulders while she smiled broadly, and her breasts rolled alluringly before settling into their glamorous splay. It was impossible to know if her eyes were open behind her dark glasses. "It wasn't for you," she said dryly.

"Wasn't it?"

This made Lilith smile, a smile I believed was the most genuine one I had seen from her. "Well," she said tonelessly.

A long minute of silence passed, and I was just about to believe Lilith had fallen asleep, and I was wondering what to do next, when she lifted her glasses and squinted at me. "Did you come all the way down here about this? Have you ever heard of a phone?"

"Would you have answered?"

Lilith slapped the glasses back down and smiled again. "No."

Another moment.

"Well, Thomas don't stand there all day, tell me why you're here and then skedaddle, you're a buzzkill."

"Why'd you send me the text, Lilith?"

"Why do I do anything, Thomas?"

I hesitated for a moment. "For the fuck of it," seemed like the right answer, but Lilith was a little more complicated than she appeared to be. Or perhaps, more simple.

"For money?" I suggested.

Lilith made her hand into a gun and blew on the barrel in reply.

"I'll take that as a yes. So why did you send me a text about what April's up to tonight?"

"Yoey," Lilith said, almost too quickly. "It was a misunderstanding on my part, actually."

"Lilith, do you have to work at being this infuriating, or is it just a happy accident?"

Lilith waved a hand dismissively at the air. "April gave me the impression it was just business as usual, Thomas, so I thought I'd throw a bone your way, given that you've been a little... I don't know. Wobbly lately."

"It's a miracle no one has strangled you yet, Lilith, you know that?"

She smiled like she had a secret. "Well..."

I lost my patience. "Is April hooking up with somebody tonight, Lilith? That's what I'm fucking here to ask, so knock it off with all the mysterious intrigue bullshit."

"I *like* that accent, Thomas. I like it a lot."

"Jesus," I hissed. I hadn't gotten this worked up for a long time, worked up enough that I started sounding like I was from Hegewisch. I spat, for good measure.

"Here's a question for you Thomas: why don't you just *ask April*?"

"Because I'm here asking you, Lilith."

"Right."

I was about to turn and stomp off, because I was way past my violent years, which were never really much to write home about, but I was starting to feel like I understood how strange violent crimes ended up happening at 11 am in neighborhoods like this one. Anyway, I had to get back to work, and Lilith was being a pain in the ass.

The only thing I couldn't understand is what I had been thinking was going to happen when I came here.

"Do you want the key?" Lilith said, after sighing.

"The fucking key, Lilith? Do I want the key? The key to what?"

"Oh God," Lilith complained, rolling over and lowering her recliner to flat in one smooth, sexy motion. "It's on a peg in the kitchen. Take it or leave it. Greg is out of town until Monday."

What the fuck did that even mean?

"What the -" I began, but decided against it. I was standing in Lilith's back yard trying to put the squeeze on a block of diamond.

Anyway, she was right. Why didn't I just ask April? Why was I standing here, trying to get information out of Lilith, as if Lilith was the main problem here?

I knew the answer to that question, but I wasn't letting it in to my conscious thoughts at that point.

I breezed through Lilith's house the way I had come through - through the back, into the cavernous, open-concept party area, which was still littered with empty drink glasses and general party detritus. The kitchen where I had stood on more than one occasion, watching April make the rounds at a Lilith-sponsored "party" was to my right, and I meant to walk by it and out the door without looking for "the key."

But I cast an eye to the side and saw it, hanging on a gold ring, in plain sight but not especially noticeable. It was like my eye was just drawn to it. It was a complicated key, a fob-type device similar to one I had at work, but unique and like no other key I had ever seen. Which is why I recognized it instantly, and why the security codes that had to accompany it surfaced in my mind, as memorable as if they were my home phone number.

Okay, well... even more memorable than that.

I walked toward the door but made a sharp turn and tracked back through the kitchen. Outside, Lilith was still face-down and naked on the recliner, unconcerned. I snatched the key and stuffed my hands in my pockets again, then made another sharp right, and walked right out of Lilith's house.

A robotic, mechanical, calculating, reptilian version of Thomas Roberts had been initiated, and so the next things I would do were not very rational. But they were done with a methodical determination.

It just wasn't entirely clear - nor considered by me at all - *whose* determination drove those actions.

CHAPTER 17

I was there for what seemed like a very, very long time, elbows on knees, breathing as though I had only just climbed ten flights of stairs, broken into a rich voyeur's hobby apartment, and sat down in his specially crafted room for watching a woman who looked like his wife fuck black men for jewelry.

A very thin sheen of sweat had developed on my neck and my temples, but the room was a comfortable temperature. It was a cold sweat that pooled, every minute or so, into an icy droplet that snaked down my spine, or licked my cheek.

I hadn't thought of much since I left Lilith's. I had driven, parked blocks away, walked purposefully into the parking garage as the gate closed behind another tenant, strolled to the stairway after pressing the elevator button, because I didn't want to accidentally run into April, and then I had trotted up all ten flights without breaking a sweat.

Everything had gone perfectly, smoothly: I had entered the codes and used the fob and installed myself in this room, as smoothly as if I lived there and had come home to this place a million times.

Only after half an hour of damp, determined waiting did I begin to think about what I was doing. About what my wife was doing.

It occurred to me, somewhere during that lengthy wait, that I had locked myself into the closet and didn't really know where the secret release handle was, but I didn't get up to investigate it, because I didn't want to move from where I was, make a noise, get caught - not when I was so close to catching April doing what I feared most, suspected, fantasized about.

Carefully thinking through the evening's events later, I would calculate that I spent an hour to an hour and a half sitting there, sweating coldly, my blood running ice-cold and then boiling, a deep, parched need clawing inside of me and demanding something, anything, to sate it... and then mysteriously, that same raw need would rot and turn to a queasiness that on more than one occasion felt like it might actually cause me to vomit.

It was the idea that I would not be able to clean it up or hide it that stopped me.

And then, just as it had become pitch-black in the windows, with only the grow lights from the herbal garden illuminating the condo, a series

of hard clicks and a high-pitched chorus of beeps announced the arrival of someone.

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It was April, April opening the door, April's long thighs bare to just below her ass that swished through the door, red heels with elaborate, sexy, bondage-style straps around her ankles making a crisp clip-clop on the tile in the entryway.

She walked with purpose, no hesitation whatsoever, like an escort in a movie - almost too confident to be truly believable.

A hulking, dark figure entered behind her - less sure of himself, hesitation in his gait.

Rog.

My gut twisted, my heart plummeting through the floor, to the cold, damp dark of the parking garage - it felt, honestly, as though it were lying, beating its final throbs away on a cold concrete floor.

The door closed behind him and he looked around before following April, loosening his tie. "You sure this fucker isn't gonna call the cops on me, he finds us in here?"

"I told you," April said, walking over to the bar like she owned the place. "He really *is* out of town."

"Huh," Rog said, leaving the tie loosely around his neck and watching April as she prepared a drink. "You steppin' out?"

"What?" April said, laughing, doing a great job of acting like she didn't understand the question. She handed Rog a whiskey, a fat round ball of ice in the center. Rog took the drink, but it could have been a ream of paper she had handed him. His eyes were on April, and he slipped his free hand around her waist to pull her toward him with a stone-aged male gruffness.

"You steppin' out?" he repeated. He traced one finger up April's dress, between her breasts, then up to her chin, tilting her face up to his. "You doin' something your hubby doesn't know about?"

April tipped her head to one side, and smiled, bringing her own drink to her lips. "Maybe," she told him.

Rog took this with cool approval; it was something he had expected, his expression said. "Yeah? He tell you you couldn't play with

Rog anymore?"

April shook her head, drink at her lips.

Rog smiled. He took a sip of his whiskey and set it down hard on the table next to him. "I got you," he said, a peculiar menace in his voice that made me uneasy. April seemed, if anything, not only at ease with that tone but to be turned on by it. Her smile remained, her eyes locked on his, and she swayed a little as Rog gripped her arm and reached for her hair, pulling on it sharply to turn her face up to his while he leaned in to speak to her in a low voice, saying things I couldn't hear, his lips almost touching hers.

Whatever he said, April didn't speak. Rog took the drink from her hand and sipped some of it, then turned slightly to set it down next to his, and leaned in to April. He pulled her jaw open and let a trickle of the drink spill from his mouth into hers. Then he kissed her, biting into her lip, and then stared at her, an almost sadistic look on his face.

A tremor of fear went through me, because this was a different Rog from the one we had come to know and love. I couldn't say why, or what detail of his body language or face had changed. Maybe because April had freed him from his professional persona by asking him here, maybe because he thought he had the upper hand - who knew? But he was about to do some decidedly *unprofessional* things with my wife.

He spun her and shoved her, suddenly, onto the bed. "You keep that pussy all nice and fresh for me this time? Hmm? I like to get in there first, feel it nice and tight on my cock."

April pushed herself up to her elbows and looked at him as she moved her fingers over her abdomen lazily. She only smiled, didn't answer.

Rog was loosening his tie, opening the buttons of his shirt, and he dropped his hand to April's left ankle and dragged her toward him, bringing her ass to the edge of the bed. One of her legs was between his, and he dropped her other ankle to let her leg fall to the floor. April was still on her elbows, looking up to see him now.

Rog pulled the tie off, and shed his shirt. Then he took off his belt, unzipped his pants, and fished his big cock out of them. He held it in his hand, stroking it languidly. April's eyes dropped to watch him: even I could not tell if this was conscious or the tremor of an addict. Was she playing to Rog's big ego when her eyes went wide and she adopted a hungry expression, or was that a physical reaction she couldn't avoid?

Probably some of both. Rog watched her and just nodded, so I took it this wasn't the first time it had happened to him. He shook it a little above her face and then pointed it toward her lips, six or so inches away.

His thick black hand moved slowly down the length of it, and a bead of pearly cream squeezed from the tip. He seemed to be squeezing it out, the way he was touching himself.

"Go ahead," he told April. "Lick it off. I know you want to."

April rose from her elbows, still looking at Rog's cock. She reached for his cock with her hand, but he nudged her hand away and brought the tip of his dick closer to her lips. "Just lick it off for me, baby, nice and slow. I'll let you hold on to it, don't worry. That's it."

April's eyes fluttered open and she met Rog's stare as her tongue swept in a slow, teasing circle around the crown, before she gave him a smile, a teasing pause, and then scooped the precum from his hole with a fast-moving, hungry tongue.

She brought her hand up to seize his cock again, and Rog didn't fight her off this time, just chuckled smugly as she grasped it. In her slender grip it seemed to grow in size and grotesqueness: dark and veined, twisted and almost gnarled, it dwarfed her porcelain and flawless hand, and her long fingers almost did not meet as she encircled it.

Then she went to work on him, but more slowly than she usually did. It was at this point that reality began to peel away, and cease to exist for me. As April lovingly took Rog's cock into her mouth, sucking, licking, smiling as she took a breath before pleasuring him again and again, I was disembodied. She was not acting, not at that moment - I was not even supposed to be here - and she was really enjoying sucking Rog's cock, with no audience, to her knowledge, to perform for.

"Take it easy," Rog said, at last, putting a hand to April's hair and pushing it back from her face. "I wanna get that first load in your pussy, little girl." He pushed April's head away from his cock by pulling gently on her hair, a hand on her jaw.

His cock left her lips with a pop, and saliva spilled from her open mouth. The red lipstick she had been wearing had smeared onto his dick. She still had her hand on his cock, and she stroked him a few times. Rog grunted, and then pushed her by the shoulder backward. She fell onto the bed on her elbows again and he stepped away. He shook himself out of his unbuttoned shirt, his loose pants and boxers.

"Nah, leave that dress on, leave them shoes on, too. I got plans for all that," he told April, as she started to squirm out of her figure-hugging dress.

He started to climb onto the bed, then leaned down and grabbed April's hips to pick her up like a rag doll and toss her back a few feet. He grasped the bottom of the dress and pulled it up and over her torso. April lifted her arms above her head, and he pushed it up until it was tangled in her arms over her head, before giving it a twist and dropping her arms onto the bed. The dress was twisted around her wrists, working like bondage - and April had no clear desire to escape.

I stared at the red lingerie I had discovered at home, at the silky, physical manifestation of April's betrayal: the cups that held her breasts in a miasma of treacherous lace and sheer fabric, at the blood-orange lines that criss-crossed her hips and nestled between her buttocks.

Rog looked my wife up and down, wriggling in between her legs, one hand holding his cock, stroking it lazily.

"It really true you never did any of this before?" Rog asked. The question was unexpected. April wriggled, demurring, and Rog dropped a hand to pick up one leg by the calf. He brought it up, pushing it in front of his face, and licked her leg, then along the straps of her shoe. "Seems like you've had an awful lot of practice. Being a slut." He bit into the straps of her shoe and tugged on her foot, then let the strap snap as he released it from his teeth.

April didn't answer, just squirmed on the bed. Rog dropped her foot and reached between her legs. His fingers explored her mound, over the surface of the panties. "You ain't got those slutty panties on?" Rog crowed, sounding disappointed. "I liked those."

He seized April's mound with his big hand and began to massage her pussy through the fabric, his thumb on her clit. April's breathing became ragged, but neither spoke for a few moments as Rog got her so worked up that she was lifting her ass from the mattress and her thighs began to tremble.

Suddenly, Rog pulled his hand away, laughing. April mewled in disappointment.

I saw him jerk at her panties, and heard them rip. Rog held them up above her and then dangled them over her mouth, grazing her lips with the

scant red fabric. "Open up," he said, in a low voice. "I'm gonna give it to you til you scream, and I ain't wantin' no cops up here."

I watched, my body rigid, as Rog lowered her torn panties, heavy with her juices, into her obediently opened mouth, and then stuffed them into her throat.

I didn't breathe for the next few moments, which passed as if entire hours were folded inside of them. Rog moved his hand possessively over April's creamy skin, and then jerked her bra so that her tits were freed, spilling out from the tight confines of the cups scrunched up beneath them.

Sheer terror gripped me as I waited, my lungs burning somewhere distantly in my mind, because I was still not breathing, thinking only of what Rog would do with my wife now that he had her hands tied, her panties in her mouth, and no one watching that he knew of.

So it was surprising to me, and made me at last gulp a swallow of air, when he lowered his body over hers, and licked her from top to bottom, his fat lips sucking at her skin as he moved down to her mound, but did not linger there, and then back up to her stuffed mouth.

And then he eased his huge cock into her pussy, between her spread legs, and April made incomprehensible noises of pleasure as he slowly filled her up.

"Fuck, baby, your pussy is so wet. You sure you saved this for Rog today? Huh? Mmm. Fuck, you've got such a nice tight little pussy for such a slut, I could fuck this all night. Would you like that, you little whore? Yeah, you like Rog's cock, I can tell. Yeah, fuck yeah, squeeze it just like that."

Rog was on top of her, moving slowly inside of her. He moved a hand to her hair again and pulled on it to jerk her chin up at him, and April winced, but it quickly faded away to a moan.

Beneath him, she squirmed. From my vantage point I had a good view of April's legs spread open for Rog, her heels bouncing lightly as he fucked her long and deep.

April mewled and then began to squirm.

"Yeah, you want it, you're gonna come for me, aren't you, baby? But you're going to have to wait it out, because I like this pussy just like it is, I like to fuck it nice and slow the first time. Don't you worry, I'll get to fuckin' you hard till you scream, but this is what Rog really likes. Hold still, let me feel all that fresh tight pussy."

April moaned and mewled beneath Rog's body, her legs spread but floppy and useless, her whole body sunken into the mattress, the only movement the slow sawing of Rog's cock inside her slushy cunt. Rog groaned occasionally, or mumbled something close to her ear that was impossible to pick up from inside the closet.

This seemed to go on forever, and somehow it was more devastatingly raunchy than all the things Rog had done to her before - they were almost innumerable. But that had all been, somehow, almost fake, sterilized of feeling, unrealistic and over-the-top. Now, Rog's skin touched hers everywhere, and their sweat was mingling, and April was just enjoying the slow rhythm of his enormous dick in her pussy.

When she came, she screamed, and her cries were muffled by the panties in her mouth.

I could see Rog's smile - his white teeth, his smug satisfaction - as he continued to fuck my wife through her orgasm with his steady thrusts, her flailing limbs and kicking heels futile against his mass. April's muscles tensed and her cries become almost hysterical, but Rog didn't stop, just kept fucking her well past her climax, right through her protesting screams as the pleasure became painful to her freshly-exploded, over-sensitized pussy.

"Oh, I ain't done with you yet, little girl, so you just gonna have to take it," Rog told her.

"There we go," he said, after a while. "Now you gettin goin' again."

April's heels floated slowly to Rog's lower back, the stilettos grazing against his skin as he fucked her. April was making noises into the panties, which made Rog smile. He ran his fingers over her lips. "Ima take them out soon, honey, and get my cock in your mouth."

He fucked her for a few more moments, then pulled the panties from her mouth slowly as he sat up and leaned back on his calves. He put one leg, then the other, over April's legs, so he was straddling her, and then slowly edged up the length of her body, dropping his cock with a loud, wet slap between her breasts. He pushed them together and rubbed his cock between her tits, watching himself, while April panted and stared at him.

Rog leaned over her and pulled her dress off, freeing her hands, which he guided to her tits, pushing her hands inward so her flesh wrapped around his cock. But April's breasts were too small to bury his dick - the black, veiny flesh barely disappeared between her creamy mounds. As he fucked her, his cock bumped against her chin.

He reached for a pillow and stuffed it under her head, all without missing much of a beat. Pulling on her hair, he tilted her head at a dangerous looking angle. "Just open up, lay your tongue out, give me a little lick when I get up there. Yeah."

My wife obeyed him, pushing her tits together to squeeze his cock as he fucked them, opening her mouth to have the crown of his dick slide over her flat tongue and against the roof of her mouth with a cacking sound as he rubbed his dick between her tits.

"Where you want this first load, baby?" he asked her, as his muscles began to tense up. "Hmm? You want a taste of Rog's hot cum? Or you want your pussy all filled up? Hmm? What'd you come here for? Maybe you want a little Rog baby? Huh? You close?"

I was seated in the chair, but now I was dizzy, and the world spun around me as if I were in motion. April didn't answer this question, but she leaned forward to lick greedily at Rog's cock. Rog had dropped one hand behind him, to April's pussy, which he was finger-fucking absent-mindedly.

He brought his fingers to his nose and sniffed April's scent, licked her pussy juices from his fingers. "Yeah, maybe that's it. I'm gonna fill your pussy up, little girl. Fuck, that's hot."

"April," I breathed, not really sure what that meant. I was on the edge of the chair, so close I might fall off, my breath sticking to the window. Other words were on my lips - no, wait, stop - but none of them formed.

Rog scooted backward and rolled April onto her stomach, then pushed her and manipulated her body until she was lowering her pussy onto his cock, and then seated on his lap as he groped and mauled the front of her, pinching her nipples, sucking on her neck. "Yeah, you want a load of Rog's cum, ain't that right? You gon' get it, don't worry. You just ride that cock nice and slow, baby, yeah, just like that, squeeze that pussy and show me how much you want it."

April did as she was told, and slowly rose and fell on Rog's lap, her fingers clawing at her own thighs, her body damp with sweat, her squeals deepening to moans as she approached another climax.

"I like this, mmm," Rog said, after a while. He had his mouth on her neck again, and he said something I couldn't hear. April started to pump him faster, and his fingers wandered between her legs.

"Oh, oh, oh my God!" April said, bouncing faster.

Rog groaned, and seized her hips, and thrust up deep inside of her. He started to slam her body up and down on his cock and then he leaned back and groaned loudly before going silent with his mouth open. I saw a vein in his neck pulse wildly, his muscles strained, and then he gripped April's shoulder fiercely and pushed her violently to the bed before rising up and slamming his load into her with wet splats that echoed loudly in the room, even as April gasped and squealed like a whore, and Rog began to yell.

"Fuck. Fuck. That. Pussy. Is. Fucking. Hot," he said, punctuating each of his punishing thrusts with one word of his sentence.

He looked down at April, who was squirming against him, after he was done. One hand moved over her backside, through the sweat, caressing the shape of her body. He played with her ass for a moment, and April mewled.

"Fuck," he said, in almost a whisper. "Fuck, that's fucking hot. I can tell you're close, your pussy wants it bad."

I was sure I was going to throw up for a moment, I could even taste the bile at the back of my throat. Was this a game that they played, or was there something serious to it? April was on birth control, I knew that... didn't I?

But Rog gave me no time to think. April was still mewling, twisting her body, Rog still inside of her.

"Oh, you ain't done, huh?" Rog said, grinning. "Where's my manners?" He sawed slowly into her as April mewled and bucked against him, pushing herself up onto her hands and knees to fuck Rog's still-hard cock.

"Oh!" April screamed, pumping his cock faster. "Oh, yeah, oh, oh!"

I stared at the animal my wife seemed to have become, milking her orgasm from Rog's cock, her hair wild, her body sweaty, one single thought on her mind.

My cheating wife, who could not, evidently, get enough of Rog's cock, whose pussy was filled with his cum.

Rog watched her as she screamed and bit the pillow he had placed under her head earlier, and came, her juices squelching around his cock as he watched, impassive, only the shadow of a smile on his lips.

She collapsed, panting, and Rog at last let his cock slide from inside of her. He rose to his knees and worked his way off the bed, standing

up, enjoying the view of April's dripping, swollen pussy, her ass in the air for a moment before she rolled to the side and then to her stomach.

Rog took a sip of whiskey, standing there, appraising, I supposed, what he had done.

April pushed her hair from her face and sat up.

Rog handed her his whiskey, and April looked at it, but didn't sip it.

"I'd get some of that in you," he told her, crossing the room to fetch the bottle. He returned, poured some into her glass, and gave himself a little more in another glass - no ice.

April sipped her whiskey with a coquettish look on her face. "Oh, yeah?" she said. She twisted the glass sexily in her fingers, and dipped a finger into the liquid before bringing it to her dirty mouth to suck on. "You have something special in mind?"

Rog's cock, which was never, as far as I knew, ever *not* at attention, pulsed at this last statement and rose to a full erection. He laughed, a light laugh from the back of his throat, a laugh that sounded almost dangerous. Fear gripped me: what would Rog have in mind for her? I didn't understand how April could take his cock in her ass, but it was even more terrifying to think of what kind of creative idea he might come up with, now that she had all but invited him.

What would I do, I wondered, if push came to shove, and something got out of hand? Part of me wanted April to learn a lesson, and I hated that part of myself, but the idea of seeing Rog spank her ass firmly while he fucked it so that she might learn not to step out of line flitted through my head pleasurably, and then clanged against the confines of my flesh as a painful pulse in my cock.

"I'm just gonna hit that ass, baby," he said, giving his dick a shake with his fingers. "But it's gonna be a long one, you suckin' me dry here." He set his drink down and walked toward April, pushing a strand of her hair from her face. She sipped her whiskey.

"Thas' all right though," Rog said. "Cuz you like it, don't you? You like a nice long fuck in your tight ass, I can tell."

He took her drink and watched her as he moved it to the headboard, setting it down without taking his eyes off her. April was looking up at him, lips red and puffy, mascara smeared, a hungry, slutty gleam in her eyes and her lips quivering a little with desire.

Rog fished the ice sphere from the glass without looking at what he was doing, and brought it to April's mouth. "Lick that for me baby, get that mouth nice and cold, then you gonna suck on my balls for a little bit, and if you do a real good job, I'm going to fuck your little ass 'til you can't walk."

The memory of my fingers in April's ass as she fucked me, the hot silky flesh closed around my fingers, smooth and tight, pulsing as she came, washed over me so intensely that I could almost feel her weight on me, smell the scent of her pussy as though it was rising from between our bodies. I stared at my wife's lips as they stretched to accommodate the big ball of ice, sucking at it as Rog teased her, pulling it from her mouth and then letting her have it, a little like she was a dog he was toying with.

April slid to the floor and Rog dropped the ice into the glass with a loud clunk, his left hand moving to April's head, pulling her toward his cock. With his cock jammed into her mouth, he moved her head up and down the length of his shaft while tipping his head back and groaning in pleasure, eyes closed, muscles rippling with pleasure as my wife's cold mouth took his entire huge cock to the depths of her throat.

"Oh, fuck, baby, fuck, yeah, get it hard, keep working on it, that's a good girl. You know what I like."

This went on for a stretch of time, April on her knees, sucking Rog's endlessly re-hardening cock back to life, getting his thick meat ready to stretch her ass.

"Up on the bed, turn around, yeah, that's it."

April got on all fours and looked back at him, her feet twisting invitingly, heels kicking playfully, her smile an invitation to debase her yet again. It was the look of a hungry whore, a woman who wanted what she wanted - a huge cock, a dark man, to pump her full of cum and make her scream like the whore she was.

He nudged her legs apart and used the tip of his cock to rub her split, gushing pussy. Even where I was, I could hear, over their deep breathing and mewling, the sticky slurps of her pussy as he played with her. He dipped his cock inside of her, easily, quickly - her pussy was so wet and stretched that he glided in and out of her almost playfully.

"What you want, little girl?" he asked her, as April bit her lip and mewled. "Come on now, say it."

"I want you to fuck me in the ass," April purred, pushing her hips back.

"Mmn," Rog murmured, taking a finger from his mouth and dropping it to April's ass. His dark finger contrasted with her fair skin, the pink of her eyelet. "You all tight again, ain't you? That's why you like it in the ass, ain't it, little girl? Always feels like the first time. You ready for it? I'm gonna fuck you nice and slow, I'm gonna take my time."

He dipped his cock into April's pussy one more time, and drew some of her juices and his cum up to her ass, before he lined his cock up with her tiny eyelet.

My insides twisted again: he was too big. Even if it had already happened before, over and over again, and I had already seen it, I couldn't help but stare with mounting fear as he paused with the tip of his dick covering her asshole completely.

April was still looking at him, still nudging backward, begging for it.

"Nah," Rog said unexpectedly, pushing April to the side so that she fell on her right side. His left arm shot out to hold her legs to one side as he repositioned himself, dragging her ass up onto his knees. "I wanna see your face when I break that open, I like that look you get."

April drew her arms up the length of her body and lay them next to her head, as though they were two lovers, a romantic gesture that seemed stunningly out of place, and brutally stabbed me in the heart. I couldn't see her face, but I could see by the shape of her jaw that she was smiling: it was something she had done for me, welcoming me to the pleasures of her body.

"You keep that smile on your face, little girl. That's right. And you gonna take it."

Rog pushed forward, and sank into April's ass, her legs off to one side, her feet suddenly stiff. She lifted her head to look at what he was doing, and then fell back, a gasp escaping her throat. "Oh!" she squeaked. "Oh my... oh God..."

"Yeah," Rog said, one hand catching her legs as they floated up. He pushed them harshly down to the side and he leaned on her ankle to keep them there, to keep April's body contorted, as his cock went deeper, until he was finally lying on her body. "Smile for me and beg me for it," he said.

And then I was swallowed up in the ringing of my own blood in my ears, my vision blurry, as Rog slowly fucked April in the ass. Her feet bounced lightly, the red heels still clasped around her ankles, her voice rising and falling in ecstasy.

He fucked her like that, and then moved one leg onto his right side and pushed her heels up by her head. I could see his dick as it sawed in and out of her ass, unable to believe that the tiny hole had accommodated him, but it had, it always had. April panted and mewled, and this went on for a long, tortured, ten minutes or so.

"Fuck, I could fuck this ass all night," Rog said. He sat back on his calves and dragged her ass onto his lap. April's legs spread open like a frog's, her ankles wandering in the air as she twisted her feet in either discomfort or too much pleasure. Rog had hold of her hips and was moving her body, staring down at her face as he fucked her ass raw.

I slid off the chair at some point and stared, my abdomen wracked with pain, and so I was huddled pathetically on the floor, as April began screaming, her voice rising higher and higher, her legs getting tense. Rog fell onto her and rolled his body against her, one hand on her right foot, fucking her slowly as she begged him to make her come. "Oh, oh, oh, I'm so close, I'm so... please... please... I can't take any more... please... make me come..." she babbled.

At last her voice cut out, and she began to let out a high-pitched wail, which was muffled by her panties as Rog stuffed them back into her mouth. "Yeah, that's hot, oh, fuck, oh yeah, that feels so fucking right," Rog growled, tipping his head back again.

April's screams died away, and her legs went limp. Rog threw her legs to the side again and pulled out of her ass, slapping her bottom. "Get on those hands and knees now," he said.

April obeyed, and Rog paused with a hand on her lower back, kneading her flesh for a moment, staring, I'm sure, at the huge gape he had created, at the way her asshole quivered with her orgasm. "Now you gonna get it," he said.

And then, he slammed his cock into my wife's ass hard, and pulled out completely, and April howled but remained in her submissive posture for him, her head tipped back. He grabbed her hair and fucked her brutally like this for a few minutes, before he sank in deep and thrust hard and fast until he groaned and gripped her hips with both hands, fingers deep in her flesh, his second load of come exploding in April's ass.

I closed my eyes and crawled back up onto the chair, unable to see anything but their forms as they rolled on the bed and then lay still except

for the heaving of their chests. I still could not see well when they embraced, and tangled their legs together, and I couldn't hear what they murmured to each other as they rolled around in their cum and sweat for the next ten minutes, as if they were lovers and not co-stars of porn.

Finally, April rolled onto her stomach and fished her phone out of her purse. She pushed her hair back and read something, while Rog ran his hands all over her body and kissed her shoulder. My stomach dropped.

April turned to him and propped herself up on her elbow. "I gotta go," she said.

Rog moved in on her, putting his finger in the center of her chest, sucking on his lower lip. He said something in a low voice, and April rolled onto her back. Bright stars swam in my eyes as I stared, believing I would see it all happen again, and again, and again, forever.

But April sat up and started looking around for her dress.

Rog watched with amusement, a very satisfied look on his face, one that I knew well: the look of having fucked himself senseless. But eventually, he also rose, slowly, taking his time, sitting for a while, while April tried and failed to straighten out the twisted mess of her bra. In the end she took it off and stuffed it into her tiny purse.

The bed was rumpled and soiled. Rog downed his whiskey, and April went to the bathroom, so he poured himself another while I seethed at him from behind the door, unable to move.

And then, they were all a quick flurry, Rog's hands occasionally slapping April's ass, and she flipped off the lights, said, "Don't worry, there's a cleaner," to something Rog asked. She deftly reset the alarm, and the door opened, and with the giggle of a remorseless, cheating whore, they slipped into the hallway, and the door closed, and the scene before was dark except for the silver light from the kitchen and its eerie glow on the tile in front of the door.

CHAPTER 18

The phone didn't even ring on my end, so when Lilith answered, her sultry voice ricocheted around in my uncomprehending head.

"You locked yourself in," she had said, a statement of fact with only the hint of a lilt tipping the very end of the sentence up in a casual question, her feelings about it shrouded in her usual blasé, sexual purr.

When I didn't answer, she sighed, but the sound of it revealed that it had left a smiling mouth. In the background, I could hear loud voices echoing in a crowded locale of some kind. My hands moved blindly around on the wall next to the door, as if I could somehow find the magic button and escape and pretend that I had never placed this call. My heart was racing and I could think only of running from here, at which point my imagination diverged: I would either follow them, confront April, watch the shock on her face. Or I would go home, and sit in the darkness, and wait for her to come home, to see if she would lie to me, to plumb the depths of her cheating depravity.

"Thomas?" Lilith asked. She sighed again, before I would have even had a chance not to answer. And then she laughed. The end of the line became muffled, I heard her purring something to a male voice, but I was holding the phone with a hand that was not attached to me. I was not even in this world.

"I'll send right" she said, her words swallowed by a raucous cheer somewhere in the world that she inhabited.

And then she was gone.

I fumbled with the door, my hands going over the same parts of the wall, my eyes unable to see, my brain unable to think about what I was doing and how irrational it was. The phone fell to the floor when my hand gave up on holding it. It was dark, I couldn't see much, I slid my fingers around, looking for a light switch - surely there was one, somewhere.

Panic about being trapped was clawing inside of me, but the real panic that had seized me was a different kind. This had all been a terrible mistake, it had all gotten out of control, and now I was going to die in a closet, dehydrating to death while listlessly pondering the loss of my wife that had been entirely my own fault.

I found the latch by accident, I would never know how much later. It was a tricky switch, so flush with the frame of the door that I had probably passed my fingers over it a million times before I chanced upon the almost undetectable groove between it and the door frame.

The door popped open and I stood up, my head light, fury and jealousy burning a hole through my gut. I started to exit, and then I froze, looking around, wondering if the place needed to be tidied up, wondering why I cared. As I turned slowly in the sex-scented, heavy air, April's pussy mingled with the musky scent of Rog's sweat and cum, I saw the closet door ajar and leaned toward it to push it gently closed.

And then, not knowing what else to do, I shakily exited.

For some reason, I went to the stairs. Perhaps it was because that was how I had come up, and my brain could not divert from that same pathway. The door was swinging open when the elevator dinged, and I cast a look backward as I stepped into the stairwell. It was enough to see her step from the elevator, hair over her face as she bent down to dig into her purse, red dress tight against her skin, her hand to her ear, holding the phone.

I stopped, disbelieving, and the door swung almost closed. I shot my hand out to stop it, my head spinning, a new confusion taking over me, a different hot fury boiling in my chest. I threw it open, and it bounced against the doorstop, threatening to whack me, but a well-designed spring caught it in a slow-motion closure.

I could hear her voice as I approached the corner, hear the clatter of the key fob, the quick succession of beeps as she opened the door. "... called me, I don't know..."

She was inside, the door closing behind her, but I reached the door before it shut. I stepped inside. April was approaching the closet door, still saying something into her phone.

My hand must have gone to my pocket, fished my own phone out, and held it up where I could see it. One missed call. From April. Not even a minute ago.

April had her hand on the wall, but something must have stopped her. The change of light as the door had been pushed open by me; a sound, maybe my breathing. Perhaps I had added an energy to the room that had made her skin tingle. She turned, before opening the door, and jumped, and then brought her hand to her chest.

"Jesus!" she said, in a whisper, looking at me.

I was walking toward her, my phone in my right hand, my face probably twisted in anguish. Sure, somewhere in the back of my mind I was trying to work it all out, and looking back on it, I would think about how obvious it should have been. But jealousy consumed all rational thought, and I was unable to put it together.

"Lilith said you were stuck," April said, pushing on the lever, the door popping open. She looked away from me and inside before she closed it again, and then back at me. Her expression was expectant, not especially shocked by then, as if the only thing that had surprised her was that I was behind her, not that I was there.

Not that I had been in the closet, because she had gone to get me.

And still I couldn't put it together. "What did you do?" I heard myself say, my voice raspy, an anguish I didn't even know I was capable of tightening my throat. The image of her face twisted into screams of pleasure while Rog's hands slid over her sweaty skin, his cock deep inside of her, would not leave my field of vision long enough for me to really see what was before my eyes.

April's face fell, and her mouth opened, the blue of her eyes suddenly dark. The tiniest changes of her features - millimeters that delineated the difference between fun shock, and real fear - overtook her expression, and though it had changed very little in the grand scheme of things, she now looked like I felt. Shocked. Afraid. Horrified.

"Did you...?" April began, and looked at the closet door again, as if the answer would be there. "I thought you were already here," she said, still confused.

"April," I said, still walking toward her.

"Oh no," she said, slightly anguished but more disappointed than anything. She let go of the closet door and pushed it shut. "You were supposed to... be... here..."

I stopped, still for a long moment, heart thumping irregularly in my chest. The ringing sound seemed to at once get louder, and to diminish to nothing.

"What?" I demanded, suddenly, almost like a cough.

"What?" April echoed.

We stared at each other.

"You were supposed to be here," she said. Her hand lifted to point limply at the closet. "With me and... it was a... a... a... Lilith said you would be in the closet."

I said nothing. I couldn't shift my mind to take in what she was saying.

"I just came here with Rog," April said. "You were supposed to be..."

The way answers to puzzles come to you suddenly, and all the time you could not understand them seems instantly like a past that never existed, I understood. The force of it made me lose my balance a little, and I stumbled to one side like a drunk. "This was all..." I said. I moved to the bed just in time to crumple onto it.

"You were supposed to be here," April repeated. "It was Lilith"

"I was here," I interrupted. I was looking at the floor. I looked up at April.

"Wait," she said, her hand pushing back a huge swath of her messy mane. "What?"

"I was here, I was..." I pointed toward the closet.

April looked back at the closet again. "But Lilith said you were in there," she said, confused.

"April, what the hell is happening?" I said, seasick. Some part of me was already relaxing, the muscles that had grown so rigid without me knowing began to soften, but in the forefront of my mind the betrayal I had believed in so deeply was still baring its teeth and growling at me, daring me to confront it, refusing to simply disappear.

"Lilith..." she began, and then a furrow began to form on her brow, and she stopped speaking, at a loss for how to explain what was already dawning on me.

But really, she had said everything that needed to be said.

What happened?

Lilith.

EPILOGUE

I didn't see Lilith again for a long time, but when I caught her eye at a party at her house - a very tame, almost serious get-together with more business-like people than attractive porno types, she met my gaze with a level, neutral expression, as if she had expected me to walk in and look at her at that very moment, and then she winked, leaned on an elbow, and went back to talking to a very young, very tall, dark-haired man.

I took a seat on the porch and bummed a cigarette off Jonny, who also didn't look particularly surprised to see me. He gave me a wry smile and tossed me his lighter.

April was inside, wearing a fetching shade of red, and somewhere in there was Rog, because I had seen him as we had come in. This was months later, because we had decided to take a break after that wild adventure. I had left it up to April what she wanted to tell Rog, but my heart had needed a break from the highs and lows that Lilith had contrived for me, or us, or herself. It was hard to know what Lilith was thinking, what her motivation had been.

People came and went on the patio, Jonny slid an arm around April and gave her a hug, and they embraced more intimately than friends, but she looked over his shoulder and smiled at me, her right eye half-closing in a partial wink. We would see, we had decided, where the evening took us.

Lilith slinked out, a real whopper of a pale pink scrap of clothing clinging to her curves, skin exposed everywhere, the full line of her ribcage to her thigh completely bare, the physics of the dress a complete mystery. When she poured herself into a chair, it folded even more mysteriously and became loose, but the darkness and shape of her hard nipples peeked from under the shimmery, nearly transparent fabric.

"Long time, no see, Thomas," she said, lighting a cigarette. Then she leaned back in her chair, crossed one leg over the other, and grinned at me as I held my gaze rigidly on her face instead of watching the disappearance of panty-less exhibition. "I was worried you were mad at me."

I shook my head and tapped the ash on the cigarette I was holding and not particularly smoking. Lilith grinned. "So. Are you two back in the

game? Or should I tell those young men to hold their stallions?"

I gave her a nothing smile.

"Thomas, please don't tell me you're *mad*," Lilith complained.

"Heh," I said. What was I? I wasn't mad: in the end, I had gotten something I had always wanted, but without having to pay the real price of it. The horrible, sinking hours that I had believed that I was watching my wife have a secret affair with Rog, when I believed that she had become a sex-crazed succubus who craved only huge black men who would manhandle her and fuck her endlessly in the ass, had been a terrifying experience. A sobering experience. And in the end, when we had straightened it all out, and April had explained that Lilith had orchestrated that twisted episode of *Fantasy Island*, I had been overcome with relief.

Relief that it had never *actually* happened the way I had believed. Relief that April was still, in the end, mine. That perhaps she had found a high in debasing, filthy sex, but it was something she could leave behind, to return to me in the end.

Lilith didn't seem bothered by this response. She grinned and smoked her cigarette, drawing the smoke into her nose Bardot-style and then blowing it up toward the roof, watching it drift away. "Well," she said, stubbing out the cigarette in what looked to be an extremely expensive crystal ashtray. "I'll see you around. I guess. But honestly," she leaned forward on both arms, crossing them almost childishly. "Greg is always game for more. It's easy money."

"I'm sure," I said, waving a hand around at Lilith's increasingly tricked-out pad. Landscapers had come and gone, leaving a wake of heavy rocks and sculpted gardens around. The pool, once a dark granite hole, had been fitted with spectacular lighting and looked to have been made bigger.

Lilith shrugged. "A girl has to make a commission," she sighed.

I tipped my head. "That's what I don't get," I found myself saying.

This intrigued her. Maybe not much, but a little. She paused, foot in mid-air, and swung it back around to cross at the ankle. How she managed such a task in the ridiculous shoes she was wearing will forever be a mystery to me. "What's that?" she said, smiling, because she already knew.

"Well... I mean, you seem like you think ahead," I told her. It was a quality I knew she knew I admired about her, and the right corner of her

mouth flicked with humored pleasure. "You had to know that would be the end, or at least a pause, on 'Greg Smith.'"

Lilith tilted her chin. Her infuriating smile screamed, *we'll see*, and the compulsion to slap her tingled in my fingertips. "Thomas," she said, tapping her fingers on her hips and tipping her head. "That's hardly my only commission." Her surliness evaporated immediately, as Lilith's mercurial moods were apt to do, and she shrugged again, cheerfully. "I like it when people get what they want," she chirped.

And it seemed, coming from Lilith, to be as close to something true as I would ever get from her. Her eyes darted to the party inside, and her attention seemed to be swept away, so I was taken off-guard when she turned back to me.

"But seriously. Is April in play or not?"

I shrugged, mimicking her nonchalance with an imitation of her bad schoolgirl routine. I leaned so that I could get a glimpse of April's arm through the party. Lilith watched me, her eyes narrowed in curiosity, which gave me a thrill. After all, capturing Lilith's attention is not the easiest task.

I held up a finger, and craned my neck, and Lilith began to smile, even though she could not have possibly known what I was looking for.

I caught April's eye, and she smiled, and gave me one of her terrible winks.

I set my elbow on the table and encircled my right wrist with my fingers. April tilted her head and looked at whoever she was talking to, then back at me. She lifted her arm to push her mane of hair over her shoulder.

The elaborate bracelet from the mysterious Greg, which we had decided, in the end, to keep, sparkled on her wrist in the light, glittering with debauched promise.

I shifted my eyes back to Lilith, who was looking back and forth between us with something that might be mistaken for pride on her face, but it was a feline, shifting form of pride, as anything was with Lilith.

"Looks like she is," I said.

The tall dark man had come out by then, and Lilith took his lit cigarette from his mouth and smoked it so sexily that I could actually see this guy's dick bounce to life in his jeans without looking away from her. She placed it back between his lips while she blew a gorgeous smoke ring.

"Oh, goody," she said, looking at him.

END